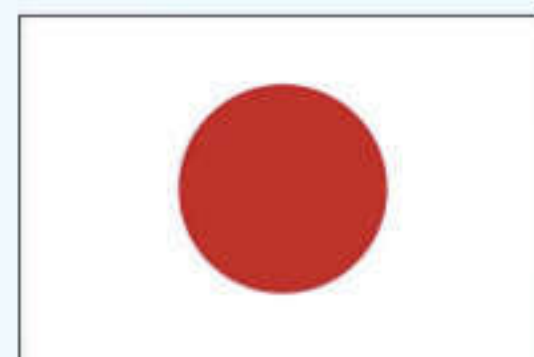




Indian Industry Welcomes

H.E. Ms. Sanae Takaichi
Hon'ble Prime Minister of Japan



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VANCE SAYS NO RETURN TO WAR UNLESS NEEDED

Technical talks kick off; ‘We are getting along well’: Trump

Iran prioritising release of frozen assets, Hormuz remains in focus

Reuters
Washington, Dubai, Doha
July 1

US VICE President JD Vance said discussions between the US and Iran were going well as they held indirect technical talks in Qatar about the Strait of Hormuz on Wednesday, adding Washington would not return to full combat unless necessary.

The talks are based on a 14-point interim accord signed last month that was meant to halt the war that began with US-Israeli strikes on Iran in February and reopen the strait, while setting up 60 days of negotiations for a permanent peace deal.

However, the US and Iran have sparred publicly over the meaning of the interim pact, leading to tit-for-tat military strikes over the past week and leaving little sign of progress on more complex issues, including on Iran's nuclear programme.

Vance said he could not guarantee that Washington would not return to full combat operations ahead of next month's deadline but that for now Presi-



An Ultra-Orthodox Jewish man poses for a photo at a memorial site on the border with Lebanon in northern Israel, on Wednesday. AP

dent Donald Trump had directed officials to make a deal.

"I can't commit to anything, because obviously it depends on what the Iranians are ultimately going to do," he told reporters on a visit to Virginia Beach, Virginia. "What I can commit to is: The president's not going to send our military back in unless he has to, unless there's a clearly defined purpose for it."

In Doha, technical talks were focused on commercial shipping in the strait and would later turn to Tehran's nuclear capabilities, Vance said, adding: "It's still pretty early, but talks are going well."

Iran is determined to win international recognition of its control over the key oil-shipping

waterway and its ability to levy fees on ships entering or leaving the Gulf, even if it has to do so by force, according to two senior Iranian sources. Trump, who has said removing Iran's highly enriched uranium is a top priority, told reporters on Wednesday that "the denuclearization of Iran is moving along well", without giving details.

Asked about the possibility of returning to all-out war with Iran, Trump added: "Well, I think they've come a long way. We hit them very hard last week. I think they're fine."

The indirect talks, mediated by Qatar and Pakistan, began on Tuesday night and were continuing on Wednesday, an Iranian official said.

8 schoolgirls in Kenya charged with murder of 16 classmates

Reuters
Nairobi, July 1

A KENYAN court charged eight schoolgirls on Wednesday with murder for the deaths of 16 of their fellow students in a dormitory fire at a school in Kenya's Rift Valley in late May, the public prosecutor's office said.

The girls died after fire swept through the dormitory at Utumishi Girls' Academy Senior School in Gilgil, Nakuru County, located in Kenya's west-central region, injuring another 79 students. Students at the school are aged from 15 to 18 years.

The eight defendants appeared before Nairobi's Kibera High Court Judge Diana Kavedza and all pleaded not guilty to the charge, the Director of Public Prosecutions said in a statement on its X account.

Prosecutors have so far given no other details on the case. The blaze renewed scrutiny of safety in Kenyan boarding schools and recurring student unrest in the education system.

Fires are common at Kenyan schools, with many set by students protesting against harsh discipline and poor conditions, researchers have found. Kenya has suffered several deadly school fires. In 2024, a fire at Hillside Endarasha Academy in Nyeri County killed 21 children.

Education Minister Julius Ogamba said in May that unrest since the incident had caused the temporary closure of at least 204 senior schools across the country.

At least \$2bn: Trump reaped a windfall in his first year back in White House

Ben Protess, Andrea Fuller, Eric Lipton & David Yaffe-Bellany
Washington, July 1

ALL TOLD, the president pulled in at least \$2.2 billion, a figure that includes other parts of his vast holdings, such as his real estate assets. That compares with a minimum of \$622 million his enterprises pulled in for all of 2024, before he returned to the presidency.

One of his biggest hauls in 2025 came when an investment firm tied to the United Arab Emirates bought nearly half of the Trump family's main crypto company, World Liberty Financial, a transaction that blurred the line between foreign policy and private enterprise.

Trump also collected hundreds of millions of dollars from sales of his \$TRUMP memecoin and World Liberty's sale of its own digital tokens.

The results, detailed in Trump's mandatory financial disclosure report for 2025 and released Tuesday, pulled back the curtain on the president's business operations. His crypto ventures, the report shows, are now some of his most lucrative enterprises, a remarkable turn-about for a man who once



slammed crypto as a haven for drug dealers and scammers.

The president's finances, which had been something of a mystery, highlight a conflict in his crypto business: Trump is a major crypto industry operator

and its top policymaker.

It is hardly the only issue to arise from having a businessperson serve as president. The president's family business, Trump Organization, has also capitalized on Trump's popu-

Never before in presidential history: Experts

Eric Lipton
Washington, July 1

PRESIDENT LYNDON Johnson's wife owned a profitable radio station. George W Bush was on the board of an oil company while his father was in the White House. And Hunter Biden was paid by a Ukrainian natural gas company while his father was vice president.

But never before in American history has there been anything like Donald Trump, a president who in his first year back in office has collected about \$1.4 billion in new revenue from cryptocurrency businesses that directly benefited from his actions as president, a financial disclosure report made public Tuesday shows.

"It is completely unprece-

ented," said Megan Gorman, a tax attorney and the author of a recent book, "All the Presidents' Money," that studied the history of presidential wealth dating back 250 years.

Generally, throughout history, Gorman and other historians said, American presidents have taken actions to try to separate themselves from corporate entanglements that might create conflicts. "Public office, if anything, was a source of debt, not a source of revenue," said Lindsay Chervinsky, a historian and the executive director of the George Washington Presidential Library at Mount Vernon.

Trump and his family have done the opposite, creating new business ventures that are prof-

iting from actions Trump has taken since he returned to the White House. Those include the pardon Trump issued in October to Changpeng Zhao, the richest man in crypto, who founded the company Binance, which has

been a critical business partner to the Trump family's own crypto venture.

They include legislation that Trump signed last July to promote a form of cryptocurrency called Stablecoins, four months after his family-backed firm introduced its own Stablecoin. The White House and Trump family have repeatedly dismissed any questions about the president's moneymaking while in office, arguing that Trump's two oldest sons, Eric Trump and Donald

"I don't get involved ... we have funds that run my money. You know why I'm profiting? Because the stock market's going up, everybody's profiting"

DONALD TRUMP, U.S. PRESIDENT

larity in certain parts of the world, licensing the Trump name to properties in countries that are crucial to US foreign policy interests, including Saudi Arabia and Qatar.

Those two deals alone generated more than \$14 million for Trump last year, the filing shows.

The White House did not immediately respond to a request for comment, though in the past, Trump has noted that he is exempt from federal conflict of interest laws. Anna Kelly, a White House spokesperson, said in a recent statement that Trump "only acts in the best interests of the American public," and that "there are no conflicts of interest." NYT

Russia approved 'secret China military training'

Reuters
July 1

CHINA'S COVERT military training of Russian forces last year was personally approved by President Vladimir Putin's defence minister and directly involved at least four Russian and Chinese generals, according to two European officials and documents seen by Reuters.

The officials said the involvement of such high-ranking individuals in training linked to the Ukraine war signalled the im-

portance for Russia and China of such cooperation, which has caused alarm in Europe even as Beijing has denied it took place.

A classified Russian document seen by Reuters directly referred to an internal decree issued by Defence Minister Andrei Belousov in August, 2025.

It said that, in accordance with a decision by Belousov, a delegation from Russia's armed forces travelled to China to participate in training exercises at People's Liberation Army (PLA) facilities.

The same report detailed one of the training courses - a three-week session focused on radiological, chemical and biological protection at a military facility in Beijing in November.

The report and a second one described and displayed images of Russian soldiers being lectured by a Chinese instructor, looking at a model nuclear reactor, and being taught about "chemical reconnaissance", "radiation reconnaissance" and protecting ventilation systems from contamination.

The inclusion of radiological, biological and chemical warfare training underlined the strategic nature of the exchanges, one of the European officials said, noting that the topic was particularly sensitive for militaries in general.

The defence ministries of Russia and China did not respond to requests for comment for this article.

China's foreign ministry said in a statement that its stance on the Ukraine crisis had remained consistent.

One US soldier missing after chopper crashes in Arabian Sea

Washington: One US service member was missing and three others were wounded but in stable condition after their MH-60S Seahawk helicopter made an emergency landing in the Arabian Sea Wednesday, US military said, adding there was no indication the crash was caused by hostile action.

"US Navy assets in the region are currently searching for other aircrewman still missing. The cause of incident is under investigation," the US Navy's 5th Fleet said in a statement, adding the helicopter was deployed to the region on the USS George HW Bush aircraft carrier.

Helicopter water landings can be dangerous given the propensity of top-heavy aircraft to flip upside-down. REUTERS

Unchecked AI progress may pose catastrophic risks, warns UN panel

Reuters
Geneva, July 1

DEVELOPMENTS in artificial intelligence are outpacing scientific understanding and government policy, meaning there are no guarantees technology will not cause catastrophic harm, a United Nations independent panel warned on Wednesday.

A preliminary report by the UN's Independent International Scientific Panel on Artificial Intelligence said policymakers face a growing dilemma: they need robust evidence to regulate AI effectively, yet such evidence is struggling to keep pace with technology's rapid evolution.

"AI capabilities are outpacing both scientific understanding and governments' ability to adapt," said Yoshua Bengio, co-chair of the panel, comprised of 40 cross-regional experts.

“With growing evidence of deceptive AI behaviour, science currently cannot guarantee that as capabilities continue to increase, AI will not cause catastrophic harm”

YOSHUA BENGIO, CO-CHAIR

"With growing evidence of deceptive AI behaviour, science currently cannot guarantee that as capabilities continue to increase, AI will not cause catastrophic harm, either on its own or due to malicious users."

Described as the first global

independent assessment of AI's risks and opportunities, the report aims to give up-to-date evaluations of the science to help guide decision-making as governments contend with fast-evolving systems.

In the near term, it expects a shift towards agentic AI systems capable of carrying out real-world tasks, although growth may be constrained by energy and high-quality data shortages.

Over time, it foresees self-improving AI embedded more deeply in the economy and converging with technologies such as quantum computing and biotechnology. AI already demonstrates expert-level reasoning in mathematics and science and is accelerating drug and vaccine development, potentially allowing systems to complete work that takes humans days or weeks, according to the report.



Court Couture

Naomi Osaka of Japan walks into the court to play against Elsa Jacquemot of France in their first round women's singles match at the Wimbledon Tennis Championships in London. AP

● AVI LOEB, A COSMOLOGIST WHO STUDIED BLACK HOLES AND SERVED AS HEAD OF HARVARD'S ASTRONOMY DEPARTMENT, WAS RECENTLY APPOINTED TO LEAD A SCIENTIFIC ADVISORY COUNCIL INVESTIGATING MYSTERIOUS ORBS

Harvard professor with polarising alien theories to lead new White House UFO council

Collin Binkley
Washington, July 1

A POLARIZING Harvard astronomer known for splashy theories about alien visits has been tapped by the White House to lead a team of outside scientists to study the national security risks posed by UFOs.

Avi Loeb, a cosmologist who studied black holes and served as head of Harvard's astronomy department until 2020, was recently appointed to helm a new scientific advisory council tasked with investigating the origins of mysterious orbs and other objects reported by military personnel in recent years. It's part of President Donald

Trump's push to declassify more information about the issue. Loeb's team will report to a new White House panel focused on UFOs, now often referred to as unidentified anomalous phenomena, or UAP.

"It's like a detective story," Loeb said in an interview. "It's a lot of fun, as long as you don't pay too much attention to the critics."

For the last decade, Loeb has been scanning the skies and seas for evidence of intelligent alien life. He began the quest in 2017 as scientists puzzled over an interstellar object soaring by Earth.

While others proposed it was a comet or ice chunk, Loeb said it could be a thin "light sail" de-

tached from an alien spacecraft.

His theories have won praise in UFO circles but often put him in conflict with academic peers. Other astronomers accuse him of making exotic claims with little evidence. Some chafe at his habit of skipping the peer review process and bringing claims directly to the public.

Steve Desch, an Arizona State University astrophysicist who has challenged some of Loeb's theories, said Loeb uses flawed methods to reach wild conclusions about alien life — all while shunning a more established branch of science searching for life beyond Earth. Loeb's role on the White



Harvard physicist Avi Loeb (left) at a press conference in New York on April 12, 2016. AP

House panel casts doubt on the entire endeavor, Desch said.

"I don't know what's going to come of this, but we're not

going to get any closer to answering these questions with him in charge," Desch said.

Loeb brushes his critics

aside, saying they lack the imagination to consider new ideas. He's promising a grounded approach to his work for the White House. As he analyzes UAP, he's starting with the assumption that they're the work of humans, he said, approaching it from a national security perspective.

Nonetheless, he envisions an outcome where his work could lead to something bigger. If the government invests in better data collection on UAPs, Loeb said, it could settle the alien debate once and for all.

His hand-picked team includes more than a dozen scientists and UFO activists. Among them is Timothy Gal-

laudet, a retired rear admiral who has warned about UAP controlled by "nonhuman intelligence," claiming the United States has recovered crashed aircraft. Also on the team is Ben Lamm, a billionaire working to revive extinct species.

After its first meeting last month, the team sent a request to the Pentagon asking for more than 50 videos, images and other documents related to known UAP incidents. Loeb's group meets behind closed doors, but he has vowed to brief the public and create a website to share findings.

"At a time when science is not so much celebrated, this is an opportunity to actually do

good for all sides involved," Loeb said.

Earlier this year, Trump directed his administration to provide more transparency on questions of UFOs and alien life. So far, the Pentagon has released three batches of files ranging from decades-old FBI reports to more recent military videos showing orbs darting or soaring through the sky.

Trump's directive led to the creation of a UAP Governance Board overseen by the Office of the Director of National Intelligence. The board met for the first time in June, and is supported by Loeb's team and several other advisory groups, the office said. AP



THURSDAY, JULY 2, 2026



The Indian EXPRESS

JOURNALISM of COURAGE

NEW DELHI, LATE CITY, 22 PAGES

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Happening today

● **THE FIRST** batch of pilgrims for the annual Amarnath Yatra will be flagged off from the Bhagwati Nagar base camp by J&K Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha as offline registration commenced Wednesday.

● **A 10-MEMBER** delegation of rebel TMC faction, led by Ritabrata Banerjee, will meet the full bench of the Election Commission amid an intensifying battle over the ownership of the party, funds and its twin-flower symbol.

● **RISING STARS** Gurnoor Brar and Manav Suthar are expected to get a look-in in the India A playing eleven when they take on Sri Lanka A in the second Test.

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GOVT NOTIFIES MEASURES: NON-BS VI VEHICLES REGISTERED OUTSIDE DELHI TO BE BARRED

Vehicle, construction curbs, WFH: Delhi moves to combat winter haze

Restrictions to be mandatory from Nov 1 to Feb 28, will operate with GRAP

Sophiya Mathew & Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 1

IN A move to combat air pollution during the winter months, the Delhi government has notified a series of restrictions that will come into force from No-

vember 1 to February 28 every year — from curbs on vehicles and construction activities, to staggered office timings and work from home.

Until now, the practice was to impose various stages of the Graded Response Action Plan (GRAP), depending on the air quality index (AQI), during these months. The implementation of GRAP — a framework mechanism under which the governments in Delhi and the National Capital Region (NCR) must take specific sets of actions — is overseen by the Commission for Air Quality Man-

agement (CAQM).

But with the new restrictions, notified on June 23 and made public on Wednesday, many of the measures will mandatorily come into force during this period. These restrictions are set to operate alongside GRAP.

This could tackle two key concerns. The move seeks to reduce disruptions to workplaces, educational institutions and transport through advance planning while addressing long-standing criticism that pollution-control restrictions

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● KEY MEASURES

FUEL ONLY to vehicles with valid PUC through the year.

ENTRY OF non-Delhi registered vehicles below BS-VI barred from Nov 1-Jan 31.

50% PHYSICAL attendance in govt, pvt offices from Nov 1-Jan 31.

BAN ON most demolition, dust-generating construction work from Nov 1-Jan 31.

COMPLETE BAN on construction, demolition from Dec 10-Jan 20, barring urgent govt projects.



ANTI-SMOG guns/mist systems mandatory for commercial buildings exceeding 3,000 sq m.

RWAs, HOUSING societies, institutions, contractors responsible for preventing open burning of waste, leaves, biomass and garbage.

NEED OF THE HOUR: REKHA GUPTA

Delhi CM offers: Can cut House term for simultaneous polls

Parliamentary panel on ONOE Bills also meets Speaker and Lt Governor



P P Chaudhary, chairperson of Parliamentary panel on joint polls, with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta in New Delhi, Wednesday. ANI

Damini Nath & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 1

DESCRIBING THE concept of One Nation One Election as “the need of the hour”, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta Wednesday told the Joint Committee of Parliament on Bills relating to simultaneous elections that her government would be willing to consider adjusting the tenure of the Delhi Assembly to align with that of the Lok Sabha. She pointed to cutting short the Assembly’s term which currently ends eight months after that of Lok Sabha.

The committee, chaired by

BJP MP P P Chaudhary, conducted a study visit in the Capital, meeting the Chief Minister at the Delhi Secretariat, Speaker Vijender Gupta and representatives of parties at the Assembly and Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu at Lok Niwas.

In a statement, the Chief Minister’s Office said: “Referring to Delhi, she (Gupta) pointed out that elections in the national Capital are held roughly a year apart from the Lok Sabha elections. If aligning election schedules at the national level requires a suitable

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AHEAD OF MONSOON SESSION

Bill clause for removal of ministers in custody for 30 days likely to be retained in panel report

Opp members of panel expected to submit dissent note on report

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 1

THE JOINT Committee of Parliament, examining the 130th Constitution Amendment Bill that seeks to remove ministers detained for serious offences for 30 consecutive days, is expected

to adopt its report on July 17. A House panel adopting a report is a routine procedure before a Bill is tabled in Parliament.

While the report is likely to retain the contentious clause that proposes the automatic removal of the Prime Minister, Chief Ministers, or other ministers from office if they are arrested and detained in custody for 30 consecutive days for serious offences, there could be notes of caution to ensure that the law is not misused for political vendetta, sources said.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

‘Put family above fear’: A year after being pushed into Bangladesh and brought back, they seek to rebuild lives

Most of them have shifted to Mumbai after failing to make ends meet in West Bengal

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, July 1

“SONSAR DEKHBO na bhoj? Sonsar dekhilam (Should I put my family first, or my fear? I chose family).”

It has been one year since Mehabub Sheikh, who belongs to Bhagabangola in Murshidabad, was picked up from Mumbai, kept in detention for days, taken to West Bengal, pushed across the border to Bangladesh and, within days, brought back.

The 37-year-old is back in Mumbai now, working as a construction worker. “I fear I may be picked up again and thrown out. But I have to support my wife and two sons, pay their school fees.”

Minarul Sheikh, 30, of Bel-danga in Murshidabad, was among the group of seven including Mehabub who were detained from Mumbai in June



(Clockwise from left) Mostafa Kamal Sheikh, Shamim Khan and Mehabub Sheikh were among the group of seven picked up in Mumbai and pushed into Bangladesh. EXPRESS

last year, pushed into Bangladesh and brought back after the Centre and BSF conceded they were Indians and held a flag meeting with their Bangladeshi counterparts. This was before the start of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in the state, which all of them later cleared.

Minarul, who procures hair to sell to the wig-making industry, has moved shop to Kashmir. The chances of being singled out in the high-security Valley

are even higher, and a nervous Minarul refuses to give his exact location. But, he must live with the risk, he adds. “After we were brought back, we received no help from the government. On the other hand, the people who owed me money took advantage of what had happened and refused to pay me, though I had to sell my family’s 1 bigha land to repay loans I had. Now I am in Kashmir to restart my life.”

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

ON THREE-DAY INDIA VISIT, WILL HOLD TALKS WITH MODI TODAY



Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi arrives in New Delhi, Wednesday. @TAKAICHI, SANAE/X

Tokyo, Delhi to deepen strategic ties, Takaichi flags global uncertainty

Chips, rare earth, supply chains on table; large Japan business delegation too here

Divya A
New Delhi, July 1

UNDERLINING THAT she intends to deepen her country’s strategic ties with India in this time of “growing uncertainty in the international situation”, Japan’s Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi reached New Delhi Wednesday evening on a three-day visit, her first to India after entering office last year.

Soon after Takaichi’s arrival, Prime Minister Narendra Modi,

in a post on X, said, “We are delighted to host you on your first visit to India and I look forward to our wide-ranging discussions tomorrow that will further deepen the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership.”

“Through our joint efforts, we will continue to advance peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond,” Modi said.

Received at Delhi airport by

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

E. EXPLAINED

Special partnership

India and Japan upgraded their ties to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014. During PM Narendra Modi’s visit to Japan last year, the two sides had charted a roadmap for the next decade, raising the Japanese investment target in India to 10 trillion yen, launching initiatives on economic security cooperation, digital partnership & AI.

INSIDE PAGES 4,7



GYMKHANA CLUB GETS EVICTION NOTICE, HEARING ON JULY 7

CENTRE ROLLS OUT RURAL JOBS SCHEME IN NEW AVATAR, NOTIFIES WAGE RATES

Ayodhya row heats up, UP weighs option to send probe to Central agency

State SIT given time until July 15 to wrap up probe

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, July 1

AMID THE clamour for a speedy probe into the alleged theft and embezzlement of



A few items belonging to accused Avinash Shukla left behind at a yoga centre in Ayodhya, Wednesday. ANI

funds and valuables donated to the Ram temple in Ayodhya, the Uttar Pradesh government is actively considering the option of turning over the investigation of the case to the CBI or another Central agency, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Sources said since the matter constitutes an economic offence which requires deep investigation, the option

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Business as Usual

By EP UNNY

Our US-born grandchildren will now earn enough to finance our pursuit of Indian citizenship.



ISSUES NOTICE, GIVES COMPANY THREE DAYS TO RESPOND

Impersonation concerns, don’t roll out ‘username’ feature: Govt to WhatsApp

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, July 1

THE GOVERNMENT has issued a notice to Meta-owned WhatsApp on the planned roll-out of the messaging service’s ‘username’ feature over concerns of impersonation and fraud and directed the company not to roll it out until a thorough

consultation on the subject, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

Earlier this week, WhatsApp announced it would gradually allow users to select a username and hide their phone numbers when contacting another user for the first time. It is an optional unique identifier a user can choose for her WhatsApp account. It can also

be used by others to message or call her, while keeping the phone number private.

Senior government officials said the Union Ministry of Home Affairs raised concerns with the Ministry of Electronics and IT. They said the government would undertake a risk assessment of the new feature.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● MBAPPE SCORES TWICE AS FRANCE BEAT SWEDEN 3-0 TO REACH FINAL 16

French strikers ruled the field, but Deschamps was man of the evening



Sandip G
New Jersey, July 1

A BANNER with flowers embroidered on its side greeted France manager Didier Deschamps, returning from his mother’s death, into the MetLife Arena. The message was simple but touching: “Didier, we are with you.” The emcee stopped

the hip-hop music. The players performed their warm-up drills with an unusual sombreness. After the national anthem was rendered, the French fans chorused: “C’est vous, Didi!” You are the man.

The understated French manager would be the man of the evening, although Kylian Mbappe nailed two goals of artful precision, Bradley Barcola exhibited his velvet feet with a goal cut from silk, and his flying Les Bleus eviscerated Sweden’s iron-willed defence, winning the Round of 32 match 3-0. The signs are ominous for teams destined to stumble into them,

shepherded by a manager who walks without aura or vanity.

The arena was so emotionally charged that Deschamps eventually broke down. He shed a tear when he staggered to the tunnel. Mbappe, putting France ahead, turned back and ran towards his manager, yelling and pointing his index finger, “C’est pour vous (It is for you)”. Sweating profusely in New Jersey, he tightly hugged Deschamps, who whispered a thanks in his ear and clung onto him. The French players joined them, and embraced their manager. He turned back, and the cam-



Kylian Mbappe celebrates with coach Didier Deschamps during the Round of 32 match against Sweden. AP

eras soaked his eyes that had turned red.

Mbappe considers him a father figure, an unwavering pillar of support during his lean days. He handed him the leap of faith debut in the tournament against Argentina in 2018; he spent months consoling him after the heartbreak of Qatar in 2022 and the European Championship in between; he defended him when rumours of a rift swirled in the dressing room.

“Kylian — whether you like him or not — the youngsters love him. You have the image of a selfish, individualistic guy, and

of course, a striker must also be selfish, but I can assure you that in the French national team, he acts like a captain,” he defended him last year. Most of all, no manager has harnessed his gifts as much as Deschamps has.

Mbappe loves him back too. “He is my comfort zone. He brings a lot of calm into the dressing room, never loses his cool, and gives us the liberty to play in our way. It’s a misconception that he is a defensive coach,” he said during the Nations League in February.

That label no longer fits. Deschamps has pragmatic traits, a spillage of virtues from his days

as a grim defensive midfielder. The condescending nickname still lingers: the water carrier. But a number from the 1998 World Cup is often forgotten: That no one made as many touches as Deschamps in the entire tournament. He was the team’s backbone, if Zinedine Zidane was its brain. He never won his dues as a player; as a manager it’s time he should. He is a World Cup winner (as player and coach), a finalist in another World Cup and European Championship. Yet, he goes uncelebrated. Maybe, it is what he wants, existing in the shadows.

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



Birthday bash

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav celebrates his 53rd birthday at the party office in Lucknow on Wednesday. Party workers also unveiled a poster that portrayed the SP chief as Lord Krishna. PTI

‘Not consulted about MSC-Adani Vizhinjam stake deal’: Kerala CM flags security concerns

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 1

THE KERALA government has said it was not consulted about global shipping conglomerate Mediterranean Shipping Company (MSC) acquiring a 49% stake in Adani Vizhinjam Ports Pvt Ltd (AVPPL), the concessionaire responsible for building, financing and operating the Vizhinjam International Container Transshipment Port for 40 years under the public-private partnership (PPP) model.

On Tuesday, Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Limited had announced that the MSC's terminal wing Terminal Investment Ltd (TIL) had taken 49% stake, which is worth Rs 13,000 crore, in the AVPPL. This has been billed as the single largest foreign private investment in Indian port infrastructure.

Chief Minister V D Satheesan Wednesday told the Assembly that the state was not informed about the deal. "Adani Group did not have any communication with the state government. As per the concession agreement, the concessionaire should not effect any change in ownership of the port without prior approval from the authority, which is the state government. Selling 49% stake means there is ownership change, which is not possible without the consent from the state government," he said.

He said the MSC is not a mere investor and the state government will examine how the investment is going to impact the port operations. "Since the port is critical infrastructure, national security is a matter of concern. The deal will be allowed only after protecting the interest of the state and safeguarding the public interest. There should be space for fair competition and we have to ensure that the deal does not lead to monopoly of a particular company in the port. There should be a competitive user facility where all stakeholders will

be able to do business without any discrimination."

Sharing the same sentiments, Opposition leader and CPI(M) politburo member Pinarayi Vijayan flagged that Adani can sell the share in the port only with the consent of the state government. "The news about selling of the share up to 49% is a matter of grave concern. When the shipping firm MSC and Adani group join hands, there is a danger of monopoly. That will be against the commercial interest of the state and port's development. When one particular firm gains monopoly at the port, all others will have to go by their conditions. This will lead to financial anomalies and eliminate the situation in which the port should grow into a multi-operator venture," Vijayan said.

The Vizhinjam port, India's first deep water container transshipment port, became operational in July 2024. Its commercial operations began in December that year. The port has emerged as a major destination for the world's largest container ships. Over 1,000 ships had been berthed at the port in the last two years. The first phase of Rs 8,860-crore transshipment deepwater multipurpose seaport project is being executed by Adani Ports and SEZ Pvt Ltd on a design, build, finance, operate and transfer (DBFOT) model.

Of the total investment, Adani Group would invest Rs 2,454 crore and another Rs 1,635 crore would be mobilised from the state government and Central as viability gap funding. The Kerala government also gave 500 acres of land. The DBFOT deal is for 40 years, with provisions extending for 20 years. The state government runs the Vizhinjam International Seaport Limited (VISL), a special-purpose firm fully owned by the Government. AVPPL is the private concessionaire (a subsidiary of Adani Ports & SEZ) responsible for building, financing, and operating the port.

Uttarakhand replaces state Madrasa Board with common minority education authority

Aiswarya Raj
Dehradun, July 1

UTTARAKHAND ON Wednesday became the first state in the country to abolish its statutory Madrasa Board, replacing it with a Minority Education Authority that will regulate educational institutions run by all six notified minority communities.

Under the new arrangement, educational institutions of all six notified minority communities, Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Parsis, Jains, and Buddhists, would come under the category of minority educational institutions. The Uttarakhand State Authority for Minority Education (USAME), established under the Minority Education Act, 2025, was inaugurated by Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, Wednesday.

Prior to this, madrasas were governed by the Madrasa Education Board Act, 2016, and the Uttarakhand Non-Government Arabic and Persian Madrasa Recognition Rules, 2019. This legislation stands repealed, as of Wednesday and has been replaced by the Minority Education Act, 2025, and Uttarakhand Minority Educational Institutions Recognition Rules 2026. The state currently has 452 registered madrasas, which were previously recognised by the

Madrasa Board. The Act was passed in August 2025 after the government's crackdown on madrasas for allegedly failing to seek recognition from the government. The government had sealed over 200 madrasas, after which a special committee was formed to draft an act to overhaul the educational system.

The CM on Wednesday distributed recognition certificates to minority educational institutions and presented National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT) textbooks to students of minority schools, saying that the initiative towards quality and modern education would provide a strong foundation for their future.

The newly instituted Authority has 12 members, including professors of economics, psychology, law, and a retired English teacher from Kumaun University, to design an academic curriculum for the students in the minority institutions. Two social workers and the Director of Higher Education, the Director of the State Council of Educational Research, and the Director of Minority Welfare are also members of the Authority. The move came after over a year following the implementation of the Uniform Civil Code.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Delhi pollution

under GRAP are largely reactive as they are implemented as air quality deteriorates.

The notification said the framework was based on an analysis of air quality trends over the past three winter seasons, which showed that Delhi's air quality consistently deteriorated between November 1 and February 15. During these months in 2023-24, 2024-25, and 2025-26, the city's median AQI ranged between 312 and 342 ('very poor'), while the peak AQI ranged between 461 and 494 ('severe+').

According to the new restrictions, motor vehicles registered outside Delhi and below BS-VI emission standards will not be allowed to ply in the national capital from November 1 to January 31 every year. This will not apply to CNG and EVs, emergency services such as ambulances, fire tenders and police vehicles, and other categories specifically exempted by the environment department.

"All motor vehicles registered outside the National Capital Ter-Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0f>

ritory of Delhi and below BS-VI emission standards shall not be permitted to ply in Delhi," says the notification. All petrol, diesel and CNG/LPG retail outlets across Delhi will supply fuel only on production of a valid PUC throughout the year.

To discourage the use of private vehicles, parking charges at authorised parking sites will be doubled from November 1 to February 28. Parking facilities owned and managed by DMRC have been exempted.

Measures such as staggered office timings and work from home have also been taken to reduce traffic congestion. From November 1 to February 28, offices under the MCD will function from 8.30 am to 5 pm, while Delhi government offices will operate from 10 am to 6.30 pm.

From November 1 to January 31, Delhi government and private offices will function with no more than 50% physical staff attendance, while the remaining employees will work from home. Essential and emergency ser-

vices, including hospitals, public transport, power, water supply, sanitation, disaster management and pollution-control agencies, have been exempted.

"All private entities are to... implement staggered working hours, ensure strict compliance with work-from-home norms, minimise vehicular movement associated with office commute by using methods like car-pooling, ride-sharing, common bus, promoting public transport etc," says the notification.

Also, from November 1 to January 31, there will be a ban on dust-generating demolition and open civil construction activities, except for essential public infrastructure projects. A complete ban on construction and demolition activities, barring urgent government projects and emergency works, will remain in force from December 10 to January 20.

During the same period, vehicles carrying construction material such as sand, stone, bricks, cement and debris will not be allowed to enter Delhi, except those engaged in projects of national importance, essential public infrastructure, emerg-

speaking at the Idea Exchange programme of *The Indian Express* recently, that if some states want, they can curtail the terms of their Assemblies to align with the 2029 elections too.

According to the CMO statement, the CM said One Nation One Election was the need of the hour. A statement from Assembly Secretariat said Speaker Vijender Gupta made suggestions to the committee during their meeting, including conducting a "comprehensive examination of issues relating to the synchronisation of electoral cycles, constructive votes of no-confi-

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/free+2RvD_RGf9mJmZg1

ency works and other exempted categories. The notification also mandates anti-smog guns or mist systems for large commercial buildings and construction sites above specified sizes.

To tackle open burning, the notification makes RWAs, housing societies, institutions, contractors and establishments responsible for preventing burning of waste, biomass, leaves, garbage and plastic within areas under their control.

Typically, under GRAP Stage I, when AQI ranges between 201-300, measures taken include intensified enforcement of dust-control measures and stricter checks on vehicular emissions.

Stage II (AQI 301-400) adds restrictions on diesel generators and increases road sweeping and water sprinkling. Stage III (AQI 401-450) bans non-essential construction and demolition activities and restricts plying of certain categories of vehicles. Stage IV (AQI above 450) brings the strictest curbs, including a ban on truck entry except essential services, school closure and suspension of non-essential construction.

dence, premature dissolution of legislatures, harmonisation of electoral rolls, strengthening the logistical preparedness of the Election Commission, and institutional mechanisms to ensure political stability while preserving India's democratic and federal character." It is learnt that during the meeting with the Speaker and MLAs, it was suggested to create a national forum with representation from each Legislative Assembly to discuss the way forward and the need to extend the provisions of One Nation One Election to RS and municipal body polls.

Ayodhya

of handing over the case to the CBI or another Central agency is being looked at.

The state SIT, which submitted a preliminary report on its findings, was Wednesday granted time until July 15 to complete its probe. It will be re-visiting Ayodhya Thursday to conduct further inquiries.

Sources said a parallel probe by the Ayodhya police has only uncovered cash allegedly stolen in recent months – eight persons have been arrested and are currently in judicial custody – and an extensive investigation is required to trace movable and immovable assets acquired by the accused who were involved in the work of counting cash and

‘Put family above fear’

While his name cleared the SIR without any hiccup, all five of his brothers were called for hearings before inclusion in the voting list. His brother Moijul, who works as a migrant worker in Assam, says over the phone that they urged him to stay at home, particularly because his business ran aground after he was branded a Bangladeshi, but he left.

Besides Mehbub and Minarul, the seven deported and brought back included Nazimuddin Sheikh and Shamim Khan of Hariharpara in Murshidabad, Mostafa Kamal Sheikh of Monteshwar, Purba Bardhaman, and Fazer Sheikh and his wife Taslima, of Bagda in North 24 Parganas.

The Indian Express also tracked down Shamim and Mostafa. Like Mehbub, both are back in Mumbai, after having tried and failed to make ends meet in Bengal.

The earlier Trinamool Congress government promised them all the help needed when they were brought back, seeking to put the BJP-led Centre in a spot. But, Mehbub says, little actually transpired. "I was felicitated by local TMC leaders. Some also promised jobs. But nothing happened. I tried to get work in Bengal, but the daily wage was Rs 650 and that too was not certain."

When the Bengal Assembly elections brought the BJP to power in Bengal, Mehbub decided to head again for Mumbai. Claiming he had to re-make his documents as they were destroyed during his detention, Mehbub says that, to his relief, all his family cleared the SIR. "I also have a police certificate verifying that I am a resident of Murshidabad."

All this gives him confidence that Mumbai is "safe" for him. "Here, I earn at least Rs 35,000-45,000 a month."

Japan

Minister of State Jitendra Singh, Takaichi said, "In discussions with PM Modi, centering on urgent issues including economic security and energy security, we will aim to deepen the strategic cooperative relationship between Japan and India in light of the current international situation, promote mutually complementary cooperation, and further strengthen the Japan-India 'Special Strategic Global Partnership'."

With economic security as the overarching theme, Takaichi's visit is expected to boost investment and innovation opportunities, and help build resilient supply chains in areas such as semiconductors and critical minerals.

According to the MEA, Takaichi will take part in the 16th India-Japan Annual Summit, a mechanism established in 2006 under which the PMs of the two countries meet annually.

Japan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs said the visit will "strengthen relations with India, which is of utmost importance for the realisation of a Free and Open Indo-Pacific". Delhi and Tokyo share a deep strategic convergence on a free and open Indo-Pacific, driven by mutual interests amid China's growing assertions in the region.

At an informal press conference in Tokyo before leaving for Delhi, Takaichi said she intends to "advance concrete cooperation" with Modi.

"At a time when the international situation is becoming increasingly uncertain, cooperation with India, which shares fundamental values and strategic interests with Japan, is becoming more important than

valuable.

Ever since it submitted its preliminary report to the office of the Chief Minister on June 23, the SIT has not visited Ayodhya and the local police, which registered an FIR on June 25, have conducted searches in Ayodhya and adjoining districts like Pratapgarh, Gonda and Basti. Police have so far recovered Rs 79.80 lakh from the eight accused.

The SIT, sources said, has already questioned all trustees of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust including top office-bearers Champat Rai, Anil Mishra and Gopal Rao. Details obtained from the trustees, sources said, were related to their role and involvement in the management of the cash and valuables dropped by devotees in the temple's donation boxes. Sources said the trustees

ever," she said, according to the Japanese PMO.

"Through this visit, I hope to advance concrete cooperation with Prime Minister Modi in three key areas: deepening the Japan-India strategic partnership in light of the current international situation; promoting cooperation in economic security; and strengthening collaboration between businesses of our two countries in investment and innovation," she said.

Diplomatic sources said the focus during Takaichi's visit will also be on boosting maritime security, defence technology cooperation, and developing an 'Industrial Value Chain' connecting the Bay of Bengal with North-East India.

India and Japan are also expected to make progress on energy security and in tackling supply chain disruptions in the wake of the West Asia crisis.

The summit follows Modi's visit to Tokyo in August 2025 for the 15th edition, during which the two countries reaffirmed their commitment to deepen cooperation across strategic, economic, technological and security domains.

A large business delegation is accompanying Takaichi, and the two PMs will also attend business events with executives from both countries. According to government statistics, around 1,400 Japanese companies operate in India, with nearly half of them in manufacturing sector.

A Japan-India Economic Forum is also scheduled after delegation-level talks Thursday, with the participation of more than 150 individuals from Japan's business community. "Working together with the private sector, I hope to broaden the scope of Japan-India cooperation and realize a strong economy," Takaichi said.

were the first to be questioned to understand the daily functioning. At least 20-25 staff members handled the donation boxes, carrying them from the visitor gallery to the hall where the counting work was done under the supervision of Subhash Srivastav and Ramshankar Yadav alias Tinnu while the process was executed by Lavkush Mishra, Anukalp Mishra, Ramashankar Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav and Karunesh Pandey – all were arrested after the FIR on June 25. The SIT had questioned them between June 16 and 21.

The next to be questioned will be the first-rung staff including supervisors of the Sainik Security Services, hired by the SBI for security and manpower to manage the counting of donated money and its dispatch to the bank branch.

ities, so that our youths do not have to migrate."

Mostafa says the deportation episode is vivid in his mind. "We were taken from one police station to another in Mumbai for three days, before finally being handed over to the BSF in Pune. We were not allowed to keep our cellphones, keys to our rooms, or any belongings. From Pune, around 130 of us were flown to Agartala in a BSF aircraft, and then taken on buses to near the Bangladesh border. There, we were divided into small groups. Around 3 am, they led us to the border, gave us 300 Taka, some food in a plastic packet and a water bottle. Wielding their batons, BSF personnel then drove us towards Bangladesh and asked us not to return. We ran towards Bangladesh, it was dark," says the 53-year-old.

He says that villagers in Bangladesh helped them make phone calls home, and informed the Border Guard Bangladesh (BGB). The BGB made all of them assemble in a field. On June 15, the BGB handed them back to the BSF, which transferred them to the Bengal Police.

One of the most known cases of a person branded Bangladeshi, pushed across the border and brought back was of a pregnant Sunali Khatun, of Birbhum. She was detained in Delhi and deported in June last year to Bangladesh along with husband Danish, their eight-year-old son, and another family.

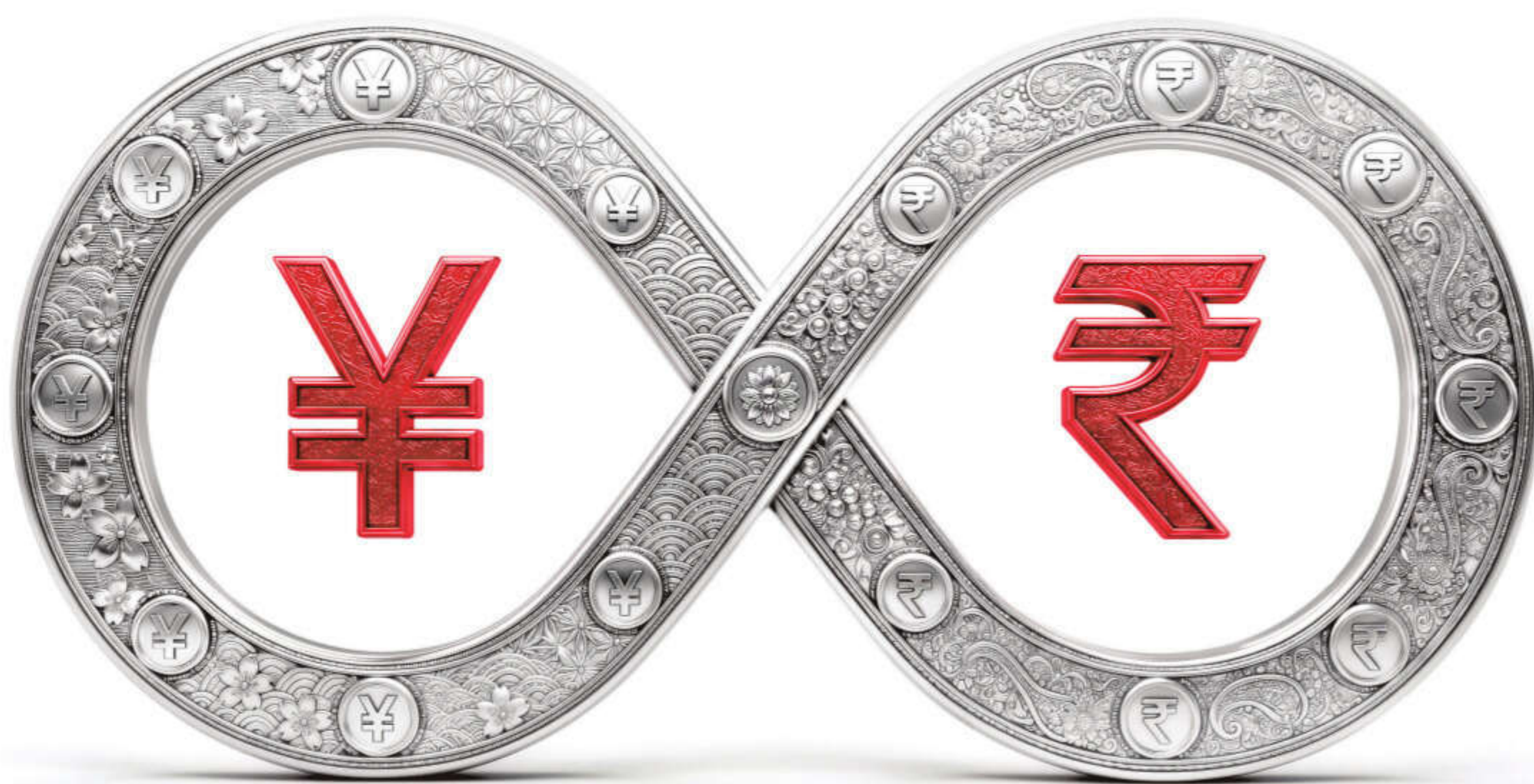
On December 5, 2025, Sunali and her son were brought back to India following a Supreme Court order. When she had her delivery the next month, senior TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee visited her and named her newborn "Apon" (meaning one's own).

Speaking to *The Indian Express* from Birbhum, Sunali says her life is worse than before. "I have not gone back to Delhi. My brother, who drives a Toto (an e-rickshaw) supports me. He earns Rs 200-300 daily. How will I bring up my children like this?"



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NOTICE REFERS TO ‘UNAUTHORISED OCCUPATION OF PROPERTY’

Centre sends Gymkhana Club eviction notice, hearing before L&DO on July 7

Damini Nath & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 1

THE UNION government has sent an eviction notice to the Delhi Gymkhana Club on Monday, saying that the Club was in unauthorised occupation of the property on Safdarjung Road after its lease was determined or had ended on May 22.

The notice, issued under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupant) Act, 1971, asked for the Club's representative to appear before the Land and Development Office (L&DO) under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs for a hearing on July 7.

It added that the premises in question “constitute valuable public premises vested in the Union of India and the Government is under an obligation to regulate, protect and utilise such public property in accordance with public interest and public purpose”.

According to the lease deed,



Monday's notice stated that the Club failed to vacate the premises despite being asked to hand over possession. FILE

the lessor – the government – can resume and re-enter or take back the premises if it is required for a public purpose, the notice said.

On May 22, the L&DO had written to the Club saying the land was “critically required for strengthening and securing of Defence infrastructure and other vital public security purposes”.

It had added that the land is essential to fulfil urgent institutional needs, governance infrastructure and public-interest projects.

“Despite lawful determination of the lease and despite being called upon to hand over possession, the respondent failed to vacate the premises and continues in occupation

thereof... Because valuable government land situated in the National Capital cannot be permitted to remain under unauthorised occupation contrary to governmental determination and larger public interest,” the Monday's notice said.

In 1928, the 27.3-acre plot was given on perpetual lease to the Imperial Gymkhana Club, which became Delhi Gymkhana Club after Independence.

The L&DO had asked for the premises to be handed over by June 5, which led the Club to move the Delhi High Court. While the HC, on May 26, did not stay the process, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta submitted that the government would proceed as per procedure established under law.

The Club has been run by a government-appointed General Committee since 2022, after the National Company Law Tribunal allowed the government to take over the administration following alleged irregularities and violations of norms.

While the incumbent governing body members declined to comment on the eviction notice, sources among the government-appointed office-bearers maintained that the matter was sub-judice.

“Since the matter is sub-judice, suffice it to say that all members and office-bearers concerned are awaiting ongoing judicial proceedings in the matter. In the meantime, the Club remains functional and efforts are being made to accommodate its existing staff members and related workforce in gainful employment elsewhere,” a source said.

Gaurav M Liberhan, the advocate who represented the last-elected governing body of the Club before the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) and the Supreme Court, said the members would explore the legal options available to them.



After summer break

Students return to school after the summer vacation, in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL

Tension in Sagarpur again, stones thrown during religious recital

FIR over incident at a DDA park, police teams deployed in area

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 1

DAYS AFTER local residents alleged that flags similar to that of Pakistan were hoisted during a Muharram procession in Southwest Delhi's Sagarpur last Friday, fresh friction erupted in the area when stones were allegedly thrown during a Hanuman Chalisa recital organised by Bajrang Dal members on Tuesday, police said.

Following the incident, a case has been registered under sections relating to voluntarily

causing hurt and wrongful restraint against unknown persons. According to police, the incident took place between 7 pm and 8 pm at a DDA park behind the jhuggi cluster in Gali 8 under the jurisdiction of Sagarpur police station.

“A brief confrontation broke out at a DDA park after members of Bajrang Dal gathered to recite the Hanuman Chalisa and some nearby residents objected to the event,” DCP Amit Goel said.

According to another officer, “There were reports that a group of women started objecting to the recital of Hanuman Chalisa. Amid the commotion, some stones were thrown at those reciting the Hanuman Chalisa.”

Police said tension in the locality had been simmering since Friday's Muharram procession that passed through the area. “Some residents claimed that during the procession, they spotted Pakistani flags being hoisted. It was found later that they were religious flags not pertaining to any country,” said a source in the police.

Purported videos of the incident showed a group of women standing a few metres away from the DDA park, raising slogans. Another video from the Muharram procession showed a child waving a green-and-white flag in the same locality.

While the police intervened and dispersed the two groups peacefully, the incident prompted the deployment of more than 100 police personnel in the area to keep a check on the law and order situation. Police said both groups were counselled and no injuries or damage to property were reported.

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 1

THE DELHI High Court Wednesday refrained from passing immediate orders to protect the Jaipur Polo Ground, now in government possession, from irreversible alteration, but orally remarked to government counsel: “You're anyway in possession, there is no hurry to tear it up.”

The Indian Polo Association (IPA), which managed the ground, in its petition sought that the government be restrained from “demolition, uprooting, digging, disturbing or altering the Jaipur Polo Ground”, or any other physical alteration of the land and turf at the specialised sporting facility.

On June 13, the government began the process of taking

physical possession of the Jaipur Polo Ground, one of the Capital's most prominent sporting venues, spread across 15.20 acres in the heart of Lutyens' Delhi.

The move was initiated following an eviction order issued on May 20 directing the IPA to vacate the property under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act. The order stated that the land was required “for a larger public purpose and benefit”.

While the IPA had challenged the eviction order, the sessions court on June 12 refused to grant a stay.

A trial court on June 18 also dismissed an application by the association seeking restoration of possession. After the government took physical possession



A notice pasted at the gate of the property. FILE

of the land, the IPA moved a petition before the Delhi HC on June 20.

On Wednesday, even as IPA's counsel pressed for interim relief, Justice Harish Vaidyanathan Shankar orally observed that the earlier coordinate benches of the High Court dealing with the case had declined to give relief to the association in any manner. The

court posted the matter for hearing on July 9.

However, addressing government's standing counsel Ashish Dixit, the court orally remarked, “You're anyway in possession, there is no hurry to tear it (the ground) up... I'm not passing any order (today).”

On June 29, Dixit had told the court that the Jaipur Polo Ground is only being demarcated for raising a boundary and nothing was being done to the playing area turf.

He reiterated the position orally before the court on Wednesday, after the association's counsel flagged their concerns over digging up of the polo turf. The IPA added that there are events slated later this month.

The land parcel where the ground is situated was gifted by the erstwhile Maharaja of Jaipur to the Delhi Polo Club around 1930, and was formally leased on February 24, 1951, to the Club by the Central Public Works Department for a period of 20 years.

According to IPA, the lease was extended in 1971 till 1982, with further extensions continuing thereafter. In 1983, the lease was extended until March 1993. Following the dissolution of the Delhi Polo Club in 1983, the premises were transferred and allotted in favour of IPA.

Over the decades, the Jaipur Polo Ground has been a centre of national and international polo events and tournaments such as the Asian Games equestrian events, IPA National Polo Championship, Indian Masters Trophy, among others.



Union Territory of Jammu & Kashmir

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER PWD (R&B) DIVISION SATWARI

SHORT NOTICE INVITING TENDERS

Short e-NIT No. 40 of 2026-27

Dated:- 30-06-2026

For and on behalf of the Lieutenant Governor, Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir e-tenders are invited on percentage basis from approved and eligible Contractors registered with Union Territory of J&K, CPWD, Railways, MES and other State/Central Governments for each of the following works:-

S. No.	Name of Work	Advertised Cost (Rs. in Lacs)	Cost of document (In Rupees)	Earnest Money (In Rupees)	Time Allowed for completion	Time and date of opening of tender	Class of Contractor
1	2	3	6	7	8	9	10
1	Macadamization of road from Bachiyal to Paryal. (manually)	30.00	600/-	(2% of the Advertised Cost)	30 Days	22/07/2026	A, B/Hot mix Plant
2	Macadamization of road from Rajpura to Batera	30.00	600/-	(2% of the Advertised Cost)	30 Days	22/07/2026	A, B/Hot mix Plant
3	Macadamization of road from Chak Maani road to Dub Karamdin	30.00	600/-	(2% of the Advertised Cost)	30 Days	22/07/2026	A, B/Hot mix Plant
4	Macadamization of road from Rajpura to Manyal.	20.00	600/-	(2% of the Advertised Cost)	30 Days	22/07/2026	A, B, C/Hot mix Plant

Position of AAA:-
Position of T.S:-
Major Head of Account:-

Accorded
Accorded
City & Town 2026-2027

The Bidding documents Consisting of qualifying information, eligibility criteria, specifications, Drawings, bill of quantities (B.O.Q), Set of terms and conditions of contract and other details can be seen/downloaded from the departmental website <http://jktenders.gov.in> as per below schedule :-

1	Date of Issue of Tender Notice	30/06/2026 at 1800 Hrs.
2	Period of downloading of bidding documents	30/06/2026 at 1800 Hrs.
3	Date, Time and place of pre-bid meeting	02/07/2026 at 1300 Hrs. in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari
4	Bid submission Start Date	30/06/2026 at 1800 Hrs.
5	Bid Submission End Date	21/07/2026 up to 1600 Hrs.
6	Date & time of opening of Technical Bids (Online)	22/07/2026 on or after 13.00 Hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari
7	Date & time of opening of Financial Bids (Online)	To be notified after technical bid evaluation is completed

1.

Bids must be accompanied with cost of Tender document in shape of e-challan through Treasury indicating Treasury Voucher No. & date, e-NIT No. and name of work duly crediting to 0059 (Revenue) favoring Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari and upload the same i.e treasury challan/receipt, Earnest money/Bid security in shape of CDR/FDR/BG pledged to Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari. The CDR/FDR/BG shall be valid for 45 Days beyond the bid validity period. The original instruments in respect of cost of documents, EMD and relevant documents of L1 be submitted to the Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari at the time of allotment.

2.

The electronic bidding system would not allow any late submission of bids after due date and time as per server time. Bidders may modify their bids by uploading their request for modification before the deadline for submission of bids. For this, the bidder need not to make any additional payment towards the cost of tender document. For bid modification and consequential re-submission, the bidder is not required to withdraw his bid submitted earlier. The last modified bid submitted by the bidder within the bid submission time shall be considered as the bid. For this purpose, modification/withdrawal by other means will not be accepted. In online system of bid submission, the modification and consequential- submission of bids is allowed any number of times. The bidders may withdraw his bid by uploading their request before the deadline for submission of bids; however, if the bid is withdrawn, the re-submission of the bid is not allowed. No bid shall be modified or withdrawn after the deadline of submission of bids.

3.

The date and time of opening of Financial-Bids shall be notified on Web Site www.jktenders.gov.in and conveyed to the bidders automatically through an e-mail message on their e-mail address. The Financial-bids of responsive bidders shall be opened online in the Executive Engineer PWD (R&B) Division Satwari The date for same shall be intimated separately

4.

The bids for the work shall remain valid for a period of 120 days from the date of opening of technical bids.

5.

The earnest money shall be forfeited, If :-

a)

Any bidder/tenderer withdraws his bid/tender during the period of bid validity or makes any modifications in the terms and conditions of the bid.

b)

Failure of Successful bidder to furnish the required performance security within specified time period after issue of letter of acceptance.

c)

Failure of successful bidder to execute the agreement on same day of allotment of work contract as per Chief Engineer PW (R&B) Department Jammu's Circular No. CEJ/G/12660-87 dated 07-10-2021.

6.

Instruction to bidders regarding e-tendering process.

Bidders are advised to download bid submission manual from the "Downloads" option as well as from "Bidders Manual Kit" on website www.jktenders.gov.in to acquaint bid submission process. To participate in bidding process, bidders have to get 'Digital Signature Certificate (DSC)' as per Information Technology Act-2000. Bidders can get digital certificate from any approved vendors. The bidders have to submit their bids online in electronic format with digital Signature. No financial bid will be accepted in physical form. Bids will be opened online as per time schedule mentioned above.

Bidders must ensure to upload scanned copy of all necessary documents mentioned in NIT and SBD with technical bid online.

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
PWD (R&B) Division
Satwari

No:- XEN/SAT/PWD/Tender/2026-27/
Dated:-...../...../.....

DIP/J-4837/26 – DATE 01 JULY 2026



बिहार राज्य औद्योगिक विकास निगम लि
(बिहार सरकार का उपक्रम)
इंदिरा भवन, राम चरित्र सिंह पथ (बोरिंग कैनाल रोड) पटना – 800001

आवश्यक सूचना

माननीय सर्वोच्च न्यायालय में चल रहे ग्राह सं 932/2022 में दिये गये आदेश के अनुपालन में बिहार राज्य औद्योगिक विकास निगम लि के इकाई बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, बहादुरपुर, भागलपुर और खंखिदपुरी इकाई बिहार स्कुटर्स लि, फतुहा, पटना के कर्मियों का बकाया वेतनादि का भुगतान किया जाता है। इस संबंध में निम्न Traceless एवं आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा नहीं किये जाने वाले कर्मियों / आश्रितों को सूचित किया जाता है कि निगम मुख्यालय (बिहार राज्य औद्योगिक विकास निगम लि, चतुर्थ तल, इंदिरा भवन, बोरिंग कैनाल रोड, पटना) में यथाशीघ्र संपर्क करे तथा इकाई तथा अनुबंधी इकाई में किए गए कार्य का प्रमाण (नियुक्ति / सेवाविपुति की प्रति, बैंक खाता विवरण, आधार कार्ड, पैन कार्ड, आश्रित वंशावली, प्रतिशोधन पत्र आदि)।

प्रकाशन की तिथि से 15 दिनों के अंदर कार्यालय में आकर आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा करें, अन्यथा उक्त तिथि के बाद किसी प्रकार का दावा मान्य नहीं होगा।

क्रमांक	Traceless कर्मी का नाम	इकाई/अनुबंधी इकाई का नाम
1.	श्रीमति गीता देवी, स्वं ओम प्रकाश सिंह	बिहार स्कुटर्स लि, फतुहा
2.	श्री शमीम अहमद, पिता मो० प्रमसुख लोहंड	बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर
3.	श्री जगदेव ओझा, पिता स्व० यासुदेव ओझा	बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर
4.	श्री रामचन्द्र पाण्डेय	बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर
5.	श्री गिरिन्ध कुमारा सिन्हा	बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर
6.	स्वं अयोधी हरजिन, पिता स्व० मोहन हरजिन	बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर
7.	स्वं सीताराम मंडल, पिता स्व० किसकू मंडल	बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर

क्रमांक

आवश्यक दस्तावेज जमा नहीं किये जाने वाले कर्मी का नाम

इकाई/अनुबंधी इकाई का नाम

1

श्री लाला राम, पिता स्व० जमुना राम

बिहार स्कुटर्स लि, फतुहा

2

स्वं रघुवीर राम, स्व० चमन राम

बिहार स्कुटर्स लि, फतुहा

3

स्वं जगदेव ठाकुर, पिता रामदेव ठाकुर

बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर

4

स्वं मनोरंजन दास, पिता निमी भूषण दास

बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर

5

स्वं सोनिलाल यादव, स्व० पटवारी यादव

बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर

6

स्वं चंद्रका मुर्मू

बिहार स्वन सिल्क मिल, भागलपुर

PR- 006774 (B & C) 2026-27

विस्तृत सूचना www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

नशे से बचने का है एक ही उपचार, दृढ़ संकल्प और परिवार से प्यार



बिहार सरकार

नालन्दा सभाहणालय, विहारशरीफ

अति अल्पकालीन सूचना

वजहिये नोटिस सूचित किया जाता है कि बिहार मद्यनिषेध उत्पाद अधिनियम 2016 की धारा- 58(घ) के अन्तर्गत अवैध रूप से देशी / विदेशी शराब का परिवहन एवं रख-रखाव / भंडारण करने के आरोप में विभिन्न थाना काण्डों में जप्त वाहनों एवं मवन / मू-खण्ड के विरुद्ध अधिग्रहण की कार्यवाई प्रारंभ किया गया है।

नव संशोधित नियमावली, 2022 के नियम-12(क) के निहित प्रावधानों के आधार पर नवीनतम बीमाकूल मुल्या की शास्ति (Penalty) की राशि जमा कर वाहनों को मुक्त करने का प्रावधान किया गया है, साथ ही नव संशोधित नियमावली, 2022 के नियम-12(ख) के निहित प्रावधानों के आधार पर शास्ति (Penalty) राशि जमा कर मवन / मू-खण्ड को मुक्त करने का प्रावधान किया गया है जिसके लिए कॉलम-06 में अंकित न्यायालय में विज्ञापन प्रकाशन के एक सप्ताह के अन्दर उपस्थित होना निर्धारित है।

क्र०	अधिग्रहण वाद संख्या एवं वर्ष	थाना काण्ड संख्या	वाहन मालिक का नाम एवं पता	वाहन का प्रकार एवं निबंध संख्या	न्यायालय का नाम एवं सुनवाई हेतु निर्धारित तिथि
1	2	3	4	5	6
1	अधिग्रहण उत्पाद वाद सं० 68 / 26	उत्पाद थाना काण्ड काण्ड सं०-68 / 2026, दिनांक- 21.02.2026	अनिता उल्ला, पति-विजय उल्ला, पता-197-E करिआपा मार्ग, सैनिक फार्म, नई दिल्ली, पिन कोड-110060	Maruti Suzuki 1.1 L16 Valve Car निबंध संख्या DL9CM-2479 थैचिस नं० MA3EED81S00319318 इंजन नं० F10DN4142823	न्यायालय अपर जिला दण्डाधिकारी-सह-अपर-समाहर्ता, नालन्दा विज्ञापन प्रकाशन के एक सप्ताह के अन्दर

अतः सभी संबंधित उपरोक्त वर्णित वाहन स्वामियों को इस प्रेस विज्ञापन के माध्यम से सूचित किया जाता है कि कॉलम-06 में अंकित न्यायालय / तिथि पर उपस्थित होकर अपने-अपने वाहन को विमुक्त कराना चाहते हैं तो प्रपत्र-IV में अपना आवेदन प्रस्तुत करें। उक्त निर्धारित तिथि पर उपस्थित नहीं होने एवं प्रपत्र-IV में आवेदन प्रस्तुत नहीं करने की स्थिति में समाज जायेगा की आपकी जप्त वाहन के विमुक्ति में कोई अमिर्लुची नहीं है, साथ ही उपरोक्त वर्णित मवन / मू-खण्ड स्वामियों को इस प्रेस विज्ञापन के माध्यम से सूचित किया जाता है कि कॉलम-06 में अंकित न्यायालय में 15 दिनों के अन्दर उपस्थित होकर अपने-अपने मवन / मू-खण्ड को विमुक्त कराना चाहते हैं तो प्रपत्र-V में अपना आवेदन प्रस्तुत करें। 15 दिनों के अन्दर उपस्थित नहीं होने एवं प्रपत्र-V में आवेदन प्रस्तुत नहीं करने की स्थिति में समाज जायेगा की आपकी जप्त मवन / मू-खण्ड के विमुक्ति में कोई अमिर्लुची नहीं है। तत्परचात उक्त वाहन एवं मवन / मू-खण्ड को बिहार मद्यनिषेध एवं उत्पाद अधिनियम 2016 की धारा-58(2) के अन्तर्गत राजस्वहित में राजस्वत (Confiscate) करते हुए नीलामी की प्रक्रिया के तहत अधिग्रहित वाहनों एवं मवन / मू-खण्ड को नीलाम कर दिया जायेगा।

PR- 006814 (Excise) 2026-27

नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

जिला पदाधिकारी, नालन्दा।

Govt nod for annual archaeology, archives fellowship programmes

New Delhi: The Delhi government has approved two new annual research fellowship programmes, in archives and archaeology, aimed at strengthening documentation, conservation and academic research on the Capital's heritage.

The 'Research Fellowship in Archives' and 'Research Fellowship in Archaeology' schemes will be implemented by the departments of Delhi Archives and Archaeology, respectively.

Under the archives fellowship, the government will engage 15 researchers every year for a one-year term — 10 Senior Research Fellows (SRFs), who will receive a monthly stipend of Rs 50,000, and five Junior Research Fellows (JRFs) who will get Rs 25,000 a month. It will include research in seven areas: records management, conservation and preservation of archival material, digitisation of records, dissemination of information and data, micro-filming and reprography, research and publication, and oriental languages,

particularly Urdu and Persian. Fellows will use rare manuscripts, maps, photos and administrative records to study Delhi's institutional history, urban expansion, environmental history, festivals, cinema, social life, etc.

The archaeology fellowship will support 12 researchers annually — three SRFs and there JRFs each in archaeology and conservation. Senior fellows will receive a stipend of Rs 50,000 a month and junior fellows will get Rs 25,000 a month.

Research under the archaeology scheme will cover topics like the earliest settlements in the Delhi Ridge and Yamuna basin, the Painted Grey Ware and Northern Black Polished Ware cultures, early historic Delhi, trade routes, archaeology of the Yamuna floodplain, conservation of Delhi monuments, digital conservation, heritage conservation and climate change, public archaeology and community engagement, and encroachment and heritage preservation. ENS



Govt. of Bihar

Public Health Engineering Department

Public Health Engineering Division, Samastipur

SHORT TENDER NIT No -06/2026-27/O&M-PHED/R1

National Competitive Bidding

(Through e-procurement mode on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in)

1	Designation and Address of Advertiser	Executive Engineer, P. H. Division, Samastipur
2	Date of issue of Tender Notice	30.06.2026
3	Period of sale (downloading) of tender Bid Document	11.07.2026 to 16.07.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. through www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
4	Date, time & place of pre-bid meeting	09.07.2026 at 12:00 hrs in the Office of Executive Engineer of concerned P. H. Division, Samastipur
5	Last date and time of receipt (uploading) of tender	16.07.2026 up to 17:00Hrs on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
6	Date and time of opening of technical bid	16.07.2026 at 17:30Hrs on www.eproc2.bihar.gov.in
7	Date and time of opening of financial bid	To be informed later after the approval of technical bid.

8. Details of works:

Group No	Name of Work	Estimated Cost (in Lakh)	Amount of Earnest Money (in Lakh)	Cost of Tender Document (non-refundable) in Rs.	BSEDC Bid Processing Fee (in Rs.)	Completion Period (in months)
1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1.	Comprehensive operation and maintenance, routine repairs and Special repairs of i.) Rural Piped Water Supply Scheme 41 (PWS), ii.) Ward level Piped Water Supply Schemes 458 in quality affected wards (WLS, Quality) and iii.) Ward level Piped Water Supply Schemes 585 in non quality affected wards (WLS, Non Quality) based on item rates; constructed by the Public Health Engineering Department including payment to the pump operators, electricity bills for five years.	11601.98 2	126.02	As per Online	As per Online	60 Month

Executive Engineer,
Public Health Division, Samastipur

For further details please visit : www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar

PR. No. 006781 (PHED) 2026-27

नशामुक्त हो जाए बिहार, सुरक्षित रहे घर परिवार।

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GROUND report



The mother of the victim at their residence at Mustafabad in Loni on Wednesday. PRAVEEN KHANNA

Youth beaten to death in Loni: No water at home, was out for a swim when his bike grazed car

One held, police teams formed to nab other accused

Drishti Jain

Ghaziabad, July 1

AROUND 2 pm on Monday, Mohammad Zaid told his elder sister he was going for a swim and would bring her a cold drink on the way back.

He never returned.

The 20-year-old was beaten to death in Ghaziabad's Loni area after his motorcycle brushed against a car. The accused, a real estate businessman named Rahul Mavi, took Zaid to his office where he and his friend allegedly brutally assaulted him. Rahul has been arrested.

On Wednesday, seated amid relatives and neighbours outside the family's two-storey home in Mustafabad, his father, Shaukat, asked in disbelief: "Was a scratch so big that someone could be killed? Even if a car is destroyed, nobody kills the other person."

The family said Zaid had gone to swim with two minor friends, aged 15 and 16, on a motorcycle, as frequent power cuts had left their home without water.

As the boys crossed the Behta Puliya crossing, their motorcycle brushed against a car. The occupants of the cargo out and slapped all three, his mother, Shakeela, alleged.

"His friends told me they dragged my son into the car, wrenched out the bike keys, and told the boys to follow them. They ran for nearly 20 minutes — about 3 km — and reached the accused's office, where they saw the parked bike," she said.

Shakeela said the boys were told to take Zaid away. "When they couldn't lift him, the accused pushed my son with their feet," she broke down.

Zaid's aunt alleged that the accused cut the motorcycle's fuel pipe and threatened the



Outside the victim's house in Mustafabad on Wednesday; (left) Mohammad Zaid, the deceased. PRAVEEN KHANNA

boys, saying they would also be beaten if they named them to the police.

"The friends somehow put my unconscious nephew on the bike and dragged it back home," she said.

They tried to revive him by splashing water on his face and making him drink, but he did not respond.

Shakeela, sitting on a chair, said Zaid was studying and working alongside. "Mera beta bahut doobla-patla aur na-zuk-tha... Jab maine use dekha, toh har jagah se khoon aa raha tha — naakhun tak se. Uska poor sa shareer garam ho gaya tha. (My son was very thin and fragile... When I saw him, he was bleeding from everywhere — even from under his fingernails. His entire body was burning hot.)"

The family, which has nine children, some of them married, owns five buffaloes and supplies milk to nearby homes. "Zaid helped us after school... he was nearly six feet tall. I used

to tell him to stop growing, that he wouldn't fit in the house," his mother said, before asking: "If our religion was different, would justice still be delayed?"

Police said during questioning, Rahul claimed he and his friend Anuja Kasana were returning to their office, Manish Properties, in a Baleno car after buying fruits from the Loni T-junction. "He claimed that near the Indraprastha Gas Plant intersection, on the road towards Behta Canal, Zaid, riding a motorcycle, collided with the car," police said.

Rahul claimed they took Zaid to the office, where they demanded he pay for the damage caused to the car. However, he told the police that Zaid refused. "So, they assaulted him till he lost consciousness," said police. Rahul claimed they came to know later that Zaid died during treatment, police said.

Police said a case of murder, assault and kidnapping under relevant sections of Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) has been registered at the Loni Border police station on a complaint by the victim's brother.

"One accused has been arrested. Teams have been formed to catch the others," a police officer said.

UNION CABINET CLEARS MEGA DECONGESTION PROJECT FOR SOUTHWEST DELHI

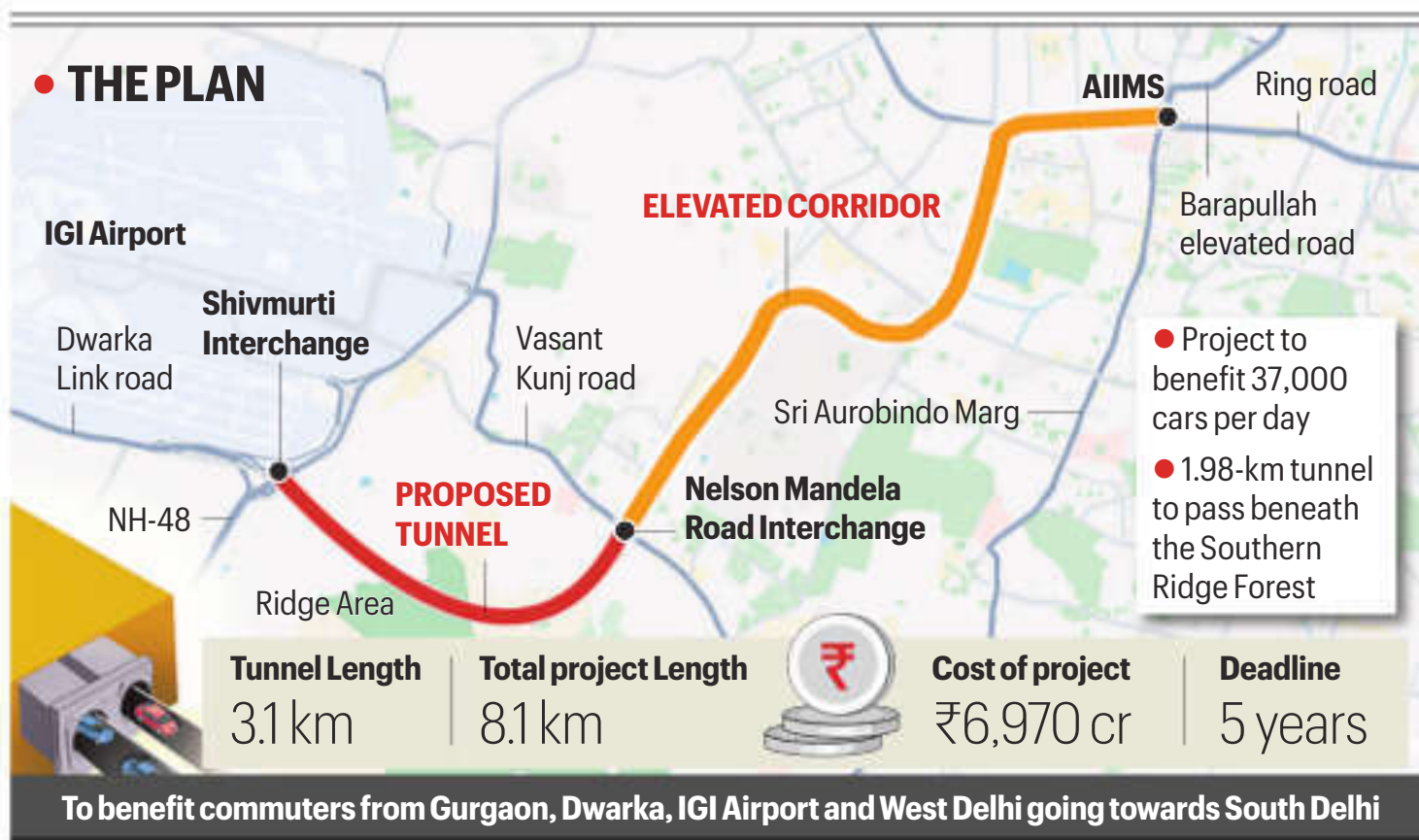
AIIMS-Vasant Kunj-Dwarka E-way: Coming, a Rs 7,000 cr road-tunnel

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, July 1

TO DECONGEST a part of New Delhi, the Union Cabinet on Wednesday approved the construction of an 8.1-km, six-lane road-tunnel project — comprising a 3.1-km tunnel and a highway — on NH-148AE connecting the Shiv Murti interchange on Dwarka Expressway, next to Indira Gandhi International Airport, with Nelson Mandela Marg in Vasant Kunj that further connects to the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS).

The Rs 6,970-crore road-tunnel project will be developed in a hybrid annuity mode — where the government shares part of the cost with a private party, which earns returns through annuity payments later — and is expected to be completed in five years, officials said. A 1.98-km-long tunnel will be constructed beneath the Southern Ridge Forest.

"There has been a demand for this project for a long time. The ridge area in this section



will not be disturbed at all, and the tunnel will pass under it. The project will be a new artery of Delhi," said Union Minister of Information and Broadcasting, Ashwini Vaishnaw, while announcing the Cabinet decision. "A tunnel-boring machine will be used for tunnelling under the ridge. It will be simi-

lar to the undersea tunnel to be constructed in Mumbai as part of the Ahmedabad-Mumbai bullet train project," he added. The road connecting Mahipalpur and Vasant Kunj is oversaturated, and there is no scope for widening, officials said. This stretch sees heavy traffic jams, even during the lean hours.

The project will help in decongesting the Dhaula Kuan-IGI Airport, Chhatarpur-Mahipalpur, and Rangpuri bottlenecks. Along with this, vehicles coming from Gurgaon, Dwarka, IGI Airport, and West Delhi towards South Delhi will see a reduction in traffic jams, officials said.

Officials added that about 37,000 vehicles will benefit daily after the completion of the project.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi posted on X, "Our government is committed to making connectivity in Delhi even more seamless and world-class. In this direction, approval has been granted for the construction of a 6-lane tunnel connecting the Dwarka Expressway to Vasant Kunj. This important project will make travel between West and South Delhi faster and more convenient than before. It will also save people a significant amount of time."

The Cabinet also approved a four-lane highway from Kanpur to Kabrai in Uttar Pradesh's Mahoba district that will enhance connectivity in Bundelkhand. The 242-km project is part of the Kanpur-Bhopal Economic Corridor. The Rs 7,145 crore project will reduce the travel time between Kanpur and Kabrai from 3.5 hours to 1.5 hours and will be designed for a speed range of 80-100 kmph.

EXPRESS special

Google search, fake website, Rs 20,000 gone: Inside Char Dham chopper fraud

Using IRCTC name, scamsters offered 'divine' chopper rides, duped pilgrims

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 1

IT BEGAN with a simple Google search for a helicopter service to Kedarnath for the Char Dham Yatra.

On May 12, a government official found what appeared to be an authorised booking website, completed the payment in minutes and received confirmation and two tickets on WhatsApp and Gmail. But when his family reached the Phata helipad, they were in for a shock — the tickets were fake.

Investigators said the website was part of a wider cyber fraud operation that allegedly targeted pilgrims across India. Since then, three arrests have been made in the case.

As per police, the government official clicked on a Google link — irctc-heliyatra.com. The portal carried the tagline, 'Divine journey to four sacred Himalayan abodes', along with a package advertising '4 Dhams, 5N/6D from Rs 89,999' and photos of the four pilgrimage sites. (The official clicked 'Book Now' and was redirected to another page titled 'Trans Bharat Aviation Kedarnath Helicopter Ticket Booking by 2026', with a helicopter image and a mobile number.

He clicked on the number and a WhatsApp chat opened, where he received details of helicopter fares: Dehradun to Kedarnath (Rs 23,000), Sirsi to Kedar-

THE CYBER FRAUD IN FOUR STEPS

1 Fake Heli yatra portal carried the tagline, 'Divine journey to four sacred Himalayan abodes', along with a package advertising '4 Dhams, 5N/6D from Rs 89,999' and photos of the four pilgrimage sites.

2 'Book Now' option opened another page titled 'Trans Bharat Aviation Kedarnath Helicopter Ticket Booking by 2026'

nath (Rs 6,390), Phata to Kedarnath (Rs 10,164) and Guptkashi to Kedarnath (Rs 12,762).

Police said the official called the number, and the person on the other end asked him which package he wanted to book. The official chose the Phata-Kedarnath helicopter service for two family members. The caller assured him that a booking link would be sent shortly. The payment was made and the official received two e-tickets worth Rs 20,328 via Gmail and WhatsApp.

Satisfied that everything was in order, the family set off from Delhi. At the Phata helipad, security personnel of Trans Bharat Aviation informed them that the tickets were fake.

Trans Bharat Aviation, one of India's oldest non-scheduled helicopter operators, offers helicopter charter services for elections, VIP movement, helipilgrimages, joy rides and aerial surveys. Its official website states that it does not accept direct bookings and that www.heliyatra.irctc.co.in is the only authorised platform for reservations. A police officer said the victim had booked the tickets through irctc-heliyatra.com, a domain designed to closely re-

3 On a WhatsApp, official received details of helicopter fares: Dehradun to Kedarnath (Rs 23,000), Sirsi to Kedarnath (Rs 6,390), Phata to Kedarnath (Rs 10,164) and Guptkashi to Kedarnath (Rs 12,762).

4 The payment was made and he received two 'e-tickets' worth Rs 20,328 via Gmail and WhatsApp.

semble the actual website. "From Phata, the government official filed a complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (NCRP), following which it was transferred to the Cyber police station of South Delhi," the officer added.

Police soon realised the case was much larger than a single incident. What initially appeared to be a single case of on-line cheating turned out to be a larger cyber fraud operation spanning multiple states," DCP (South) Anant Mittal said.

Through detailed analysis of bank accounts, the money trail, domain registrations, Gmail records, IP logs and technical evidence, police arrested two men — Omprakash Kumar and Rohit Kumar from Nalanda in Bihar on June 2.

During questioning, police said they disclosed the role of a third accused, Shreyansh Tiwari alias Shivam, a BTech student from Jaunpur in Uttar Pradesh. He was later arrested from Noida.

Investigators said Omprakash came in contact with Shreyansh through Telegram after learning that the latter could develop websites, and allegedly offered him Rs 40,000 to

create the fake booking portal. Police described Shreyansh as the technical mastermind behind the operation. He allegedly developed and maintained the fake websites, while Rohit handled customer calls, communicated with prospective victims over WhatsApp and managed financial transactions by routing payments through multiple bank accounts.

They said the syndicate cloned official-looking websites, promoted them through paid advertisements on Meta platforms and directed victims to WhatsApp conversations. Once trust was established by sharing fare charts, package details and booking links, victims were persuaded to transfer money.

Their probe so far has revealed that the gang is linked to nearly 30 complaints registered on the NCRP from different states and Union Territories, involving cheated amounts estimated at Rs 10 lakh.

Investigators suspect the actual number of victims may be significantly higher, as many pilgrims either fail to report cyber fraud or realise they have been cheated only after reaching the helicopter boarding point.

Police said Omprakash was previously booked in a cyber job fraud case in 2022 at the Cyber Police Station in North-west Delhi and spent a few months in jail before securing bail and returning to Nalanda. The other two accused have no criminal record and were allegedly acting on Omprakash's instructions.

Investigators are now examining whether the syndicate operated similar fake portals for other religious destinations, tourism services or seasonal events and if they are linked to larger cyber fraud networks operating across states.

• Skywatch



Forecast: July 2, 2026

Generally cloudy sky; light to moderate rainfall

MAX: 32-34

3.4°C below normal

MIN: 22-24

5.9°C below normal

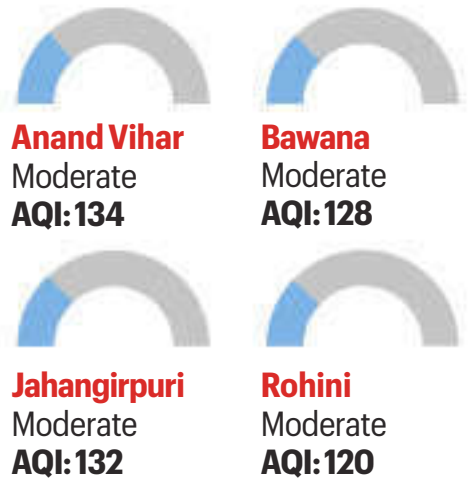
• Sunrise: 5:28 AM (July 3)

• Sunset: 7:23 PM (July 2)

• Moonrise: 9:26 PM (July 2)

• Moonset: 8:11 AM (July 3)

• AQI Tracker



● Good (0-50)
● Satisfactory (51-100)
● Moderate (101-200)
● Poor (201-300)
● Very Poor (301-400)
● Severe (401-500)

• BRIEFLY

Monsoon likely to hit Capital in two days: IMD

DELHI IS likely to receive the southwest monsoon within the next two days, ending a prolonged wait and offering respite from the lingering summer heat. The arrival will mark the latest monsoon onset over the Capital in five years, the IMD said on Wednesday. It also said that conditions are favourable for the further advance of the southwest monsoon into more parts of the north Arabian Sea, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Chandigarh, Delhi, Punjab and parts of Rajasthan during the next two days.

Illegal colonies: Ownership right deadline is Oct 31

DELHI GOVERNMENT has fixed October 31 as the cut-off date to file applications to get conveyance deeds and authorisation slips needed for registry of properties in unauthorised colonies in the city, officials said. No fresh applications would be accepted after the deadline, they added. The move comes amid the revenue department receiving a low number of around 2,000 applications from residents of 1,511 unauthorised colonies for issuance of these documents. Conveyance deeds are issued for built-up properties of government land.

• DELHI ELECTRIC VEHICLES POLICY 2026 NOTIFIED

In EV Policy, electrification roadmap: Cars next after 3- & 2-wheelers

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 1

THE DELHI government, for the first time, said on Wednesday that it intends to introduce electrification mandates for four-wheelers in the future. The intent, which did not feature in the draft EV Policy 2.0 released in April, has been incorporated into the final policy — Delhi Electric Vehicles Policy 2026 — which was notified on July 1.

As per the policy document, the government "intends to bring out electrification mandates for four-wheelers in future as well as aim to make a framework for disincentivising polluting vehicles that use inefficient fuels".

Delhi is the first city in the

country that has introduced sweeping mandates to stop registration of new petrol and diesel two- and three-wheelers to curb pollution.

Under the new EV policy, only electric three-wheelers will be allowed to be registered in the city from January 1, 2027, while registrations of new non-electric two-wheelers will be stopped from April 1, 2028.

The two-wheeler mandate had faced strong opposition during stakeholder consultations, but the government went ahead with it.

Industry players had cited lack of electric two-wheeler options for a large chunk of the population that depended on petrol two-wheelers while also raising concerns over India's dependence on China for bat-



Electric four-wheelers account for around 11% of Delhi's four-wheeler fleet. FILE

teries and rare-earth processing — a multi-step industrial process of extracting and separating similar metals from raw mined ores.

Questioning the environmental gains of EV adoption, they had pointed out that around 71% of India's electricity

is generated from coal-based power.

A four-wheeler electrification mandate would lead to an even more significant shift. However, the government has not yet revealed when such a mandate will come into place and whether it will be intro-

duced in phases or through a sunset deadline — a specific date or point in time when a measure will come into effect — like in the case of the two-wheeler mandate.

At present, electric four-wheelers account for around 11% of Delhi's four-wheeler fleet — recording a penetration of only 8.3% in the private car segment. Passenger four-wheelers, meanwhile, have an electrification rate of around 14.2%.

According to experts, while incentives can help kick-start electrification, large-scale fleet transition requires strong regulatory signals such as Zero-Emission Vehicle (ZEV) mandates or phasing out of internal combustion engine (ICE) vehicles. "These policies provide automakers with confidence

that demand for EVs will be sustained over the long term, encouraging them to ramp up production, invest in innovation, and expand model offerings. Over time, this leads to lower costs and greater consumer choice, creating a virtuous cycle for EV adoption," Amit Bhatt, India managing director at International Council on Clean Transport (ICCT), said.

Experts also pointed out that mobility policies in Delhi have historically influenced policies in other states, and the inclusion of electrification mandates for different categories of vehicles in the city's EV policy is likely to make other governments consider more aggressive EV policies.

The current EV policy primarily focuses on electrifying

two-wheelers, three-wheelers and commercial vehicles.

"Two-wheelers constitute approximately 67% of the total vehicle stock in Delhi, making their rapid electrification critical for achieving meaningful reductions in vehicular emissions. Further, three-wheelers, commercial cars, and N1 category goods vehicles exhibit high daily utilisation and mileage, resulting in a disproportionate contribution to urban air pollution," the new EV policy says.

The only incentive for four-wheelers in the current policy is in the form of a scrapping incentive — first 1 lakh applicants who scrap an existing ICE vehicle and buy an electric car within six months will be eligible for an incentive of Rs 1 lakh.

‘Saddest day for country’: Cong slams govt over VB-G RAM G

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 1

WITH THE wage rates under the VB-G RAM G getting notified on Tuesday, the Congress hit out at the Centre, saying the Act effectively repealed the MGNREGA by replacing a demand-driven legal entitlement with a centrally controlled, allocation-based programme.

Addressing a press conference in New Delhi, Lok Sabha MP and Chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Rural Development and Panchayati Raj, Saptagiri Ulaka, said the new framework dismantles the statutory guarantee of work available to rural households and weakens workers’ rights by making employment contingent on pre-approved budgetary allocations rather than actual demand. “Today is the saddest day for the country,” he said.

Congress’s communications in charge Jairam Ramesh, meanwhile, said, “Given the widespread minimum wage protests in industrial hubs like Noida, and at a time when the stagnation of rural wages is widely recognised as a key constraint on our economic growth, this notification is both a snub to India’s workers and an unwise economic policy.”

Biggest U-turn: BJP on Mann govt move

The BJP, meanwhile, called the Punjab government’s decision to go ahead with the implementation of VB-G RAM G in the state as the “the biggest U-Turn” in the history of democratic governance.

Referring to the Bhagwant Mann government convening a special Assembly session in December to pass a resolution against the implementation of the scheme in the state, Union Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said, “Just six months later, they executed a massive U-turn... Why did they do this? Because Punjab’s economy is sinking...”



Misri gets one-yr extension as Foreign Secy

New Delhi: Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri was given a one-year extension on Wednesday, till July 14, 2027. Earlier, his tenure was extended by 19 months following his supernannuation date of November 30, 2024. As per the latest order issued on Wednesday, the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet approved the extension for a period of one year beyond July 14, 2026.

Misri was appointed to the post in June 2024. The 1989-batch IPS officer served as the Deputy NSA before he was appointed the Foreign Secretary. He succeeded Vinay Mohan Kwatra.

A career diplomat, Misri has served in various capacities at the Ministry of External Affairs and across Indian Missions in Europe, Africa, Asia, and North America. ENS

Rs 300-450: Govt rolls out rural job scheme in new avatar, notifies wages

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 1

THE CENTRE has notified wage rates for unskilled manual workers under the Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Aajeevika Mission (Gramin) (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025, which came into effect on Tuesday, replacing the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA), 2005.

Daily wages have been fixed between Rs 300 and Rs 409 across states, with a special rate of Rs 450 in certain gram panchayats in Sikkim, as per a notification issued by the Union Ministry of Rural Development late Tuesday night.

Northern and northeastern states such as Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Bihar, Jharkhand, Assam, Tripura, Sikkim and West Bengal have seen wage hikes of over 15%. Haryana, which has the highest wage rate of Rs 409, stands out with the lowest hike of just 2.25%.

Southern states like Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana saw a hike of 3% or below.

The new wage rates

The wage rate has been fixed at Rs 300 for 21 states: Gujarat, Manipur, Mizoram, Rajasthan, Odisha, Jammu and Kashmir, Ladakh, Meghalaya, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, West Bengal, Sikkim, Assam, Tripura, Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

•HIKE IN WAGES: TOP 10 STATES

State/UT	MGNREGA wages			VB G RAM G wages (Rs/day)	Increase (in %)#
	2024-25	2025-26	Increase (in %)		
Arunachal Pradesh	234	241	2.99	300	24.48
Nagaland	234	241	2.99	300	24.48
Himachal Pradesh*	236	247	4.66	300	21.46
Uttar Pradesh	237	252	6.33	300	19.05
Uttarakhand	237	252	6.33	300	19.05
Bihar	245	255	4.08	300	17.65
Jharkhand	245	255	4.08	300	17.65
Assam	249	256	2.81	300	17.19
Tripura	242	256	5.79	300	17.19
Sikkim	249	259	4.02	300	15.83

*(Non-scheduled areas) # for FY 27 in VB G RAM G wages; Source: notifications for respective years

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1andLachen -- will pay a fixed wage rate of Rs 450.

Why ‘hike’ not a hike

While the wage rates notified under the VB-G RAM G Act appear higher than the prevailing MGNREGA wages, it is because the government had not increased MGNREGA wages for 2026-27. The Centre last notified the MGNREGA wages on March 27 last year, which were applicable for the 2025-26 financial year, and continued with it during the first quarter (April-June) of the current fiscal year (2026-27). If the Centre had increased MGNREGA wages for the current financial year, the hike in VB-G RAM G wages would have been more or less the same.

Section 10 of the VB-G RAM

G Act empowers the Centre to specify wage rates for unskilled manual work provided under the Scheme. As per the Act, the Central government can notify different wage rates for different areas. The Act also mandates that the wage rate notified under the VB-G RAM G law shall not be less than the prevailing wage rate as notified under Section 6 of the MGNREGA, 2005.

How are wages fixed

The VB-G RAM G Act provides for the notification of different wage rates for different areas. Although the notification issued by the Union Ministry of Rural Development does not spell out the methodology used to determine the state-wise wage rates, it is understood that the Ministry adopted the prevailing MGNREGA wage rates as the basis.

Consequently, states such as Haryana, Goa and Kerala, which already had relatively high MGNREGA wage rates, have been assigned correspondingly higher wages under the VB-G RAM G Act, exceeding Rs 400 per day in all three states.

The Act further stipulates that the wage rate notified under the VB-G RAM G Act cannot be lower than the prevailing wage rate notified under Section 6 of the MGNREGA, 2005. It also provides that, until the Central government notifies wage rates under the new law, the wage rates notified under the MGNREGA will continue to apply.

This can be traced to the methodology adopted by the Rural Development Ministry for fixing state-wise wages.

When NREGA was enacted, it stipulated that wages could not be less than Rs 60 per day. It also provided that, until the Centre notified a wage rate for a particular area, the minimum wage for agricultural labourers fixed by the respective state governments under Section 3 of the Minimum Wages Act, 1948, would apply.

As a result, states such as Haryana, where the statutory minimum wage for agricultural labourers was already higher than Rs 60 per day, offered higher wages under the MGNREGA.

Subsequently, when the government linked MGNREGA wage revisions to the Consumer Price Index for Agricultural Labourers (CPI-AL) and established a minimum wage floor of Rs 100 per day, these states retained their wage advantage.

Consequently, Haryana has continued to record one of the highest wage rates under the rural employment guarantee scheme.

Low hikes for South

The lower hike in percentage terms for southern states may be because of two reasons. First, the base effect: these states already have high wage rates in absolute terms. Second, as VB-G RAM G wages have been fixed after taking into account the current MGNREGA wages and inflation, the regional variation is obvious.



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann with AAP leader Manish Sisodia during the launch of the scheme in Sangrur on Wednesday. ANI

Mann govt rolls out Rs 1,000 monthly aid scheme for women

Kanchan Vasdev
Chandigarh, July 1

PUNJAB CHIEF Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday rolled out its much-awaited flagship monthly financial assistance scheme for women — the Mawan Dhiyan Satkar Yojana — as multiple government departments and banks, in a coordinated exercise, ensured that the first instalment reached nearly 36 lakh beneficiaries’ accounts without a glitch. Calling the day “historic”, Mann said the scheme will pave the way for women empowerment.

“Women deserve the highest respect because they are the source of life itself. Strengthening women’s financial autonomy is essential for improving household welfare, promoting gender equity and enhancing women’s participation in social and economic

decision-making,” he said, adding that although the financial assistance may not make women rich, it would certainly provide them with dignity and self-respect.

“This is an ambitious scheme and we have launched it with complete planning to ensure that it continues permanently,” he said.

To ensure that the scheme was rolled out without a glitch, officials from the Social Security, Finance and Good Governance and Information Technology departments worked through Tuesday night to synchronise the transfer of funds so that women would receive SMS alerts from their banks while the Chief Minister was addressing the launch event from Dhuri, sources said.

Around 1,500 women invited to the launch function reportedly received bank messages during the event itself.

Warring stays on as Punjab Cong chief, Channi to head campaign

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, July 1

AFTER WEEKS of high-stakes meetings, observer missions and speculation over a leadership shake-up in Punjab, the Congress high command on Wednesday delivered a classic balancing act through a fresh set of election committee appointments. The exercise appeared carefully calibrated to placate rival factions while extending the tenures of embattled Punjab Congress chief Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly (LoP), Partap Singh Bajwa.

“I humbly congratulate and thank the party leadership for putting together a broad-based team of senior leaders to lead the crucial battle for the 2027 Punjab Vidhan Sabha elections. Together, all of us owe it to the people of Punjab to free them from the callous, authoritarian, autocratic and corrupt government that the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has been running for the last four and a half years,” Warring said.

He added that every member of the team had an important role to play in securing a decisive victory for the people



The appointments of Channi and Warring (right) reflect a balancing act aimed at accommodating competing factions



of Punjab.

The appointments, signed by AICC general secretary K C Venugopal, reflect a carefully crafted balancing act aimed at accommodating competing factions within the deeply divided Punjab Congress unit.

However, they also underscore the party high command’s prolonged indecision over making decisive leadership changes despite mounting internal pressure and repeated electoral setbacks.

Among the key appointments, former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh Channi was named chairperson of the campaign committee, Vijay Inder Singla will head the election management and coordination committee, Gurdaspur MP Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa will lead the core committee,

Iran govt invites Kharge, Khurshid to attend funeral of Khamenei

New Delhi: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and chairperson of the party Foreign Affairs department Salman Khurshid on Wednesday received invitations from the Iran government to attend the funeral of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in Iran next month. The party will send Khurshid, a former external affairs minister, to attend the funeral.

Bihar governor Syed Ata Hasnain and Minister of State for External Affairs Pabitra Margherita will also be in attendance at the funeral. They will be accompanied by officials from the Ministry of External Affairs. Khamenei’s funeral proceedings will begin in Tehran on July 4, and he will be laid to rest in his home town of Mashhad on July 9. ENS

EXPRESS special
How close is BJP to 2/3rd majority in Parliament? The numbers decoded

Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 1

AS THE TMC and the Shiv Sena (UBT) split in June, the pace at which these Opposition parties unravelled and the support of the breakaway groups for the BJP-led NDA alliance indicated that the ruling party was pushing hard to reach two-thirds majority in Parliament and amend the Constitution.

With the support of these additional MPs secured, the BJP can make another attempt to push through the constitutional amendment Bill on delimitation and operationalise the women’s reservation law in the coming Monsoon Session of Parliament. The government, on July 17, is also likely to introduce the 130th Constitution Amendment Bill that seeks to remove ministers following their arrest or detention for 30 consecutive days for serious offences.

The Opposition has opposed the government on both these issues and in April defeated the attempt to expand the size of the Lok Sabha and state Assemblies.

Article 368 says an amendment to the Constitution may be initiated “only by the introduction of a Bill for the purpose in either House of Parliament, and when the Bill is passed in each House by a majority of the total membership of that House and by a majority of not less than two-thirds of the members of

that House present and voting”. That means there are two conditions to be satisfied: such a Bill requires the support of at least 273 MPs in the Lok Sabha, which has a total membership of 545, and then two-thirds of members present and voting. If all 540 sitting MPs of the current Lok Sabha are present and vote, that would mean requiring at least 360 votes in favour.

In April, during voting on the Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026, 528 of 540 current Lok Sabha MPs participated, with 298 voting in its favour, 230 against it, and 11 MPs absent. The absentees, sources said, were seven TMC, two Congress, and two of the seven Independent MPs currently in prison.

While the NDA met the first condition, it fell short of the two-thirds mark of 352.

Barely weeks later, 20 rebel MPs of the TMC broke away and merged with the Nationalist Citizens Party of India. Along with six of the Shiv Sena (UBT)’s 9 MPs who joined the Shiv Sena led by Eknath Shinde, the NDA is now said to have the support of 318 to 319 Lok Sabha MPs, still 41 to 42 short of the 360 mark.

The BJP may also attempt to get the support of the DMK, which has 22 MPs and has been niffed with the Congress following its decision to break their alliance and join hands with the Vijay-led TVK in Tamil Nadu. In the DMK, certain sections are

learnt to be open to negotiating with the BJP “on specific issues”. Then there are the Independent MPs, who may play a crucial role.

Before defections occurred, the total strength of the INDIA alliance was 225 — including 98 for the Congress, Samajwadi Party 37, TMC 28, DMK 22, Shiv Sena (UBT) 9, NCP (Sharadchandra Pawar) 8, Left 8, RJD 4, three each for IUML, Jharkhand Mukti Morcha and AAP, and two MPs of the National Conference.

This bloc of MPs is down 26, following the TMC and Sena (UBT) splits. The NDA still has some distance to bridge. It can seek the support of a party such as the Jagan Mohan Reddy-led YSRCP that has 4 MPs and ensure that Opposition parties such as the NCP (SP) or the DMK, with a total of 30 MPs, either back it or abstain. That will bring down the special majority mark.

In this context, the role of the Independent MPs becomes important. However, among them, Amritpal Singh and Sheikh Abdul Rashid are currently in prison.

For instance, if the DMK and the NCP (SP) abstain, the two-thirds mark will be down to 330, leaving the NDA short by 11 votes. Theoretically, with the support of the YSRCP and the five Independents likely to be available to vote, the NDA will be left with only two votes to get.

FULL REPORT ON www.indianexpress.com

Bihar Cabinet gives nod to separate temple from Buxar jail premises, levy ‘user fees’ on highways

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, July 1

AMONG THE 29 decisions taken by the Bihar Cabinet on Wednesday, a proposal was approved to carve out the Lord Vaman Temple from the premises of the high-security Buxar Central Jail. The move aims to separate the shrine for structural development, beautification and public access while keeping prison security unaffected.

Under the decision, the state government has sanctioned the segregation of 1 acre and 90 decimals of land, measuring 600 feet by 138 feet, from the prison complex on which the temple stands. To insulate the active prison wings and maintain security, the Cabinet ap-



CM Samrat Chaudhary at an event in Patna, Wednesday. ANI

proved the construction of a 14-ft-high boundary wall with barbed wire on three sides of the newly designated temple complex.

The land will be carved out of the 19th-century prison, which has a sanctioned capac-

ity of around 1,600 inmates and currently houses over 1,000 prisoners across its 60-acre campus.

Earlier this year, then Bihar Deputy Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary visited Buxar during the Samridhi Yatra with then CM Nitish Kumar. Addressing the public, he had announced that the temple would soon be opened to devotees with necessary arrangements by the state government.

Among other decisions, the Bihar government has decided to levy “user fees” on state highways, a move aimed at ensuring the development and maintenance of roads, officials said on Wednesday.

“The decision aims to ensure the development, upgradation and maintenance of

roads across the state,” a senior official said.

The cabinet cleared the Road User Fee (Determination and Collection of Rates) Rules, 2026, paving the way for levying the charges. “The rules prescribe clear user fee rates for different vehicle categories and provide for an annual revision. Additionally, provisions have been made for exemptions for specified user categories, as well as concessional passes and frequent-user discounts for eligible users,” the proposal stated.

The cabinet also approved the allotment of government land for establishing five new Kendriya Vidyalayas in the state. A proposal to allot five acres of government land for each of the five new schools was cleared.

EXPRESS
Careers

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Advertisement No. 15/2025-26 (Non-Teaching Positions of Group 'C')

Banaras Hindu University invites online applications in the prescribed format from eligible candidates for appointment to Non-Teaching positions under Group 'C' in Faculty of Performing Arts/Mahila Mahavidyalaya/ Central Hindu Girls School.

The last date for online submission of the application form and payment of the application fee is **20.07.2026 up to 5:00 PM (IST)**.

For details of qualifications and other instructions, please visit the University website: <http://www.bhu.ac.in/rac>.

The duly completed download application form along with supporting documents must reach the office of the **Deputy Registrar, Recruitment & Assessment Cell, Holkar House, Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi 221005 on or before 25.07.2026 up to 5:00 PM..**

Date: 20.06.2026

REGISTRAR

BANARAS HINDU UNIVERSITY

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Advt. No. IMU/Estt./Recit./RP-025/2026-27

Date: 02.07.2026

Notice

Walk-in Interviews

It is to inform that, applications are invited from interested & eligible candidates to attend walk-in-interviews scheduled to be held on 10.07.2026 (Friday) from 10.00 hrs till 13.00 hrs for the post of Project Staff on contract basis under the research project titled "Study of Ship Hull Geometry Flow Noise" at the School of Naval Architecture and Ocean Engineering, Indian Maritime University, Visakhapatnam

Eligibility criteria, location of walk-in interview and other details for the said post can be obtained from www.imu.edu.in and www.imu.edu.in

-Sd-
Campus Director

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MA

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IMPORTANT DATE

Last date for online Registration **08/07/2026**

Registration Link <https://cuhadm.samarth.edu.in/>

For more details and updates please visit www.cuh.ac.in

REGISTRAR



Magnificent '56'

SPEAKING AT an event earlier this week to mark the 18th anniversary of the Sariska tiger reintroduction, Union Environment Minister Bhopender Yadav borrowed a popular film phrase to laud the population recovery of the big cats. Referring to the number of tigers in Sariska currently, Yadav said, "Ab tak chhapan ho gaye (There are 56 so far)," citing the title of the Nana Patekar-starrer film by the same name. Tongue firmly in cheek, he went on to say that some people have a problem with the figure '56', even though it is a good number.

'Lucky' Glasses

DURING SAMAJWADI Party president and Kannauj MP Akhilesh Yadav's birthday celebrations at the party office on Wednesday, SP's Faizabad (Ayodhya) MP Awadhesh Prasad arrived at the dais wearing dark glasses. Spotting him, Yadav first asked if he had an eye surgery and then smilingly remarked that he too had similar glasses. "*Kala chashma bahut shubh rehta hai* (Black glasses are very auspicious)," the SP chief said. Prasad wittily replied that when he had visited Yadav's place wearing black glasses in 2012, he had become the UP Chief Minister. He further said he was wearing the same black glasses with an eye on the 2027 polls. Sources said Prasad had recently undergone cataract surgery.

Himachal: HC stays dissolution of panchayats

Shimla: In a setback to the Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu-led dispensation, the Himachal Pradesh High Court has stayed the state government's decision to prematurely dissolve Panchayat Raj Institutions in the tribal areas of Lahaul-Spiti and the Pangti sub-division of Chamba, holding that the move prima facie curtailed the constitutionally protected five-year tenure of elected representatives. A Division Bench headed by Chief Justice Gurmeet Singh Sandhawalia on June 30 ordered a stay on the notification dated June 24. **ENS**

Rebel who never settled for No. 2: In centenary year, why Chandra Shekhar still matters



IN THIS season of anniversaries, when everything is being celebrated — recently, Prime Minister Narendra Modi completed 12 years or 4,399 days in office, overtaking Jawaharlal Nehru as the longest-serving elected PM — there is one that few are talking about. This year marks the centenary of the country's eighth PM Chandra Shekhar, who was born on April 17, 1927, in Ballia in present-day Uttar Pradesh.

Though some of Chandra Shekhar's followers are organising functions in his memory, there is no coordinated, collective effort to celebrate his legacy. Even the BJP, which has gone out of its way to give many leaders their due, has not attempted to celebrate the former PM, though his younger son, Neeraj Shekhar, is a BJP MP in the Rajya Sabha.

Satire part of politics, not always offensive: HC on Chadha's plea

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 1

THE DELHI High Court on Wednesday ruled that BJP Rajya Sabha member Raghav Chadha's plea objecting to alleged defamatory content against him "does not pertain to protection of personality rights".

While ruling that some of the content targeting Chadha was indeed defamatory, the court noted that satirical humour is inevitable in politics, and it "does not automatically make such content offensive or defamatory".

Chadha had attracted fierce criticism, including attacks and name-calling on social media, after he led an exodus of seven MPs of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) to the BJP on April 24.

He had objected to posts on social media that alleged he had "sold himself for money", and had moved the court seeking protection for his "personality

rights".

"Majority of the allegedly defamatory content appears to be satirical expressions of (Chadha's) decisions in the political sphere, and such decisions are likely to attract both bouquets and brickbats at the same time," Justice Subramonium Prasad said in his judgment.

"As observed in a catena of judgments, a public figure should not be so thin-skinned so as to complain about any criticism of his decisions and such criticism ought to be viewed with humility," Justice Prasad said.

"...Humour about change in political party alliances, governance, policies, etc. are a part and parcel of politics. Any action by a politician belonging to any political party will, in most, if not all circumstances, invite criticism from, upset, or create turmoil amongst, the general public or members from rival



The MP had moved the court seeking protection for his 'personality rights'

political parties, which may at times be expressed in the form of satirical humour...

"Public figures assuming such positions of power must accept being at the receiving end of the satirical humour as a necessary and inevitable aspect of their profession, though unpleasant," the court said.

The court, however, noted

that some of the alleged objectionable content flagged by Chadha did indeed "reek of malice, having a nature which maligns" his reputation.

Five of the 52 documents furnished by the MP contained "explicit content, which is profane and vulgar in nature, and fall outside the purview of harmless satirical humour", the court noted.

The court ordered that this defamatory material be taken down within two weeks.

Chadha had sought the court's relief against various entities who allegedly exploited his likeness, and sought the take-down of AI-generated and deepfake content allegedly circulating against him.

The court ruled that while Chadha's complaint was not covered under the ambit of personality rights, until such time as content generated by artificial intelligence (AI) was not regulated by legislation, it remained

a judicial duty to examine such grievances.

"...The court deems it fit to declare that this Court, in no way or manner, endorses the use of AI to produce deepfake videos, morphed images, etc., when employed to harm the dignity of an individual which would strike at the very root of their fundamental rights guaranteed under the Constitution of India..." it said.

The court acknowledged "that the use of AI has become an instrument for voicing opinions across social media platforms, which is fairly evident in the political context".

"...In this context, this Court believes that at least till the time most such content is not regulated by a stringent legislation, it becomes a judicial duty upon receipt of grievances such as those in the present suit to examine whether the use of AI has reached the threshold of infringing upon an individual's fundamental right to dignity or not.

TVK alleges bid by DMK to induce its MLAs; 3 arrested

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 1

BAREILY WEEKS after the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) steadily expanded its strength by inducting a stream of Opposition legislators, the party now finds itself making the very allegation its critics have levelled against it: that rival parties are attempting to induce or buy elected representatives.

On Wednesday, the Vijay government alleged that the DMK had orchestrated an attempt to induce TVK MLAs with offers running into crores to destabilise the government. Police arrested three persons, while investigators named former DMK minister V Senthil Balaji and his brother V Ashok Kumar as being allegedly linked to the conspiracy — allegations that the DMK is yet to respond to.

The complaint originated with TVK MLA N Elaiyaraja from Uthangarai, who told police that a man identifying himself as Thirunavukkarasu, claiming to represent an opinion polling organisation, contacted him, saying he was acting on behalf of "members of an important political party".

According to the complaint, Thirunavukkarasu allegedly proposed that Elaiyaraja vote against the Speaker if a resolution was moved in the Assembly and offered him Rs 35 crore in return. When the legislator refused, the caller allegedly warned him not to reveal the conversation and threatened



Since assuming office in May, CM C Joseph Vijay has steadily strengthened his numbers

consequences for him and his family.

Based on the complaint, Triplicane police arrested Thirunavukkarasu along with Naresh of Tiruchirappalli and Thiagarajan. Police said a preliminary investigation suggested that Naresh allegedly met Senthil Balaji's brother, Ashok Kumar, in Chennai, and that Thirunavukkarasu contacted the MLA at their behest.

Energy and Law Minister R Nirmalkumar escalated the political confrontation, alleging that not just one but "several" TVK MLAs had been approached over the past 40 days with offers of up to Rs 50 crore.

"That is why Stalin keeps repeatedly saying this government will not last long," Nirmalkumar alleged, accusing DMK president M K Stalin and Leader of Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin of attempting to engineer the fall of the government.

Since assuming office in May, CM C Joseph Vijay has steadily strengthened his numbers in the Assembly.



Open schooling body's Rs 247-cr vacant office may now get a tenant — in MEA

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, July 1

A RS 247 crore office property owned by the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) that has been lying vacant in Delhi for two years may soon find a tenant, with the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) showing interest in leasing at least one of the two floors at NBCC's World Trade Center in Nauroji Nagar.

The NIOS had purchased the office space in 2021, planning to relocate its headquarters from Noida, and took possession in March 2024. However, the autonomous education body has yet to move its operations and has been scouting for tenants.

According to sources, the MEA has written to Sanjay Kumar, Secretary, Department of School Education and Literacy, which is the nodal department for the NIOS under the Ministry of Education, to take one of the floors on rent.

The May 25 letter from Vikram Misri, Foreign Secretary, comes three weeks after The Indian Express reported on May 4 that despite spending Rs 247 crore in 2021 and having received possession in 2024, the NIOS had not moved into the premium office space.

The MEA, sources said, wants to rent the space for its public service delivery divisions that provide passport, consular, emigration, and diaspora-related services. These MEA divisions, sources added, are "facing acute shortage" of office accom-



The ministry has shown interest in leasing at least one of the two floors at NBCC's World Trade Center in Nauroji Nagar

modation and are currently spread over five different locations in the national capital.

According to a source, the MEA stated in its letter that the scattered arrangement has led to "operational challenges, including difficulties in coordination, delays in communication and inconvenience to the visitors seeking consular, diplomatic/official passport and visa services". Therefore, it added, the integration of these divisions at a single location could help improve efficiency, streamline functioning, and enhance public service delivery.

The source further said that, MEA in its letter on May 25 said that as they were exploring possible options for creating a dedicated separate office space for the divisions handling citizen-centric services and diaspora work, their "enquiries revealed that the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) has ac-

quired two floors in NBCC's World Trade Centre in Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi and may be interested in leasing out at least one of the two floors acquired by them". It further stated that the location of the property is not very far from the MEA Headquarters at Jawaharlal Nehru Bhavan, and the available carpet area per floor of 22,316 sq ft perfectly matches the MEA's space requirements. The MEA sought to take on lease "at least 1 floor out of the 2 floors on a long-term basis on mutually agreeable terms and conditions".

After a month, Kumar wrote to the NIOS Chairperson on June 30, seeking comments and views on the MEA's request.

The NIOS, which is mandated to educate underprivileged children, receives no budgetary support from the Centre. It funds itself entirely through admission and examination fees.

Those not in voters' list cannot get govt money: Bengal CM

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 1

LAUNCHING THE Annapurna Yojana, a direct cash transfer scheme for women in West Bengal, Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari on Wednesday said that 26 lakh applications for the scheme were rejected because the applicants' names were not on the voters' list.

Asserting that "government money cannot be received by any non-Indian", the chief minister said, "Twenty-six lakh forms submitted under the Annapurna scheme have been rejected. Screening was necessary... These 26 lakh women are not Indian, and their names are not on the voters' list. Some are dead, some do not have voter ID cards, and some had their names listed in three places. Such names have been removed. Government money cannot be received by any non-Indian."

The CM said the first tranche of funds under the Annapurna scheme was credited to the accounts of nearly 1.1 crore bene-

'No grievance so far': HC on plea against ration denial over SIR

THE CALCUTTA High Court on Wednesday reprimanded a farm labourers' union over its petition challenging the BJP government's decision to deny ration benefits to those excluded from the electoral rolls after the SIR exercise, stating "not a single grievance" has been voiced by anyone yet.

The Division Bench said, "Not a single petition has been filed by anyone who is deprived, but your organisation is crying. No grievance has been ventilated by any person before any court so far." **ENS**

ficiaries of the state. "We will not discontinue the existing welfare schemes of the government and will not deprive any eligible applicants of their rights."



Chandra Shekhar flanked by P V Narasimha Rao and V P Singh. FILE

one-man party he became in Parliament towards the end, speaking against economic liberalisation. He was one of the dying breeds of politicians, a dhakad (formidable) leader who stuck his neck out for what he believed in.

Soon after he joined the Congress in 1965, he was introduced to Indira. She was the Information and Broadcasting Minister under Lal Bahadur Shastri at the time. Current Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairperson Harivansh Singh has written in the biography of Chandra Shekhar, which he co-authored, that Mrs Gandhi asked the young leader why he

had joined the party. To this, he replied that he wanted to give the Congress a socialist turn. She asked what he would do if he did not succeed, to which Chandra Shekhar said, "In that case, I will try and break the Congress." When a stunned Mrs Gandhi asked, "Why?", the young Chandra Shekhar said, "It has become a banyan tree under which nothing new can grow."

But first, in 1969, he assisted Mrs Gandhi in breaking the party, freeing it from the grip of the old guard and helping her become the real Congress. She went on to become the "Durga" and he the "Young Turk". There-

juvenation of the Congress remains as much of a live issue now as it was then.

The what-ifs

In one of my conversations with Chandra Shekhar, I asked him what he would have done had he been the PM on December 6, 1992, when kar sevaks demolished the Babri Masjid. He said he would have never allowed it to happen. But when pointed out that thousands would have likely died that day if force had been used to stop the kar sevaks, he reiterated what he said. Even the officials who worked with him, such as Cabinet Secretary Naresh Chandra and Shyam Saran who later became the Foreign Secretary, believed he would have taken a tough stand.

Many believe the Congress pulled the plug on his government because he had come close to resolving the Ayodhya dispute through dialogue, which veered around building the temple at the disputed spot, but with an assurance that the Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) would not raise issues like Kashi and Mathura in the future. Thirty-six years later, Mathura is being raked up again

as the Ram Janmabhoomi Trust finds itself charged with "chanda chori" of crores of rupees of "charhava" donated by devotees.

Realising that his minority government might not have much time, he had reached out to both the VHP and the Babri Masjid Action Committee on the first day he took over as PM in November 1990. At the time, Rajiv Gandhi was told by his advisors that if Chandra Shekhar succeeded, he would not only become nationally popular but also make inroads into the Congress, where he enjoyed goodwill, having once been a part of it. Soon thereafter, two Haryana sub-inspectors were found "snooping" around 10 Janpath, and the Congress pulled the plug.

Implicit in Chandra Shekhar's strength was also his weakness: he did not want to be number two under anyone. In 1977, he did not become a minister under Morarji Desai and chose to become the party chief. When Babu Jagjivan Ram exited the Congress in 1977 to form the Congress for Democracy, which supported the Janata Dal, he invited the Young

Turks to join his group. But Chandra Shekhar decided against it. Had they teamed up, Jagjivan Ram's chances of becoming the PM, instead of Desai, may have improved. When VP became the PM, Chandra Shekhar was offered the Deputy PM's post. But he could not reconcile with working under VP, who was far junior to him in the Congress but had outpaced him.

History is an aggregate of hits and misses. It is tantalising to think of what kind of leadership Chandra Shekhar might have provided if he had a majority on his own. Equally tantalising — and this is a question posed by some — is what he would have done had he been around now, a contemporary of the likes of Sharad Pawar, Mallikarjun Kharge, and Farooq Abdullah. My hunch is that if he were alive today, he would have poured all his energy into bringing together the fragmented Opposition on a common platform.

(Neeraj Chowdhury, Contributing Editor, The Indian Express, has covered the last 11 Lok Sabha elections. She is the author of How Prime Ministers Decide.)

FAKE DRUGS RACKET

IPS officer held for demanding Rs 3 cr bribe to ‘fix’ CBI case

Delhi court asks the CBI why it did not question Gahlawat on ‘role of its officers’

Mahender Singh Manral & Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 1

THE CBI has arrested a 2012-batch IPS officer of Haryana cadre for allegedly accepting a bribe of Rs 1 crore in connection with the Puducherry counterfeit medicine racket. The development comes a month after the agency arrested two men, including a Delhi Police inspector, in connection with the racket.

The IPS officer, Deepak Gahlawat, allegedly told the prime accused in the case, N Raja alias Valliappan alias Rajasekhar, that he could “arrange” relief in the CBI case through his “connections” within the agency. Gahlawat allegedly demanded Rs 3 crore from Raja in the Rs 5,000-crore counterfeit medicine racket in Puducherry. He had allegedly already taken Rs 1 crore from Raja, the source said.

A Delhi court Wednesday asked the CBI why it didn’t question Gahlawat about the “role of CBI officers” in the alleged Rs 3 crore bribery case. “Are you trying to mislead the court? Of course you are. Why didn’t you ask him? He’s joined probe four times. He has been with you for 24 hours... Is there any explanation why you didn’t ask about who (which CBI officers) had to be influenced,” Special Judge Sushant Changotra, Rouse Avenue Court, asked CBI’s IO during a hearing on Gahlawat’s remand.

“The answer to queries posed to the IO today makes it apparent that till date no effort has been made in the probe as to whether any public servant

who was posted in CBI was ever approached by accused Deepak Gahlawat or if he had made any attempt to exercise his public influence over such public servants. The IO made no endeavour to ascertain as to whether such a person existed or the identity of this public servant. The conduct of the IO in this respect and the responses given by him today are totally unfathomable,” he said.

Gahlawat, who was in the courtroom, said, “From May to June, I never called any of my acquaintances in CBI. Not a single call... There isn’t a single penny recovered from my account.” The court granted the CBI one-day custodial interrogation of Gahlawat. Gahlawat is serving as a Regional Director with the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA).

A source said that after identifying Gahlawat and informing his department, the CBI summoned him and questioned him multiple times. “We have arrested him and are probing the role of his internal contacts in the agency,” the source said.

“Earlier, the CBI had arrested the accused Delhi Police Inspector along with six other private persons, which led to the recovery of nearly Rs 25 lakh of trap amount and Rs 90 lakh, along with other incriminating documents seized during the probe,” a spokesperson said. The counterfeit and spurious medicines manufacturing operation was uncovered following raids by police and the CB-CID in Puducherry last year. Raja was arrested in December.

Gen Dhiraj Seth takes over as Army Chief, unveils ‘VIJAY’ roadmap

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 1

ASSUMING CHARGE as the 31st Chief of Army Staff on Wednesday, General Dhiraj Seth underlined the need to take forward the modernisation of the Army with “renewed energy and firm resolve to respond effectively to the evolving security environment.” He said the aim is to build a technology-enabled, future-ready Army “which is fully empowered and capable of operating across multiple domains.”

Stating that the Army is a combat-ready and battle-hardened force, fully prepared and capable of meeting every challenge in the operational domain, he listed his focus areas in the acronym ‘VIJAY’, of which ‘V’ stands for Vigilance along borders and against emerging threats.

Gen Seth said that ‘I’ stands for Innovation and Transformation and that his focus will be on innovation in both doctrine and technological solutions. “Innovation will remain an integral part of our thinking, our systems and our capability development. At the same time, necessary transformations will be undertaken in keeping with the changing character of warfare.”

‘J’ stands for Jointness and Integration, Gen Seth said, adding that to enhance the operational effectiveness of the Indian Army, “we will maintain complete synergy and coordination with the Indian Air Force and the Indian Navy.”

“I fully recognise that national security is not limited to military strength alone. It requires military-civil fusion and a whole-of-nation approach. This integrated approach will also enable us to contribute meaningfully to nation building and to the goal of

Free Whatsapp Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1



Chief of Army Staff Gen Dhiraj Seth inspects the guard of honour in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBGYAL
Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

In leadership reshuffle, CISC and Vice-Chiefs take charge

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, July 1

SENIOR INDIAN military leadership Wednesday saw a series of changes with top officers of the Army and Air Force taking over critical appointments in the Armed Forces.

General Dhiraj Seth took over as the 31st Chief of Army Staff. He is the third Army Chief from the 2nd Lancers, one of the oldest armoured regiments in the country, and the first Armoured Corps officer to be appointed as the Army Chief in the last 30 years after General Shankar Roy Chowdhury (1994-97).

Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, who has been serving as the Chief of Integrated Defence Staff (CISC), took over as the Vice-Chief of the Air Staff after the retirement of Air Marshal Nagesh Kapoor.

Commissioned into the

fighter stream of the IAF on December 6, 1986, Air Marshal Dixit has extensive flying experience on various aircraft such as the Mirage-2000, variants of MiGs, HPT-32, An-32, Avro, Kiran, Jaguar, IL-78, Hawk and Tejas.

He is an Experimental Test Pilot and a Qualified Flying Instructor and has been actively involved in numerous operations and exercises such as Op Safed Sagar, Op Rakshak, Cope India and Op Sindoor.

On Wednesday, Lt Gen Sandeep Jain, formerly the Southern Army Commander, also took charge as the Army’s Vice-Chief; while Air Marshal Tejinder Singh became the new CISC.

Additionally, Lt Gen Mohit Malhotra and Lt Gen Rajesh Pushkar assumed command of the Army’s Jaipur-based South Western Command and the Pune-based Southern Command.

BRIEFLY



BRO personnel use excavators to clear debris from the Manali-Leh Highway after flash floods, in Lahaul & Spiti district, Wednesday. PTI

HIMACHAL PRADESH

6 dead, several roads blocked as monsoon reaches Himachal

WITH ITS advance in Himachal Pradesh on Wednesday, the Southwest Monsoon already claimed six lives and caused losses estimated at Rs 44.40 lakh during the first 24 hours, according to the State Emergency Operations Centre (SEOC). According to a revenue department report, the highest monetary loss worth Rs 24 lakh was recorded in Mandi district, followed by a loss of Rs 16 lakh in Kangra. Crop loss amounting to Rs 20.4 lakh was also reported. The SEOC also reported that 35 roads remain blocked and 127 distribution transformers are out of service. ENS

Demolition of Surat shanties: Five suspended

FIVE OFFICIALS of the Surat Municipal Corporation were on Thursday suspended in connection with the controversial demolition of several shanties in the city’s Nasir-nagar area in May, with the matter having reached the Gujarat HC. Some of the residents have moved court alleging that due process was not followed during demolition drive and they were not issued any notices beforehand. A departmental inquiry has been initiated on basis of findings of an internal inquiry committee. ENS

Fresh ethnic tension in two Manipur villages

FRESH ETHNIC tensions gripped the Indo-Myanmar border in Kamjong district of Manipur on Wednesday after armed miscreants attacked two villages, police said. Police said unidentified miscreants arrived at Phaimol Kuki village around 12:30 pm and torched all the houses, sparing the church. The attack on Phaimol Kuki village triggered retaliatory violence, with another group targeting Shangkhak Tangkhul village barely an hour later. No casualties have been reported. ENS

Expedite release, repatriation of 188 fishermen and prisoners: India to Pakistan

Divya A
New Delhi, July 1

INDIA HAS urged Pakistan to expedite the release and repatriation of 188 Indian fishermen and civil prisoners who have completed their sentences, the MEA said on Wednesday.

“As a result of sustained efforts by the government of India, 2,661 Indian fishermen and 78 Indian civil prisoners have been repatriated from Pakistan since 2014,” the MEA said. These include 500 fishermen and 20 civil prisoners who have been repatriated from Pakistan since 2023.

India has also shared with Pakistan a list of 386 civil prisoners and 53 fishermen, believed to be Pakistani nationals, in its custody. Under the provisions of the Agreement on Consular Access signed between India and Pakistan in 2008, such lists are exchanged every year on January 1 and July 1. “India and Pakistan today exchanged, through diplomatic channels simultaneously in New Delhi and Islamabad, the lists of civil prisoners and fishermen in each other’s custody,” the MEA said.

Under the framework, Pakistan has also shared a list of 52 civil prisoners and 198 fishermen, believed to be Indian nationals, in its custody. Delhi has consistently called for the early release and repatriation of civil prisoners, fishermen along with their boats and missing Indian defence personnel from Pakistan’s custody. “Pakistan has been urged to expedite the release and repatriation of 188 Indian fishermen and civil prisoners, who have completed their sentences. In addition, Pakistan has been asked to provide immediate consular access to the 13 civil prisoners in Pakistan’s custody, who are believed to be Indian and have not been provided consular access so far.”

Indian has also urged Pakistan to ensure the safety and welfare of all Indians and believed to be Indian prisoners, pending their release and repatriation to India. According to Pakistan’s statement, Islamabad handed over to the Indian High Commission a list of 250 Indian prisoners in Pakistan, comprising 52 civilians and 198 fishermen.

Toddlers locked in washing machine, bathrooms: Five creche employees booked

Kiran Parashar
Bengaluru, July 1

CHILDREN UNDER two years old put inside a front-load washing machine, locked in bathrooms, sprayed with toilet jet sprays and physically intimidated into silence. These were some of the visuals captured on CCTV cameras, based on which five staff at a baby care centre of a major technology services company were booked by the Bengaluru police.

The complainant, Tilakesh Kumar, a legal-cum-probation officer, district child protection unit, said the baby care centre staff allegedly assaulted and ill-treated toddlers, some only a few months old, left by employees of Capgemini Technology Services India, Brookfield campus, while they were at work.

Following the FIR, Capgemini has temporarily shut down its facility. In its statement, the

firm said, “Capgemini’s foremost priority is the health, safety and wellbeing of its employees and their families. We are cooperating fully with the authorities... As a precautionary measure, we are temporarily closing the Bengaluru on-campus daycare facility.”

Police have registered an FIR under BNS Section 351(2) (criminal intimidation) as well as Section 75 (cruelty to child) of the Juvenile Justice Act. The five caregivers named in the FIR are Manjula, Vijayalakshmi, Bhavani, Sindhu and Bindu. Tilakesh said he received videos via WhatsApp showing very small children crying and being subjected to abuse, which prompted him to file a complaint at the HAL police station on June 29.

DCP (Whitefield Division) Saidulu Advath said they will issue notices to the people involved, including one of the creche in charges.

Bashaarat Masood & Kanchan Vasudev
Srinagar, Chandigarh, July 1

FOR THE last few weeks, Abdul Rashid Bhat has been worried. His daughter is getting married in two weeks, but he has been informed of a problem: a shortage of mutton in meat-loving Kashmir. “Our butcher has informed us about the crisis,” he tells *The Indian Express*. “We have delayed the distribution of invitation cards for now. We hope the issue will be resolved by the time she gets married.”

Kashmir is facing an unusual problem: a shortage of mutton caused by Punjab’s levy on vehicles carrying livestock to the Valley. The levy, which traders claim began last year, has meant they have to shell out to Rs 25,000 per truck at the border. Mutton, as a result, has also become more expensive — Rs 750 per kg from Rs 700. The crisis could not have come at a worse time: it has directly hit Kashmir’s ongoing marriage season, from April to October, leading to mutton dishes disappearing from the traditional Kashmiri multi-

course meal, wazwan.

Officials call the levy “illegal and arbitrary”. In his letter to Punjab counterpart Bhagwant Mann, J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah sought intervention for the “smooth, secure and unhindered” movement of livestock transport vehicles. On the ground, the impact is visible. “Our sheep mandis (markets) are closed for the ninth straight day today,” Meraj-ud-din Ganai, general secretary of Kashmir Mutton Dealers Association, told *The Indian Express*. “We understand that it is wedding season, but we are helpless.”

With close to 90% of the population being meat-eaters, Kashmir has one of the highest per capita mutton consumption rates in India — over 600 lakh kg every year, according to official data. More than half of this comes from sheep brought in from Haryana, Delhi and Rajasthan. Traders said that mutton dealers import 40-50 vehicles carrying sheep (around 8,000 animals) every day, though demand rises to 60-70 vehicles (around 11,000 sheep) during the peak wedding season.



Mutton dishes have been disappearing from Kashmir’s traditional wazwan this marriage season, from April-October. SHAWAN SARKAR

For its part, Punjab officials call it a “cattle mandi tax” — a levy states impose on livestock purchased from local markets. “The issue is not about the imposition of any new tax, but relates to alleged evasion of mandi fees and other prescribed charges in Punjab’s cattle markets. In several cases, cattle are being transported to other states without adherence to regulations, leading to revenue losses,” one Punjab official said.

But J&K traders said Punjab is merely a transit state and they are thus not liable to pay the tax. “Our livestock vehicles coming from Haryana, Delhi and other states are stopped at entry and exit points in Punjab... Earlier, they would charge Rs 5,000 but with every passing day, they are raising the tax. They are charging us as high as Rs 25,000 sometimes and it is becoming untenable,” a trader said.

The levy has prompted CM

{ VIJAYA MEHTA • 1934-2026 }

Doyen of realism & experiment, she gave new shape to Marathi theatre

Dipanita Nath
Mumbai, July 1

IN 1953, Mumbai’s Wilson College staged William Shakespeare’s *Othello*, and in the audience was a brave young actor-director who would go on to become a legend in Indian theatre, Ebrahim Alkazi.

As he watched the play, Alkazi’s keen eye picked out Desdemona, the heroine who encapsulates a woman’s tragedy as she pleads with her jealous and murderous husband in her dying moments, “Banish me, my lord, but kill me not”. Alkazi asked ‘Desdemona’ to join his ensemble, Theatre Group, which was, at the time, creating the most powerful plays in then Bombay. The actor was Vijaya Jaywant, a final-year student at

Wilson College. She later became famous as Vijaya Mehta, the doyenne of realism and experiment, who gave a new shape to Marathi theatre.

Working in the newly Independent India, she helped open up the imagination of artists across the country and experience the best theatre practices from around the world. Vijaya became the chairperson of India’s prestigious theatre academy, the National School of Drama (NSD) in Delhi and the Film and Television Institute of India (FTII) in Pune. For a decade-and-a-half, she was the Executive Director of the National Centre for the Performing Arts in Mumbai.

Vijaya passed away on June 30 at her Mumbai residence due to age-related ailments. She was

91. She is survived by a daughter, actor-director Anahita Uberoi, and sons Ravi Khote, a singer, and Deven Khote, a filmmaker and producer.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi described her as a pioneer of modern Marathi theatre, recognised for her unwavering dedication to creativity and artistic excellence. “As a towering figure in the fields of culture and cinema, she will always be remembered,” he posted on X.

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnis said: “The passing away of Vijaya Mehta marks the end of a defining chapter of a generation in the world of performing arts.” She left an indelible mark on theatre and cinema through her work as an actor, director and producer.

Anuradha Kapur, theatre



Vijaya Mehta died on June 30 due to age-related ailments

director and former director of NSD remembered Vijaya as one of the greatest theatre makers of modern India. “Her theatre language was both cosmopolitan and rooted — she handled Sanskrit text as also Brecht and modern Indian texts with equal elan,” said Kapur.

The daughter of a middle-class Maharashtrian family from Vadodara, Gujarat, Vijaya found her stage presence early. Among her influences were Alkazi and the doyen of Parsi theatre, Adi Pherozeshah Marzban. Her professional Marathi theatre experience began with Govind Ballal Deval’s Marathi adaptation of *Othello*, *Junjarao*, in 1955. In 1960, she began her landmark journey with Rangayan, a group that she co-founded with playwrights Vijay Tendulkar and Mahesh Elkunchwar and actor-director Arvind Deshpande.

“With Rangayan, an entirely new sensibility was introduced in Marathi theatre. Vijayabai used to act in English theatre during the time of Alkazi. She had studied at the Royal Academy of Dramatic

Arts in London and was a trained actor. She was also a part of the socialist movement, Rashtriya Seva Dal,” said eminent playwright Satish Alekar.

Famous actor Durga Khote was her mother-in-law. After her first husband’s untimely death, Vijaya married Farrokh Mehta, who was from Mumbai’s English-language theatre scene. She brought all these influences and a kind of discipline and professionalism to Marathi theatre that had been lacking, Alekar said.

Alekar called Vijaya a “flawless actor”. “She performed in all kinds of theatre, from traditional Marathi musicals to historical pieces to commercial plays as well as the radical, thought-provoking plays of Rangayan,” he said. Actor Shreeram Lagoo, reportedly, moved from his home-

town Pune to Mumbai to work with Vijaya. Vijaya, who attended theatre festivals and created collaborations with international directors, helped several artists conduct workshops in India. Among them were English theatre director and filmmaker Peter Brook and Eugene Barba from Denmark. She had a legendary collaboration with East German director Fritz Bennewitz, producing works such as *Ajab Nyaya Cartulacha*, an adaptation of Bertolt Brecht’s *The Caucasian Chalk Circle*.

For a generation of young theatre artists, she was a mother figure who was particular about details, from how to design a play to the finer points of set creation to making compositions. With her demise, an era ends in Indian theatre.



The Indian EXPRESS

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Signs of resilience, but risks need monitoring

IN THE fourth quarter of the last financial year, the Indian economy grew at a healthy pace, despite widespread disruptions to energy markets and global trade in March due to the West Asia conflict. In the months thereafter, even as the conflict dragged on, some of the high-frequency indicators suggest that the economic momentum has sustained to an extent. This is evident in e-way bill generation, PMI indices and electricity consumption, as the finance ministry’s latest monthly economic review points out. However, as the report also notes, there are some signs of moderation. For instance, the index of eight core industries grew by just 1.1 per cent during April-May.

India entered this crisis with high growth, low inflation and strong bank and corporate balance sheets. These, as RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra notes in the latest financial stability report, have “helped preserve macro-financial stability”. The health of the financial system can be gauged across a range of indicators. Banks have seen a decline in bad loans — gross NPAs were at 1.8 per cent in March 2026, there were no signs of any build-up in stress. Their capital position remained comfortable — capital to risk weighted assets ratio was at 17.7 per cent — the liquidity buffers were strong and profitability indicators stable. In fact, the stress tests conducted by the central bank suggest that banks can cope with adverse shocks. Funding, though, is a challenge. Similarly, the corporate sector also appears to be in sound health. Leverage continued to fall, while its ability to service its debt obligations showed improvement. Yet, despite this, private corporate investments remain depressed. Alongside, as household debt has continued to edge upwards — standing at 45.5 per cent by the end of September last year — it is a matter of concern that borrowing for consumption purposes, not asset creation, is the key driver of loans.

Uncertainty around West Asia persists. A deficient monsoon so far has impacted kharif sowing, while a strengthening El Niño may pose risks for the ensuing winter-spring rabi crop. Going by the prolonged food inflation during 2023-24, which was also an El Niño year, this could have implications for inflation and demand — between July 2023 and December 2024, food inflation averaged 8.5 per cent. These internal and external risks need close monitoring.

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Trump could use new tools after court snub

THE US Supreme Court’s decision to uphold birthright citizenship comes as a blow to President Donald Trump’s crusade against immigration and a reprieve for millions of immigrants, including the Indian diaspora. The executive order, signed on his first day back in office last year, sought to deny citizenship to children born in the US if neither parent was a US citizen or lawful permanent resident, including those whose parents were legally in the country on temporary visas. But the text of the Constitution — the Fourteenth Amendment — is unambiguous, reinforced by well over a century of legal precedent: People born in the US are citizens. Few expected the court to endorse the Trump administration’s argument that children born to parents who entered illegally were not “subject to the jurisdiction” of the US and not entitled to citizenship. But even in defeat, Trump has succeeded in politicising birthright citizenship, an issue that was once the subject of broad bipartisan consensus in America.

The US is home to an estimated 5.4 million people of Indian origin — the largest Indian diaspora — accounting for roughly 1.6 per cent of the US population. After Mexicans, Indians constitute the second-largest immigrant group. They are not only the largest recipients of H-1B visas but also the nationality most affected by employment-based green card backlogs because of caps that are country-specific. Many professionals spend years, even decades, waiting for a permanent status, raising families while on temporary visas. Without birthright citizenship, children born during that period would enter the same uncertain immigration pipeline as their parents. Trump’s order was also detrimental to America’s own interests. Foreign-born workers make up nearly one-fifth of the US labour force, and a sharp reduction would carry significant economic costs.

Trump has threatened to use Congress to abolish birthright citizenship in response to the court verdict. Even if the constitutional guarantee survives, it is only one setback for an administration that has already enacted hundreds of immigration restrictions, contributing to net migration to the US turning negative for the first time in half a century. The Supreme Court’s judgment may have preserved one of America’s oldest constitutional promises, but immigrants remain vulnerable and Trump’s crackdown on immigration is far from over.

A bit like a volcano, AI walks through the door

ADOG walked into a tavern and said, “I can’t see a thing. I’ll open this one.” That’s it — that’s the joke. To get the humour, one would need cultural context from one of the oldest civilisations, Sumer (c. 3300-1900 BCE). Missing context is one of the ways in which an ancient text, though present, may still be “lost”. In other cases, the text’s physical condition may prevent it from being read. For instance, the eruption of Mt Vesuvius in Italy in 79 CE led to a whole library of scrolls being carbonised and preserved, but left too fragile to open. Until AI walked in and said, “I’ll open this one.”

A scroll from the Herculaneum library has now been “unwrapped”, though not literally — it was scanned using high-resolution X-rays, virtually reconstructed and flattened so that a machine-learning tool could bring out the traces of ink, allowing scholars to read the text. It turned out to be a treatise on ethics, perhaps authored by the Stoic philosopher Chrysippus. Hundreds of scrolls remain to be opened, and both the data and the code are open to all. Classicists are chomping at the bit, talking about all the ancient texts they dream of rediscovering. Some have brought up the lost dialogues of Aristotle, called a “river of gold” by Cicero. The nerdiest may yearn for the dictionary of the Etruscan language written by the nerdiest of emperors, Claudius.

This speaks to the duality of AI in academia: While it has arrived as a menace in the classroom, the possibilities it opens up for both scientists and humanities researchers are mouth-watering. It’s destruction and preservation wrapped up in one — a bit like a volcanic eruption.

As US reshapes its Asia strategy, India must rewire its regional leadership

THE UNITED STATES is reshaping its Asia strategy as it accepts that China can no longer be contained at an acceptable economic or military cost. This shift is reducing India’s strategic importance in Washington’s calculations while expanding US engagement across South Asia. As both the US and China compete for influence in India’s neighbourhood, New Delhi must act to preserve its strategic autonomy and rewire regional leadership.

The shift in American approach is driven by declining influence and a series of strategic setbacks. In Europe, the Ukraine war has imposed high financial and military costs on Washington, which now wants European nations to shoulder more of NATO’s burden. In the Middle East, the Iran war proved costly for the US. Iran was not subdued, while attacks on US bases in Gulf countries weakened confidence in America’s security guarantees and made close ties with Washington appear riskier for regional stability. Old US partners such as Saudi Arabia and the UAE are expanding ties with China.

In the Indo-Pacific, despite housing thousands of troops and maintaining military alliances with Japan, South Korea, Australia, and many ASEAN countries, and being part of frameworks such as the Quad and the Australia-UK-US Security Partnership, the US faces a different reality. China has become the largest trading partner for most economies in the region, and Asian manufacturing supply chains remain deeply tied to Chinese industry. This economic dependence has made many governments reluctant to fully align with US strategic objectives against Beijing. Malaysia’s

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withdrawal from the trade deal with the US is an example.

As Washington recognises these limits, its China strategy is changing. Instead of trying to contain Beijing, it increasingly appears to be treating China as a de facto equal — a G2 partner. In the Asia-Pacific, the US is seeking to preserve its influence without openly confronting China. It has become noticeably quieter on issues such as the Quad and Taiwan to avoid provoking Beijing.

Washington’s view of India is also undergoing a shift. For nearly two decades, India was central to Washington’s Indo-Pacific strategy and the Quad was a democratic counterweight to China. However, Washington now sees India not as a key strategic partner but more as a large market for American goods and technology and a subordinate partner. The February 7 US-India joint statement calls for India to align its economic and security interests more closely with those of America. Strategic co-operation is increasingly giving way to greater US strategic influence over India.

The US now appears to be following China’s playbook by expanding its engagement across South Asia. China has spent more than a decade building its “string of pearls” through ports, infrastructure financing and connectivity projects in countries around India. Its regional presence now includes the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, Gwadar Port, Hambantota Port, Colombo Port City, Belt and Road projects in Nepal, major investments in Bangladesh and infrastructure projects across the Maldives.

Rather than treating South



AJAY SRIVASTAVA

India cannot stop great-power rivalry in South Asia, but must avoid becoming an object of external power-politics. It should preserve strategic autonomy by keeping relations with both Washington and Beijing transactional

Asia as India’s natural sphere of influence, Washington is deepening defence, maritime, digital and infrastructure cooperation with Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal and the Maldives. The appointment of Sergio Gor as both US Ambassador to India and Special Envoy for South and Central Asia reinforces the impression that Washington increasingly views South Asia as an integrated strategic space rather than through an India-centric lens.

This competition will give Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka and the Maldives greater leverage to play India, China and the US against one another to extract economic and political concessions.

Both Washington and Beijing also have an interest in keeping Pakistan strategically relevant as a counterweight to India. Pakistan has positioned itself as a swing state by maintaining close ties with the US, China, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Turkey and Iran. As the world’s only nuclear-armed Muslim country, it holds growing strategic value in West Asia. Its ability to engage both Sunni states (Saudi Arabia, Qatar, the United Arab Emirates, Kuwait and Turkey) and Shia states (primarily Iran) further strengthens its regional influence. As the US and China view Pakistan as an important partner, India’s strategic environment becomes more challenging.

While India’s trade surplus with South Asia has grown from about US\$6.7 billion to nearly US\$20 billion over the past two decades, its political and strategic challenges remain. SAARC is largely dysfunctional, and relations with Bangladesh, Nepal and the Maldives con-

tinue to fluctuate. Pakistan is a failed state thriving on external steroids. Intensifying US-China competition is likely to deepen these challenges.

India cannot stop great-power rivalry in South Asia, but must avoid becoming an object of external power-politics. The play book is simple. India must strengthen its economic base by prioritising manufacturing, artificial intelligence, semiconductors, critical minerals, defence production, and other advanced industries, while reducing its dependence on imported industrial inputs from China.

It should preserve strategic autonomy by keeping relations with both Washington and Beijing transactional and judging each issue on its merits. India must build connectivity projects, more responsive development partnerships and consistent political engagement with most neighbours.

Finally, India must avoid actions that create confusion about its longstanding positions. For example, India has consistently rejected third-party mediation with Pakistan, as it did by dismissing US President Donald Trump’s claim of mediation during Operation Sindoor. It should therefore avoid forums that invite outside powers into South Asian affairs. India’s high-level participation in the June 25-26 South Asia Dialogue in Colombo, alongside representatives from Pakistan, the US, the UK, Sri Lanka and the Maldives, blurred that position.

At a time when both Washington and Beijing are expanding their influence in South Asia, India should avoid actions that could be seen as accepting a larger role for external powers in its neighbourhood.

The writer is founder, GTRI

PPP 2.0 should focus on matching capital to risk



ARVIND MAYARAM

TWENTY YEARS ago, I was among those involved in developing India’s public-private partnership (PPP) framework. It transformed airports, highways and ports, but also produced stressed assets following the global financial crisis and the domestic slowdown. As confidence waned, public capital expenditure replaced PPPs as the principal model for financing infrastructure. That retreat was understandable. It was also a mistake.

Today, India faces a challenge far greater than the one we confronted two decades ago. By March 2025, the infrastructure pipeline had expanded to more than 13,000 projects with an aggregate value approaching Rs 185 lakh crore. Yet this is only a fraction of what will be required as India pursues the goal of becoming a developed economy by 2047. Simultaneously, it must finance the green transition — renewable energy, transmission, green hydrogen, climate-resilient cities and adaptation infrastructure. Recent estimates suggest that achieving net zero could require investments exceeding \$20 trillion by 2070. No country has financed a transformation of this scale without mobilising vast pools of private capital. India’s leading corporates will develop and operate many of these assets, but their balance sheets cannot finance investments of this magnitude. India needs not merely more capital, but a fundamentally different financing architecture. The central lesson from the first generation of PPPs is not that partnerships failed. It is that the financing model failed.

Infrastructure assets generate economic value for 30-50 years. Yet many PPP projects were financed through bank loans with repayment schedules of just 7-10 years. Projects therefore carried their heaviest debt-service burden when revenues were most uncertain. When growth slowed after 2008, revenues underperformed while debt obligations remained fixed, contributing to rising NPAs and undermining confidence in the model.

The central flaw was simple: Long-lived assets were financed with short-lived capital. The challenge today is no longer merely capital scarcity. It is capital circulation — matching the right capital to the right risk at the right stage of a project’s life cycle.

Governments are uniquely placed to finance high-risk phases such as project preparation, land acquisition and construction.

But once projects stabilise, scarce public capital should not remain locked in mature assets. Ownership and financing should progressively migrate to investors whose liabilities match long-duration infrastructure.

The opportunity is enormous. Global pension funds, insurance companies and sovereign wealth funds control more than \$110 trillion, much of it seeking stable, inflation-linked, long-term returns. India has already created the building blocks. InVITs have emerged as credible investment vehicles, while the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund has demonstrated the ability to attract global institutional capital. What is missing is a mechanism through which government capital, developer capital and institutional capital can continuously replace one another as project risks decline.

This is where circular finance becomes relevant. Government-supported finance and developers should fund projects through construction. Once revenues stabilise, InVITs should acquire operational assets, allowing governments and developers to recycle capital into new projects. As risks decline further, high-cost bank debt should be refinanced through infrastructure debt funds and ultimately held by pension funds, insurance companies and other long-term investors. The cost of capital should decline as project risks decline. Today’s financing architecture often does the opposite.

That is why the RBI should mandate dynamic risk-based repricing of infrastructure loans. Banks currently retain construction-stage risk premia long after projects have been de-risked, removing incentives for refinancing and capital recycling. Equally important is reviving infrastructure debt funds as the bridge between operational infrastructure and long-term institutional investors.

Every rupee locked indefinitely in a mature infrastructure asset is a rupee unavailable for financing the next highway, transmission line or renewable-energy project. The first generation of PPPs sought to mobilise private capital. The second must ensure that the same capital finances successive generations of infrastructure. In an economy that must build, decarbonise and maintain fiscal discipline, capital circulation may prove as important as capital mobilisation.

The writer is former finance secretary, Government of India

Hind Rajab’s voice carries a warning and a message



RAJNI BAKSHI

ONE MORNING last week, I was reading about Josef Mengele’s horrific deeds in Nazi Germany. Later that same day, I saw the film *The Voice of Hind Rajab*. Both accounts of wanton cruelty tell us something terrifying about our present.

Mengele’s unspeakable torture of Jewish people, particularly children, as described by Claudio Magris in *Danube*, draws attention to more than a monstrous personal pathology. This medical doctor, in the name of scientific experimentation, enjoyed inflicting pain. As Magris highlights, it was the system created by the Nazis that enabled Mengele’s evil to destroy countless lives. *The Voice of Hind Rajab* tells the real-life story of the workers at a rescue centre who kept talking to the trapped child over a cell phone, while they struggled desperately to arrange a rescue. Throughout Hind’s ordeal, an ambulance was only eight minutes away. But the rescuers were prevented from reaching the child. If the ambulance moved without a “green light” from the Israeli army, its staff would be killed. Eventually, even though the ambulance was granted the “green light”, Hind and the rescuers were killed by the Israeli army. At one point, one of the staff at the rescue centre cries out in mind-numbing anguish that the Israeli army has gadgets that will show that there is someone alive in the crushed vehicle. Why is no one getting the child out of the wreckage?

Hind Rajab’s story reminds us of a terrifying truth that affects all of us. Namely, the rupture of action from conscience. This happens at two levels: Systemic and individual. Most atrocities of the 20th century were done by people who claimed they were just doing their job. This is what Adolf Eichmann, who served virtually as CEO of the project to exterminate Jews, said at his trial in Jerusalem. Listening to him led Hannah Arendt to coin the term “banality of evil”. While the systemic dimension produces dramatic events, the individual dimension may be more insidious and dangerous. For this causes otherwise law-abiding and moderately moral beings to feel so much fear and hatred towards some “other” that anything done to this “other” seems justified.

The ongoing conflict between the Israelis and Palestinians is just one manifestation of this phenomenon, gathering momentum across the world — including India. I belong to the generation born in the 1950s, brought up to believe that humanity had learned its lesson: Horrors like the Holocaust, Hiroshima-Nagasaki and Partition violence would not be allowed to happen again. To many young people today, we oldies seem to have “fallen” for a false and naïve assumption. Actually, we never “assumed” that the 21st century would be more humane. What we do have is the faith that societies can learn from mistakes, and each individual act of goodness and compassion counts. Often, rejection of this faith is nothing but moral laziness dressed up as nihilism. Yes, the material power of the tank that crushed the car with the child inside must be dealt with. Cruelty and injustice must be stopped. The question is: How? We may not know how our actions will eventually overcome systemic injustice. Yet every time we stand up for compassion, every time we refuse to join those baying for the blood of some “other”, an essential truth is reaffirmed. That every act of putting conscience ahead of action counts.

Bakshi is the founder of the YouTube channel ‘Ahimsa Conversations’

40 YEARS AGO

July 1, 1986



Mixed response to bandh

AUTHORITIES TIGHTENED security measures all over the state to meet any situation arising out of a bandh call given by some militant organisations, the Hindu Shiv Sena, and the youth wing of the Akali Dal (Badal). The bandh call was supported largely in urban areas in the state while it failed to evoke any response in the rural areas. Barring minor incidents, the situation in Punjab remained peaceful.

No newspaper on July 2

IN A totally arbitrary and hostile move, the Government of India has tampered with the

recommendations of the wage board for journalists and non-journalists on the extent of interim relief. Its deliberate action has at once destroyed the sanctity of the wage board and the value of its work. As a protest against this, our office will remain closed on July 1, 1986. Consequently, the *Indian Express* will not appear on July 2.

Pay panel ‘unjust’ to employees

THE CONFEDERATION of the Central Government Employees and Workers described the recommendations of the Fourth Pay Commission as “highly unjust and disappointing”. The Confederation secretary general, S K

Vyas, said the commission has caused a major injustice to the employees by fixing the date of implementation of the recommendations on January 1, 1986.

Rs 150 hike for infantry soldiers

THE STARTING salary for an infantry soldier in the Indian Army will be Rs 1,020, according to the recommendations of the Fourth Pay Commission, presented to the government on Monday. This will represent a rise of about Rs 150 over the existing total emoluments.

There was no edition on July 2, 1986. The above stories are from the July 1, 1986 edition.



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● **WHAT THE OTHERS SAY**
Israel must rid itself of the government behind the settler revolution.
— *Haaretz, Israel*

Can Mamdani effect break through cultural barriers of American conservatism?



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE RECENT June 2026 New York congressional primaries have sent shockwaves through the national Democratic establishment, signalling a seismic realignment rather than a mere localised shift. A progressive slate of democratic socialists endorsed by Mayor Zohran Mamdani has pulled off an unprecedented sweep by unseating entrenched heavyweight incumbents like Dan Goldman and Adriano Espaillat (the latter, the powerful chair of the Congressional Hispanic Caucus). While Indians took a keen interest in one of their own, Mira Nair's son no less, contesting the most powerful job in New York, they should also be paying attention to the wider impact he is having on New York State politics (and, by implication, US politics).

This decisive victory has catapulted democratic socialists Darializa Avila Chevalier and Claire Valdez, alongside leftist ally Brad Lander, onto a clear path to Congress. The Democratic primary almost guarantees the election outcome, since New Yorkers overwhelmingly vote Democratic. This clean sweep proves that the democratic socialist movement in New York is no longer just an insurgent faction within the majority party, but has effectively captured the institutional steering wheel of the city's Democratic electorate.

These three primary outcomes dealt a stinging blow to establishment figures like House Democratic Leader Hakeem Jeffries, who campaigned heavily for the moderate incumbents, and exposed a deep ideological rift in the party heading into the national midterm elections in November. Further, because a central pillar of these primary challenges was sharp dissent against current US foreign policy regarding Israel's war in Gaza, these victories demonstrate that foreign policy can, perhaps counterintuitively, dictate local turnout in deep-blue urban areas. The Gaza and Iran wars were both unpopular, but American voters are rarely swayed by foreign

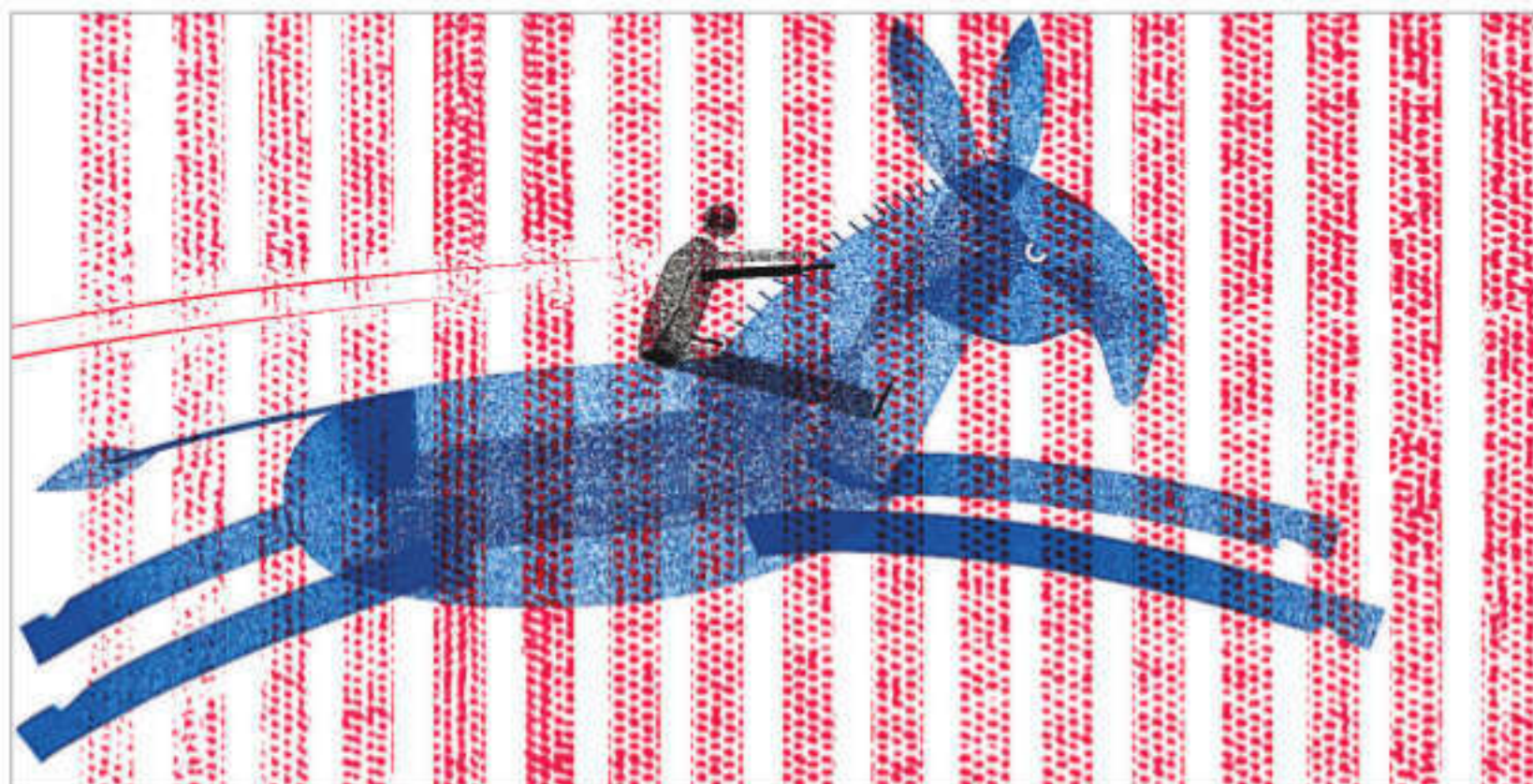


ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

policy considerations when they enter the voting booth. This was a vehement rejection of US support for both; the message was, "not in my name".

Of course, domestic issues mattered too. Voters were fundamentally reacting to a compounding crisis of affordability and public safety by embracing a platform that focusses on aggressive economic intervention. The victorious slate galvanised support by advocating for housing security through rent freezes on rent-stabilised units, "Good Cause" eviction protections, and massive investments in public housing. They paired these housing initiatives with promises of economic relief, including aggressive minimum-wage hikes to \$30 by 2030, fare-free public transit on city buses, and universal child care. To finance these public goods, they proposed steep tax increases on corporations and individuals earning over \$1 million annually, while also vowing structural reforms to public safety and the abolition of Immigration and Customs Enforcement. These are not policies that the Democratic establishment was prepared to endorse. By ousting institutional figures like Espaillat and Goldman, the progressive base is demanding a complete structural overhaul of who holds power in their name and to do what.

This political shift follows a clear lineage that connects past political insurgencies to the current

Across most of the heartland, the ideal of the self-reliant individual and a reverence for free-market capitalism severely limit any platform calling for significant expansion of the federal government or socialist redistribution

governing reality. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez's stunning 2018 victory was originally the harbinger of this trend, as she provided the blueprint and the vocabulary for a revival of socialism in the national discourse by proving that a well-organised grassroots campaign running on explicitly democratic socialist ideas could dismantle a powerful incumbent. However, Mamdani's stunning 2025 mayoral triumph was the institutional catalyst that transformed a loose coalition of activists into a disciplined governing machine with immense institutional gravity. Mamdani's ability to wade into these 2026 congressional primaries and successfully drag his entire slate across the finish line shows that his own victory was not an isolated fluke, but rather the establishment of a new political era in the city.

While New York City possesses unique structural advantages that make it fertile ground for democratic socialism, it is not entirely alone as an outlier. It features a rare concentration of rent-burdened working-class voters paired with a massive, hyper-organised local Democratic Socialists of America chapter. A moderate-to-high likelihood of similar socialist waves exists in California, particularly in districts across Los Angeles and the Bay Area that already possess heavy progressive infrastructure, meaning that we can expect similar primary challenges to moderate Democrats in deeply progressive-

inclined urban areas. In the liberal western states of Oregon and Washington, the likelihood of a socialist assertion remains moderate; while cities like Portland and Seattle have long traditions of leftist activism, their broader statewide electorates tend to lean toward pragmatic progressivism or traditional Democratic liberalism. Vermont maintains a high likelihood of democratic socialist success, though its landscape is distinct, as the birthplace of modern American democratic socialism via Senator Bernie Sanders, its politics are rural and driven by a unique brand of independent progressivism rather than New York's brand of urban machine politics.

Ultimately, while similar primary challenges will likely emerge in deep-blue urban districts across the country, replicating New York's sweeping success elsewhere requires a dense population of working-class tenants paired with a hyper-disciplined grassroots organising apparatus built up over many years. That simply does not exist in the majority of American states. Democratic socialism also faces a profound cultural barrier in traditional American conservatism. Rooted deeply in the nation's ethos, this worldview prioritises rugged individualism, strict constitutionalism, and a fundamental scepticism toward state intervention. Across most of the heartland, the ideal of the self-reliant individual and a reverence for free-market capitalism severely limit any platform calling for significant expansion of the federal government or socialist redistribution.

Even at the high-water mark of American socialism, when Eugene Debs captured nearly 1 million votes in 1920, the movement failed to establish a permanent electoral foothold. Tellingly, this peak was never matched by any socialist candidate afterwards — not even during the economic nadir of the Great Depression. When millions of unhappy working-class voters were desperately seeking relief from systemic economic collapse, they did not pivot toward radical socialism; instead, they sought refuge in the mainstream liberalism of Franklin D Roosevelt's New Deal, demonstrating that even in times of severe crisis, the American electorate overwhelmingly prefers reforming capitalism over replacing it.

The writer is a fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram and chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs

India's cotton farms need better soil, not just new GM seeds



KESHAV KRANTHI

THE ARTICLE by Ashok Gulati, Ayushi Gupta, and Ritika Juneja ('In cotton fields, policy is undoing what science built', IE, June 8) reads more like an advocacy piece for the seed industry than a balanced analysis of what ails Indian cotton. The authors credit Bt cotton, especially Bollgard-II, for the 88 per cent productivity increase between 2002 and 2013. They then argue that seed price control decisions killed the introduction of new GM events, including BG-II RRflex and Bollgard-III, causing a decline in production and productivity since 2014-15. Had India continued its earlier trajectory, they claim, production would have reached 65.3 million bales by 2026, implying a productivity of 967 kg/ha. This diagnosis is flawed.

The authors appear to believe that GM seed technology alone drove India's productivity gains, and that approving BG-II RRflex, Bollgard-III or the seven-gene Thryvon stack would restore that trajectory. Neither premise is supported by evidence. BG-II and BG-III protect crops against bollworm damage; RRflex enables better weed management. These traits are agronomically useful, but there is no credible evidence from anywhere in the world that any of these traits directly increased yields. Framing GM trait approvals as the primary lever for productivity recovery deflects attention from the agronomic, soil science, breeding and management interventions that are decisive for sustainable yield improvement.

The authors compare India's yields of 441 kg/ha with China's 2,311 kg/ha and credit technology adoption for the difference. But China grows neither BG-III nor HT cotton nor Thryvon. It deploys exactly the same BG-II, Bt genes as India. The critical difference is that China grows Bt varieties rather than Bt hybrids.

The authors also omit a telling counterexample. Turkey has not approved GM cotton, yet its yields rose from 1,100 kg/ha in 1999 to 1,728 kg/ha in 2026. Over the same period, India's yields rose from 304 kg/ha to 458 kg/ha — they peaked at 566 kg/ha in 2013-14 and then declined. Turkey, without any approved GM variety, now achieves yields nearly four times that of India, whose cotton area is almost entirely planted with GM hybrids. China and Turkey offer compelling evidence that sustained productivity improvement depends on varietal development, agronomic investment and soil health, not trait approvals.

Data from the Ministry of Textiles also complicates the authors' narrative. India's productivity had already reached 521 kg/ha in 2006 and 554 kg/ha in 2007, when BG-II was approved, but occupied only a negligible share of cotton area, as seed production and distribution had yet to scale.

Crediting BG-II with the gains is not defensible. Productivity then declined to 449 kg/ha by 2018, even as BG-II adoption peaked. The productivity gains of 2002-2011 are better explained by a confluence of factors: Effective bollworm control by Bt cotton, hybrid seed adoption surging from 38 per cent to 92 per cent, fertiliser use increasing 2.3-fold, and irrigated area expanding from 2.5 million to 4.4 million hectares. Heavier farmer investment in crop management compounded these gains. Once inputs approached saturation, it was the law of diminishing returns, not seed price policy, that drove decline.

The root cause of India's cotton productivity collapse goes unmentioned in the article. According to FAO, nearly 32 per cent of Indian land is degraded and 25 per cent faces desertification. Soil organic carbon in Indian croplands averages just 0.3-0.6 per cent, far below the globally accepted minimum of 1-1.5 per cent for productive soils, with critically low levels below 0.25 per cent recorded across cotton-growing regions of Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra. No technology stack, GM or otherwise, can deliver its yield potential in soils thus depleted.

The primary focus of the Cotton Technology Mission should be restoring soil organic carbon through regenerative agriculture, particularly biochar-compost systems combined with farming-system-specific high-density plant spacing geometries. The mission must also prioritise climate-resilient varieties, improving ginning output from 33 per cent to the global average of 39 per cent, raising harvest index from 30 per cent to 50 per cent to improve input-use efficiency, smallholder mechanisation, sustainable pink bollworm management, and reducing input costs that disadvantage farmers.

India need not refuse new GM technologies, but approving them will not, by itself, move the needle. The transformation Indian cotton needs will come from better climate-resilient varieties, healthier soils, and better agronomy. That is what the Cotton Technology Mission must be built to deliver.

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mJmZg1
The writer is chief scientist, International Cotton Advisory Committee (ICAC). The views are personal and do not represent ICAC's positions



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Delhi's EV push

DELHI'S DECISION to make electric two-wheelers mandatory by April 2028 is a bold climate policy ('Road ahead is electric, but it isn't easy', IE, July 1). Two-thirds of the capital's vehicles are two-wheelers, so targeting them first addresses a major source of toxic air pollution. Subsidies helped raise the EV share to 15 per cent, yet deadlines create certainty for investors, grid planners, and buyers alike. Still, ambition must be matched by infrastructure. Charging points in cramped colonies, battery-swapping facilities for gig workers, and reliable power during summer peaks will determine success.

Veda Chidanand, Bengaluru

WHILE THE Delhi government's push to mandate electric mobility is a commendable step towards clearing toxic air, a holistic analysis reveals a troubling macroeconomic paradox ('Road ahead is electric, but it isn't easy', IE, July 1). An aggressive transition to an EV-dominated fleet, without a robust domestic manufacturing ecosystem for critical components, runs the risk of replacing our traditional dependence on imported crude oil with an equally dangerous dependence on imported lithium cells and processing capacity, which is concentrated in China.

Krishan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi

FCRA restrictions

CIVIL SOCIETY organisations play a vital role in areas such as health, education, disaster relief, and civil liberties and rights, stepping in where the state falls short. Yet, the Indian state has treated NGOs with suspicion, using the FCRA, 2010, to impose stringent restrictions on their functioning ('New FCRA rules shrink space for civic action', IE, July 1). Far from improving transparency, the newly notified rules appear to be another way of throttling NGOs that utilise foreign funding for civil society work.

SS Paul, Nadia



SUANSHU KHURANA

PARTITION, ONE of the most consequential political events in the Subcontinent, is usually remembered through its defining motifs: The arbitrarily drawn Radcliffe Line, communal violence that accompanied the birth of two nations, and trains laden with refugees fleeing into the unknown. But filmmaker Imtiaz Ali's *Main Vaapas Aaunga* manages to find another route into that history through the cultural world of "Saaniha Punjab", the shared region that Partition could never divide.

As the love story between a Sikh boy and a Muslim girl finds its feet, a Punjabi folk tune accompanies an engagement ceremony in Muzaffar Ahmedzai's home in the Sardogha of 1947. In a fleeting moment, some women are heard singing 'Kothete aa mahiya, milna taan milaake nahitaa khasma nu khamahiya', a *tappa* often heard at Punjabi weddings. Sung in call-and-response style, this folk song has a woman asking her beloved to come to the terrace. "Come meet me if you want, or else be damned," she sings.

This folk piece wassung at both my grandmothers' weddings, my mother's wedding as well as mine and continues to be sung even today on both sides of the border. Besides being recorded by Punjabi singers Surinder Kaur and Musarrat Nazir, both originally from La-

In Ali's film, the song serves as a reminder that the Radcliffe Line may have divided lives, but it could never sever the shared cultural inheritance

hore, there is also an absolutely charming rendition by ghazal duo Jagjit and Chitra Singh. Nearly 80 years after Partition, the song still lives on.

In Ali's film, it serves as a reminder that the Radcliffe Line may have divided lives, but it could never sever the shared cultural inheritance: Music, poetry, literature, and cuisine. Mainly because the intangible is all that people could really carry with them. In *Main Vaapas Aaunga*, composer A R Rahman and lyricist Irshad Kamil have absorbed that world of folk songs, *boliyan*, *qisse*, Sufi poetry, and wedding melodies.

But Punjab was never confined to folk traditions only. Members of the Punjabi elite patronised European musicians, while venues like Lahore's Faletti's Hotel hosted house orchestras for ballroom dancing. These influences converged in one of the film's most inspired songs, 'Ishq mastana', which begins as Punjabi folk before turning to jazz and jive. Drawing on Kabir's "*Haman hain ishq mastana, haman ko hoshiyaari kya?*" (We are intoxicated with divine love, what need do we have for cleverness?), Kamil invokes a poet who straddled Hindu and Muslim religious worlds without belonging exclusively to either.

Two songs — 'Dariya', which draws from Bengal's baul tradition and explores separation through

through caution, and experience. After three years, it has become woven into everyday routines, shaping decisions about where people travel, study, work, and whom they encounter along the way.

When violence first erupted, most people assumed that the arrangements created in response to it would remain temporary. Communities retreated into areas where they felt secure, and movement became more difficult. Security forces were deployed across large parts of the state. Institutions struggled to function normally. The expectation was that these disruptions, however severe, would eventually recede. But over time, people adjusted their routines, journeys, and relationships around them, gradually incorporating them into everyday life. Relative periods of calm have not al-

ways produced a corresponding sense of peace. The number of violent incidents may decline while the habits formed in response to them remain largely unchanged. By the time these become routine, they no longer feel like responses to a crisis. They linger in daily decisions and become part of how life is organised.

Ongoing tensions involving the Naga

Three years ago, many of the adjustments demanded by the conflict were understood as emergency responses to an extraordinary situation. Today, some have lasted long enough to become part of the social landscape

The writer is senior assistant editor, The Indian Express. suanshu.khurana@expressindia.com

In Manipur, the communities don't meet anymore

Free Whatsapp Channel <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> and Kuki communities illustrate how quickly separation can reinforce itself. The immediate priority lies in preventing further violence and ensuring accountability. Yet every confrontation leaves behind new calculations about safety, movement, and trust. Existing suspicions acquire fresh reasons to persist. Journeys that once seemed routine require greater caution, while interactions that once occurred naturally become less frequent.

Recent violence has brought additional COBRA units into the state. Few would question the need to protect vulnerable communities or prevent further escalation. However, after three years, the pattern has become familiar: Every fresh crisis is followed by another deployment, another operation, and another effort to restore order. Such measures can secure

roads and reduce violence. They cannot undo the routines that prolonged conflict leaves behind.

Three years ago, many of the adjustments demanded by the conflict were understood as emergency responses to an extraordinary situation. Today, some have lasted long enough to become part of the social landscape. Whether these fade or endure will depend in part on the recovery of the institutions and encounters that once brought different communities into routine contact. The longer that recovery remains incomplete, the more difficult it becomes to distinguish between temporary adjustments and the habits a society learns to live with.

Hansing is a researcher and writer based out of Manipur

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• GLOBAL

Why US Supreme Court scrapped Trump’s birthright citizenship order

Anagha Jayakumar & Vineet Bhalla
New Delhi, July 1

THE US Supreme Court Tuesday ruled that the Donald Trump administration’s executive order outlawing birthright citizenship was unconstitutional. It reaffirmed that children born in the US are American citizens under the Fourteenth Amendment, regardless of whether their parents are in the country unlawfully or only temporarily.

In a 6-3 decision, the court rejected the administration’s argument that such children are not “subject to the jurisdiction” of the US, holding the executive order inconsistent with the Constitution’s Citizenship Clause and longstanding Supreme Court precedent. The ruling marks one of the biggest judicial setbacks to the US President’s second-term immigration agenda, and reaffirms a constitutional guarantee that has stood for over 150 years.

What is birthright citizenship?

The 14th Amendment to the US constitution says: “All persons born or naturalized in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof, are citizens of the United States and of the State wherein they reside.” Ratified in 1868 after the American Civil War, it intended to ensure that formerly enslaved people would be recognised as US citizens. Courts have long interpreted the provision to confer citizenship on nearly everyone born on American soil, with two longstanding exceptions:

- The children of diplomats who have allegiance to another government.

INDIAN CITIZENSHIP

- Article 5 says every person born in the territory at the commencement of the Constitution shall be a citizen of India.

- The Citizenship Act, 1955, provided birthright citizenship to every person born in India on or after January 26, 1950, with some exceptions.

- The Act was amended in 1986 to address the entry of migrants from ‘Bangladesh, Sri Lanka and some African Countries’, and in 2003 to bar children born to illegal immigrants.

automatic citizenship under the US Constitution.

A five-judge majority of the court, led by Chief Justice John Roberts, rejected this defence. The court held that the phrase “subject to the jurisdiction” simply refers to the government’s power to enforce its laws over anyone physically present in its territory, regardless of their immigration status. To arrive at this decision, the majority traced the concept back to the English common law principle of *jus soli* or “right of the soil”, under which anyone born within a sovereign’s territory owed them allegiance in exchange for protection, making them a natural-born subject.

Why does Trump want to end birthright citizenship?

Trump signed an executive order in January 2025 denying citizenship to children born in the US to parents illegally or temporarily in the country. He claimed that the US was the only country to have birthright citizenship. However, at least 37 other countries grant citizenship to anyone born on their soil, mostly in South America and the Caribbean. India does not practice unconditional birthright citizenship, nor do several European countries.

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• HEALTH AND POLICY

Why eggs matter for schoolkids

Different foods serve distinct nutritional purposes. But from the lens of nutrition science, the egg remains one of the most complete and easy-to-prepare foods



EXPERT EXPLAINS
DR SEEMA GULATI

HEAD, NUTRITION RESEARCH GROUP, AT NATIONAL DIABETES, OBESITY AND CHOLESTEROL FOUNDATION, DELHI

AT A time when several states continue to debate whether eggs should be part of school midday meals, West Bengal has pulled them out. The discussion often centres on culture, ideology or personal food choices. Lost in that debate is a fundamental question: What does science say?

For millions of Indian children, especially those from low-income households, the midday meal may be their most nutritious meal of the day. Decisions about what goes on that plate must, therefore, be guided by evidence. And the evidence on eggs — as a source of complete, affordable and highly bioavailable protein (which is well-utilised by the body upon consumption) — is difficult to ignore.

All nutritional guidelines suggest that 10-35% of our daily calories should come from protein-rich foods. Protein is also necessary for building lean mass, burning fat, increasing metabolism, slowing blood sugar release, and helping the body repair itself. However, “the issue is not just of protein from animal or plant sources. The most important one is, how much of that protein can the body actually use,” **Dr Seema Gulati**, Head, Nutrition Research Group at the National Diabetes, Obesity and Cholesterol (N-DOC) Foundation, Delhi, tells **Rinku Ghosh**. N-DOC is a non-profit that partners with the Indian Council of Medical Research to research and prevent metabolic diseases.

The answer begins not with grams of protein, but with amino acids, the tiny building blocks of life from which every muscle fibre, hormone, enzyme and immune cell is made. The human body requires 20 amino acids, of which 11 can be manufactured internally. The remaining nine must come entirely from food.

“A food that supplies all nine in adequate proportions is called a complete protein. Eggs are among the very few natural foods that do precisely that, hence they have been a part of midday meal schemes. Those who cannot have eggs need a mix of plant proteins for equivalence,” Gulati adds. Here, she explains why eggs are often seen as the gold standard for protein intake, and what it takes to match their nutritional profile for people who don’t consume them.

Protein: Quantity vs quality

Consider the numbers (*see box*). A hundred grams in terms of real meals means two boiled eggs, a two-thirds cup of cooked soyabean and more than a cup of paneer chunks. In this scenario, cooked soyabeans contain 13.23 g of protein, almost identical to the 13.43 g found in two boiled eggs. Paneer provides 18.9 g, while whole milk contributes 3.3-3.7 g.

Judged solely by protein content, eggs and cooked soyabeans appear virtually indistinguishable. But proteins are not all created equal. Egg protein naturally contains all nine essential amino acids in proportions remarkably close to human requirements. It is also highly digestible, allowing the body to absorb and utilise it more efficiently compared to other foods. This bioavailability is why eggs have long served as the international reference protein against which the quality of other proteins is assessed.

Plant proteins tell a more complex story. Soyabean is undoubtedly among the highest-quality plant proteins avail-

able and comes closer than most plant foods to providing a balanced amino acid profile. Yet, like other plant proteins, it is best viewed as part of a dietary mix rather than a standalone solution.

Nutritionists, therefore, recommend combining legumes with cereals — *dal* with rice, *rajma* with rice, *khichdi*, *roti* with *chana*, or millets with pulses — so that one food compensates for the amino acids another supplies in smaller amounts. For vegetarians, this principle of protein complementation is fundamental with legumes, dairy and nuts. An egg, by contrast, has that balance already built in.

Plant proteins may seem inadequate individually. But they achieve their full nutritional potential through intelligent combinations. Cereals and pulses complement one another. Dairy and soy enrich the overall amino acid profile. Apart from combinations, there are always fortified foods.

The ‘brain nutrient’ factor

Choline is a nutrient that receives far less public attention than protein, despite being indispensable for brain development, memory, nerve signalling and liver health. Whole milk provides around 14-16 mg of choline per 100 g. Paneer contains roughly 15-20 mg, while cooked soyabean offers about 44-45 mg. Eggs provide 290-300 mg of choline. In simple terms, eggs contain almost seven times more choline than cooked soyabeans and nearly 20 times more than milk or paneer.

Each food has its own strength

Each food brings something valuable to the table. Cooked soyabeans are an excellent source of dietary fibre (792g), iron (2.88 mg), magnesium (66.1 mg) and potassium (571.9 mg). It also contributes useful amounts of thiamine, niacin and folate, making it one of the strongest plant-based protein foods available.

Paneer stands out for its 18.9 g of protein and its exceptionally high calcium content (476 mg per 100 g), making it an important food for bone health. It also contributes phosphorus, zinc and biotin in meaningful amounts.

Milk remains one of the most accessible sources of calcium, riboflavin and high-quality dairy nutrition.

A boiled egg provides high-quality complete protein, meaningful amounts of riboflavin, pantothenic acid, biotin, phosphorus, iron and zinc, together with one of the richest natural sources of choline, all within a single, compact food.

Carbohydrates and fats

The accompanying fats and carbohydrates also determine how a food fits into a balanced diet. Per 100 g, boiled eggs contain 10.54 g of fat and virtually no carbohydrates, making them naturally suited to diets that prioritise high-quality protein. Cooked soyabeans provide 6.79 g of fat, 3.57 g of carbohydrates, and an additional 792 g of dietary fibre, offering a combination of plant protein, complex carbs and fibre that supports sustained energy release.

For the same quantity, paneer contains the highest fat content (14.8 g) among the foods compared, together with 12.4 g of carbohydrates, reflecting its energy-dense nature. Milk, meanwhile, remains the lightest option, contributing 4.5-6.6 g of fat and 4.9-8.3 g of carbohydrates, depending on whether it is cow’s or buffalo’s milk.

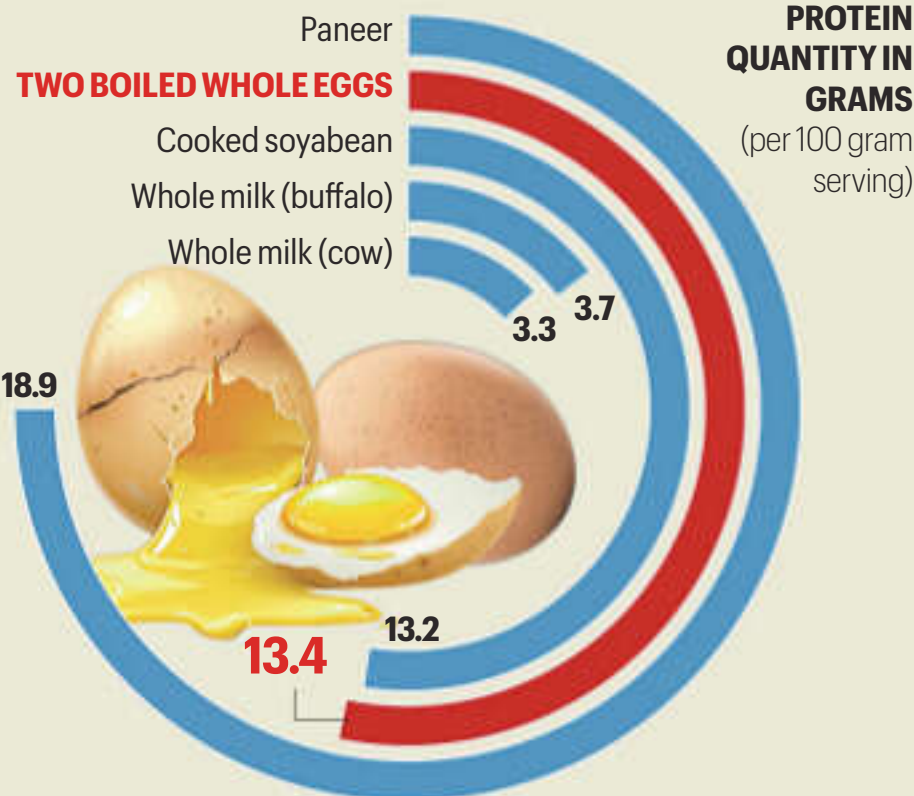
These differences illustrate that while eggs stand out for their complete protein and micronutrient density, soyabeans contribute valuable fibre and plant nutrients, paneer offers concentrated dairy nutrition, and milk provides a balanced everyday source of energy and nutrients. Each food serves a distinct nutritional purpose rather than competing on a single parameter. But from the lens of nutrition science, the humble egg continues to hold its place as one of the most complete and easy-to-prepare foods.

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• EGGS vs THE REST

The chart and table show the quantity of nutrients such as protein and carbohydrates in various foods.

- Eggs and cooked soyabeans appear indistinguishable in protein content. But not all proteins are created equal.
- Eggs are highly digestible and ‘bio-available’ (well-utilised by the body).
- Soyabean is a high-quality plant protein. But it is best as part of a dietary mix rather than a standalone solution.
- Paneer has higher protein. But 100 gms is tough to consume at one go. Egg also contains all nine essential amino acids.



(NUTRIENT VALUES BELOW ARE PER 100 GRAM SERVING)

Nutrient	Whole milk (buffalo)	Whole milk (cow)	Paneer (cottage cheese)	Cooked soyabean	Two boiled whole eggs
Energy (gram)	107.3	72.9	257.9	132.09	147.7
Carbohydrate (g)	8.3	4.9	12.4	3.57	Virtually nil
Fats (g)	6.6	4.5	14.8	6.79	10.54
Calcium (milligram)	121	118	476	68.25	55.1
Riboflavin (B2) (mg)	0.13	0.11	0.1	0.08	0.19

DATA COMPILED BY DR SEEMA GULATI

A lesson from Tamil Nadu, pioneer in midday meals



ANAGHA JAYAKUMAR

THE WEST Bengal government has announced that it will remove eggs from midday meals, sparking a debate over what children should be served in school.

The decision has prompted comparisons with Tamil Nadu, which, as Madras Presidency, pioneered the concept of midday meals in India, and has provided eggs under its programme for decades now. Tamil Nadu’s midday meal scheme has evolved over a century, with governments revisiting what children should be fed, and why.

Getting children into school...

Chief minister K Kamaraj is often credited with introducing a school meal programme in Madras State in 1956. But he had built on decades of experiments within the pre-independence Madras Presidency to get children into schools.

The first publicly funded school meal experiment in Madras Presidency began in 1920 as part of an effort to expand compulsory elementary education.

Officials recognised that poverty, hunger and families’ dependence on children’s earnings kept many children out of school. They also realised that compulsory education could not be achieved through coercive tactics alone. Against this backdrop, the Madras Corporation turned to school meals as an incentive to attract and retain children in classrooms, writes historian Catriona Ellis in her 2023 book *Imagining Childhood, Improving Children: The Emergence of an ‘Aunacular’ State in Late Colonial South India*.

By most accounts, Justice Party president P Theagaraya Chetty, also president of Madras Corporation Council, backed a midday meal scheme to benefit the state’s impoverished children. The pilot was at a corporation school in Madras city in 1920.

The daily cost per head was capped at one anna. Yet the scheme quickly proved its value. In *Imagining Childhood, Improving Children*, Ellis notes that attendance reportedly dropped by 50% when the scheme was briefly suspended in 1927.

By the end of the decade, the debate had

How school lunch came to other states

- In 1984, Kerala became the country’s second state to have a school lunch programme.

- Over the next few years, many other states launched their own versions of the scheme, and finally in 1995, the Centre stepped in. It was launched as a centrally sponsored scheme across 2,408 blocks for students up to Class 5, initially providing foodgrains to states.
- In 2001, following a landmark Supreme Court order, states were directed to provide cooked mid-day meals rather than dry rations. In 2007, the UPA government expanded the scheme to Class 8.
- In 2021, the scheme was named PM POSHAN.

shifted from getting children into school to ensuring they could learn once they were there. In 1930, the Madras Corporation declared: “If you cannot feed the body of a child, you cannot feed the brain.” For Ellis, that shift was rooted in education rather than public health. “Hungry children can’t concentrate on learning; they might be in school but they can’t learn anything if they’re hungry,” she told *The Indian Express*.

...and keeping them there

By the 1930s, education authorities in Madras increasingly treated children’s health as central to their educational mission, Ellis writes. Corporation debates increasingly focused on the nutritional value of school meals, the need for a balanced diet and the quality of food provided to children. Officials debated whether bread and milk were preferable to the usual rice-and-curd diet, but also whether children should be served food familiar to them.

“The key conclusion was that it was more important to provide food that the children would like and eat, than to focus on the most efficient or nutritious food,” Ellis told *The Indian Express*. “Providing food similar to what the children would have eaten at home seems to be a way of helping school feel familiar and safe, and therefore a place to learn.” Medical inspection increasingly accompanied school meals, reinforcing the idea that schools were responsible not only for education but also for nutrition and physical development. This marked a wider shift in how the state viewed children.

However, this political concern did not always translate into adequate funding.

Eggs in the basket

The next milestone came after Independence, when chief minister Kamaraj expanded the school meal programme in 1956. The scheme was transformed under chief minister MG Ramachandran’s Nutritional Meal Programme in 1982, which placed greater emphasis on nutritional needs alongside improving attendance.

In January 1989, chief minister M Karunanidhi announced that children under the scheme would receive one boiled egg every two weeks. Successive governments expanded the frequency of egg distribution and the menu itself. In 2013, Chief Minister J Jayalalithaa introduced the Variety Meals scheme to expand the nutritional value and appeal of the midday meal programme.

Free Telegram Channel https://t.me/+2RvD_RGf9mljMzg1 without regard to the rest of the world.

The war stands as a rare instance — the first since the 1956 Suez war — in which a Middle Eastern nation has directly faced off with one of the world’s foremost military powers, stood its ground, and compelled the adversary to negotiate on balanced terms. That boosts Iran’s position in the Islamic world and strengthens the hands of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps.

Outlook for oil and gas markets

While price forecasts are logical determinations based on supply and demand projections, market prices are based on sentiments of traders whose job is to match demand with supply, and make money. During the last four months, market prices have remained consistently below forecasts, indicating optimism which may, fortunately, be borne out. But optimism and pessimism are no substitutes for planning. Oil prices could have easily gone in the

opposite direction had there been no MoU and had the Strait remained closed for much longer. The world’s economy has had a close shave in terms of energy security. And we are by no means out of the woods yet. Oil prices have fallen back but do not represent a return to the pre-war situation. Disruptions to negotiations and outbursts of fighting may cause volatility in the coming months. The power balance in the Persian Gulf stands fundamentally altered, reducing its reliability as an energy supplier. Changes in the energy policies of consuming nations will be needed.

Meanwhile, it would be wise to top off oil, liquefied petroleum gas, liquefied natural gas, and fertiliser stocks and expand reserves, taking advantage of reduced prices. Reserves cost money but insure against much worse economic damage and social unrest from physical scarcity.

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• GEOPOLITICS

US-Iran talks: ‘MoU is a breakthrough for Iran, but overreach would be folly’



EXPERT EXPLAINS
AJAY SINGH

TOKYO-BASED ENERGY & SHIPPING EXECUTIVE

AFTER TRADING strikes over the past week, the US and Iran appear to be finally inching back towards the negotiating table. These strikes had threatened to unravel a fragile truce between both countries that remains in place despite occasional flare-ups and Israeli aggression in southern Lebanon.

Last month, a 14-point Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed as part of a framework agreement to end the war

in West Asia that began in February. **Ajay Singh**, a management advisor and a former oil and gas industry executive with considerable experience of the Middle East, spoke to **Anil Sasi** about how the situation could have unfolded differently in the absence of an MoU or had the Strait remained closed for much longer.

Prospects for US-Iran talks

Flare-ups may continue as the MoU has left crucial details unaddressed, such as arrangements for monitoring and enforcing the ceasefire in Lebanon, protocols for shipping in the Strait, and whether or not the International Atomic Energy Agency’s inspectors may access sites in Iran.

Some people on both sides may prefer that full-blown fighting resumes, and cause disruptions in Lebanon or the Strait as elections in Israel and the US draw closer. But the US and Iran will likely get on with negotiations because both realise that further con-

flikt is not in their interests, at least for now. Mutual mistrust and the complexity of the nuclear issue make it highly unlikely that a result will be forthcoming within 60 days — if at all — and extensions will be required. The best outcome would be something like the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) of 2015, whereby Iran may pursue a peaceful nuclear programme under safeguards and secure a lasting end to sanctions, in return for the highly enriched uranium being rendered harmless.

Perhaps the US — although not Israel — may be amenable to such a deal, so long as it can be presented as an improvement over the JCPOA.

This is an opportunity for Iran to make peace with dignity, secure the rightful future prosperity of its people, and end its decades-long ostracisation. The unknown is the internal dynamic within the Iranian regime at this time. It may well decide that the country’s only guarantee of security lies

in continued conflict, or insist on a complete withdrawal of US forces from the Middle East. That would be an overreach.

The situation after the US mid-term elections may not be quite as favourable for Iran; the military advantage that it has secured through the use of drones and missiles will eventually be countered; and in a no-holds-barred conflict, superior American economic and technological strength will prevail.

Significance of the MoU

One may say that Iran has pulled off something of a breakthrough. After decades of enduring tough sanctions, it has restored its primary source of national income through oil export in addition to securing access to hitherto frozen funds, besides another \$300 billion of funding. It retains the military capabilities to continue menacing adversaries and choke off the Strait of Hormuz. Extraordinarily, the US has recognised Iran’s claims over the Strait,

GST COLLECTIONS HAD HIT A RECORD HIGH OF RS 2.43 LAKH CRORE IN APRIL

GST mop up in June rose by 14%, revenue from imports soared 35%

Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 1

THE CENTRE collected Rs 1.95 lakh crore as Goods and Services Tax (GST) on a gross basis in June, up 13.9% from last year, buoyed by a 34.6% rise in tax revenue from imports — almost double the 19.1% increase seen in May.

According to data released by the Ministry of Finance on Wednesday, the June GST collections were only marginally higher than the Rs 1.94 lakh crore mopped-up in May.

GST collections had hit a record high of Rs 2.43 lakh crore in April. In June, domestic revenue accounted for 69.2% — or Rs 1.35 lakh crore — of the gross GST collections as it rose 6.5% year-on-year, with the remaining 30.8% amounting to Rs 60,038 crore came from imports. In May, GST from imports had made up 30.7% of total collections, with government sources arguing then that the rise in Integrated GST revenue from imports was a sign of “industrial capacity expansion”.

Officials had said the 19.1% rise in GST from imports in May was driven by inbound shipments of raw materials and intermediate inputs that feed India’s industrial production

New EPF scheme notified: Most core provisions retained

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 1

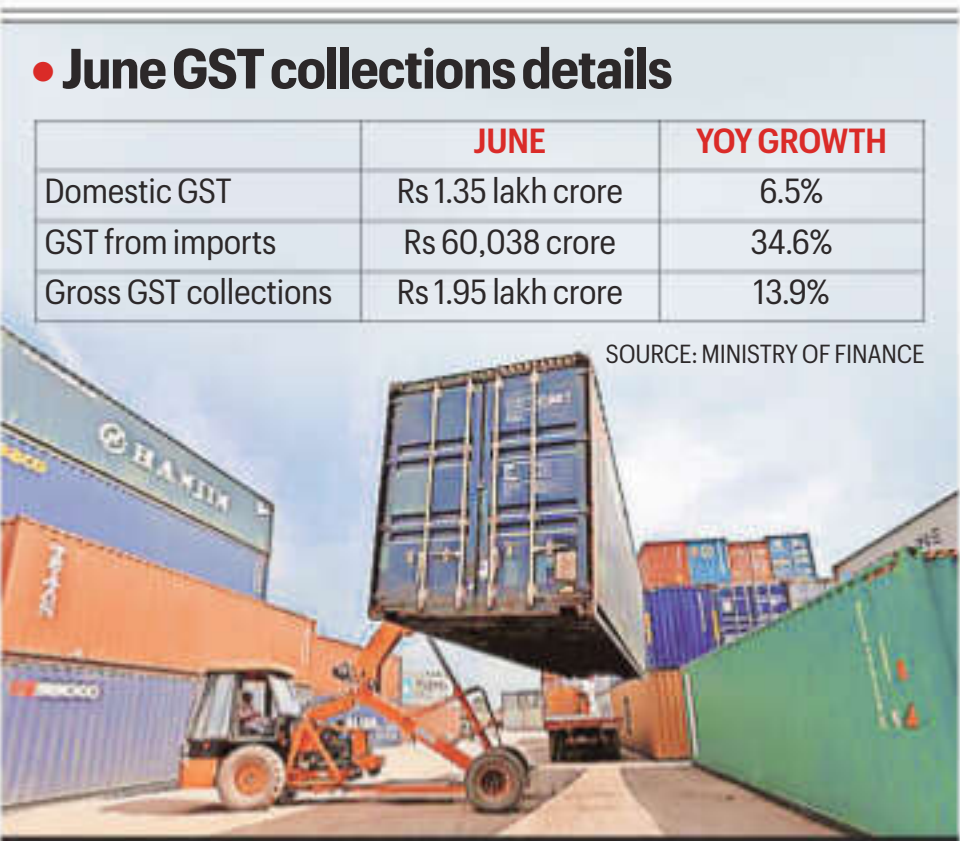
THE CENTRE has notified the Employees’ Provident Fund Scheme, 2026, retaining most of the core provisions — including the 12% contribution rate, eligibility norms and withdrawal framework — of the Employees’ Provident Fund Scheme, 1952, while aligning the provident fund framework with the Code on Social Security, 2020.

The new scheme focuses on simplifying procedures, strengthening governance, expanding digital compliance and easing the transition to the labour codes. Most fundamental features of the EPF system, including contribution rates, eligibility and benefit structure, remain intact, offering continuity for both employers and employees.

“The new Employees’ Provident Fund Scheme, 2026 represents a major milestone in the next phase of implementing the labour codes,” said Puneet Gupta, Partner, People Advisory Services, EY India. “Coming into effect immediately, it modernises the provident fund framework through greater digitalisation, simplified processes and enhanced compliance requirements for both employers and employees.”

For employees, one key change is the simplification of withdrawal rules.

Members will be able to make partial withdrawals under streamlined procedures for essential needs such as illness, education, marriage and housing requirements. FE



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Indian economy amidst geopolitical uncertainties”.
Meanwhile, Ikesh Nagpal, Lead-Indirect Tax at tax and consulting firm AKM Global, said it was “encouraging” that the growth in GST collections was alongside a 29.1% increase in refunds. This, according to Nagpal, indicated that “strong revenue growth is being achieved without affecting liquidity for businesses”.

Total refunds in June rose to Rs 32,436 crore, resulting in net GST revenue being 11.2% higher at Rs 1.62 lakh crore. Net domestic revenue was only 2.6% higher from last year at Rs 1.17 lakh crore, while net revenue from imports was 42.2% higher at Rs 45,370 crore.

Public funds clause reinstated in RBI’s upper layer NBFCs

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, July 1

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) on Wednesday reinstated a key definition on public funds in its revised guidelines for core investment companies (CICs) and upper layer NBFCs.

The move keeps Tata Sons’ prospects of avoiding a mandatory stock market listing tied to the central bank’s decision on its application to surrender its CIC licence.

The RBI had originally defined indirect receipt of public funds in a circular issued on April 29 as “funds received not directly but through associates and group entities which have access to public funds.”

The definition was omitted from the central bank’s June 24 circular but reinstated in a footnote in an updated version released on Wednesday, effective July 1, 2026.

Although Tata Sons has had no direct access to public funds since repaying its debt in 2024, it remains an indirect recipient of public funds under the RBI’s definition because listed Tata companies, including Tata Steel, Tata Chemicals, and Tata Power, hold equity stakes in it.

The RBI came out with revised guidelines last week stating the requirement to qualify as Upper Layer non-banking finance companies (NBFC-UL) without giving clarity whether Tata Sons, the holding company of \$180 billion Tata group, will have to go public with an IPO or not.

The RBI’s final list of NBFC-UL — which is expected soon — and the qualifying assets are



Tata Sons remains an indirect recipient of public funds under the RBI’s definition, because listed Tata companies hold equity stakes in it. REUTERS

potentially very significant for Tata Sons as they could remove the main regulatory trigger that has kept alive the possibility of a mandatory IPO.

In 2024, the RBI classified Tata Sons as an Upper Layer NBFC (NBFC-UL) under its Scale-Based Regulation framework because of its size and systemic importance.

Under RBI rules, an NBFC-UL is required to list on a stock exchange within three years of being notified and comply with stricter governance and disclosure norms.

That classification effectively put Tata Sons on a path toward a public listing since September 2025, unless the RBI changed the rules or granted relief. Tata Trusts hold 66 per cent stake in Tata Sons.

The data for June came on the same day the GST began its 10th year of existence, having been rolled out on July 1, 2017. The new indirect tax regime continues to be fine-tuned, with the GST Council last year in September approving a raft of changes, including lower tax rates and a two-slab structure, among others.

Experts continue to expect more reforms in the GST system, with BDO India’s Karthik Mani, Partner & Leader (South) — Indirect Tax, saying that industry and taxpayers want a single pan-India GST registration “to end the compliance burden of state-wise registrations”. Other changes on the wish-list include a “genuine amnesty” for routine reconciliation mismatches so taxpayers are not dragged into litigation over minor notices, auto-populated monthly returns to reduce manual filing to near-zero, and fungibility of Input Tax Credit across states. “Achieving these would mark GST’s true transition from a tax reform to a genuinely frictionless, taxpayer-first system,” Mani said.

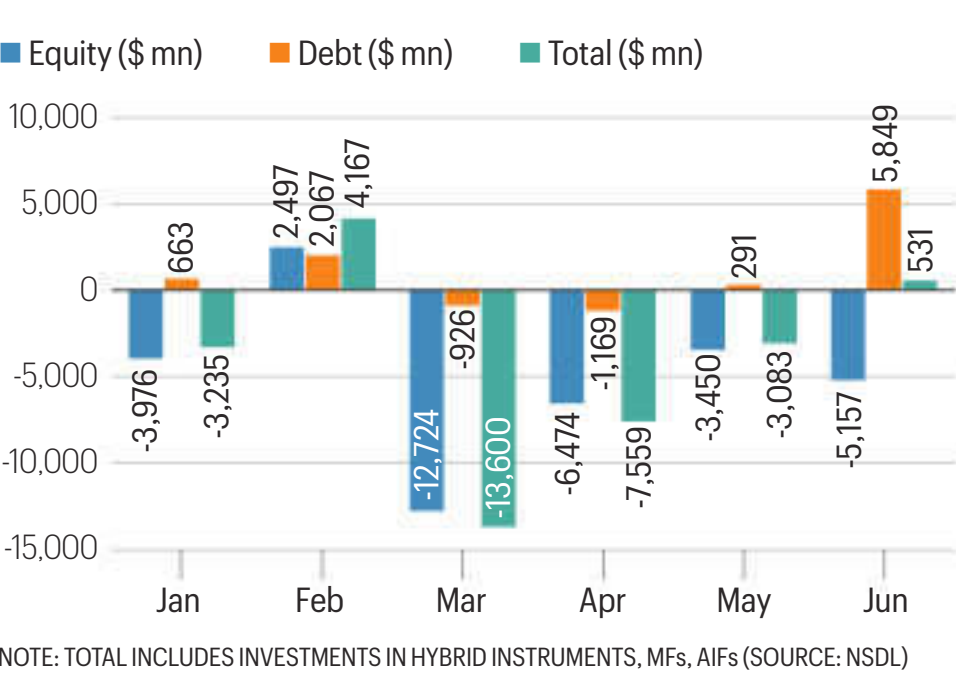
Manufacturing activity cools in June: PMI data

New Delhi: India’s manufacturing sector activity growth eased in June, as new business orders and international sales increased at softer rates, resulting in slower expansions in buying levels, employment and output, a monthly survey said on Wednesday.

The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers’ Index fell from 55.0 in May to 54.2 in June, pointing to the second-weakest improvement in the health of the sector since mid-2022. The HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers’ Index (PMI) is a gauge of overall conditions derived from measures of new orders, output, employment, supplier delivery times and stocks of purchases. A print above 50 means expansion, while a score below 50 denotes contraction. Several firms reported an improvement in demand conditions, but others noted subdued client appetite for their products and fierce market competition. PTI

● Is foreign investment tide turning for India?

For the first time in four months, June saw India post a positive number for net foreign portfolio investments (FPIs). While only \$531 million, it marks a turnaround after a total net outflow of \$24.2 billion over March, April, and May.



NOTE: TOTAL INCLUDES INVESTMENTS IN HYBRID INSTRUMENTS, MFs, AIFs (SOURCE: NSDL)

- The positive net FPI investment in June was down to the debt segment, with the measures to attract foreign funds in sovereign bonds paying immediate dividends. After FPI investment in debt of just \$291 million in May, the figure jumped to \$5.85 billion in June.
- Outflows from equities, however, continued in June, rising to \$5.16 billion from \$3.45 billion in May.
- There has been a rebound even in terms of foreign direct investment (FDI), which jumped to \$15.29 billion in April — the highest since August 2020 — in gross terms, as per latest data. Even on a net basis, FDI was in positive territory for the fourth month in a row at \$6.58 billion, the highest since May 2021.

Prudential-HCL JV gets IRDAI license

Mumbai: The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has granted certificate of registration to Prudential HCL Health Insurance Ltd to carry on health insurance business in India.

Prudential HCL Health Insurance is a joint venture between the Prudential Group of the UK and the HCL Group. With this registration, the number of standalone health insurers operating in India has increased to eight. This is the third registration granted by IRDAI during the calendar year

2026. Although Prudential has maintained a long-standing relationship with the ICICI Group over the years, it chose to establish its new joint venture with the HCL Group instead.

By partnering with the HCL group, Prudential aims to leverage the group’s expertise. UK-based Prudential plc recently acquired a 75% stake in Bharti Life Insurance Company Ltd for an initial cash consideration of Rs 3,500 crore (\$389 million). ENS

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

How insurance regulator aims to curb tricky dark patterns

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, July 1

MISSELLING HAS long been a rampant problem in the insurance industry, with agents, brokers, and even banks often accused of pushing complex products to customers. Some of them have also been accused of using “dark patterns” to boost sales at the cost of credibility.

The insurance regulator is now gearing up to tackle this menace, and instill confidence in consumers. Ajay Seth, the Chairman of Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), has asked the Institute of Public Auditors of India to study this practice over the next nine months.

What is a dark pattern?

“Dark pattern” refers to a mechanism hidden in websites that manipulates users into sharing data or making choices they otherwise won’t usually make by pressurising or misleading them. Some examples include nudging users to provide personal information to view product offerings on websites, deliberately making it difficult for users to cancel subscriptions, and spam calling to push products.

“We need to look at it from their (consumer) perspective... to help make financial inclusion more understandable, more trusted, and more actionable,” Seth said at an event in Mumbai on Tuesday.

How big is the problem

Dark patterns have plagued the industry since insurance moved into digital space.

According to a survey by Local Circles, a social media platform focusing on governance issues, around 80% of respondents said they faced issues such as hidden charges, difficulty in cancelling policies, and forced data sharing. Around 90% of the sample size



IRDAI chief Ajay Seth highlighted the need to tackle dark patterns in his speech on Tuesday. REUTERS

of over 87,000 respondents said they were repeatedly bugged to continue or buy policies through unsolicited calls and messages.

The study covered some of the biggest digital insurance platforms in the country, such as Policybazaar, Acko, and Tata AIG among others, highlighting the widespread nature of the problem.

How IRDAI plans to check it

The regulator has partnered with the statutory body Institute of Public Auditors of India to monitor dark patterns across the industry. Just a few months ago, in April, it had directed insurers to conduct a self-assessment on dark patterns and submit observations.

“When we sent a letter to all of you to check up on dark patterns, almost all have said they don’t have dark patterns. With that kind of a response, we have reached out to the Institute of Public Auditors of India to take up the study and also monitor over a period of nine months who has got dark patterns and who has not,” Seth

said at the event on Tuesday.

During his speech, he also noted how most insurers ask for loads of personal information from users before providing details about products. This leads to information being hidden behind complex processes, limiting product discovery and potentially driving away consumers who were “already on the fence” about getting insurance.

“How do we communicate if people do not have a choice to go and know the products, the price, the performance? How do they make a decision?” Seth asked.

“While we have not yet spoken to many industry players, what we understand is that insurers might face some short-term problems if the regulations are tightened. After all, we do not know exact figures for how much of their sales are contributed by dark patterns and mis-selling,” an analyst tracking the sector at a domestic brokerage said.

“However, that impact will largely be inconsequential, and tighter norms would build trust for consumers and be good for the industry,” they added.

The regulator will be releasing a consultation paper on reforms in insurance distribution in July, which is expected to include steps to curb mis-selling across distribution channels, improve transparency, and tweak the existing commission-based distribution model of insurers.

These steps come after the Reserve Bank of India introduced a comprehensive framework to curb mis-selling of financial instruments by banks, which comes into effect from January 1.

“I would like to acknowledge the good set of guidelines that the RBI has brought. They have done their piece. All those banks are also licensees of the insurance sector. Now it is our turn to bring in suitable guidelines for them,” Seth said on the matter.

US lifts curbs on Anthropic’s new Fable, Mythos AI models

Bengaluru: Anthropic said on Tuesday that the US Commerce Department lifted export controls on its most advanced Fable and Mythos AI models, less than three weeks after the company was ordered to suspend their access over national security risks.

Washington has stepped up oversight of new model releases to identify potential threats amid concerns that advanced AI models could be misused by military intelligence in China, Russia or other countries of concern. A June 12 order requiring Anthropic to immediately restrict access for Mythos 5 and Fable 5 to foreign nationals prompted the company to disable both models for all users as there was no way to verify nationality in real time.

Last week, the US government allowed the company to release Mythos 5 but only to some “trusted” US organisations. The model had earlier been made available to a broader group of companies as part of its Glasswing project. REUTERS

RBI Guv sees case for lower inflation target in long run

Mumbai: India is unlikely to raise its official inflation target and there may be a case for lowering it over the long term, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Governor Sanjay Malhotra said at an event in Russia on Wednesday.

The country’s inflation-targeting framework has helped lower average inflation, the central bank chief said in a conversation with his Russian counterpart, Elvira Nabiullina. India adopted its inflation-targeting framework in 2016, which tasks the RBI with keeping inflation

within a band set by the government. In March, the government retained its retail inflation target of 4%, within its comfort band of 2%-6%, following a review.

The target will remain in place for five years. Speaking at the Financial Congress of the Bank of Russia, Malhotra said while inflation in India is expected to rise, it currently remains below the central bank’s target.

He added that he was confident the economy would continue growing at a fast pace for the foreseeable future. REUTERS

● BRIEFLY

Macros, AI woes to weigh on IT Q1: Motilal Oswal

New Delhi: The macro environment, AI and geopolitical overhangs are likely to weigh on discretionary spends, decision cycles, and demand commentary for exports-led IT services firms leading to a soft Q1 FY27 showing, Motilal Oswal Financial Services said adding it expects some companies to walk back top end of guidance bands. The latest note by Motilal Oswal highlighted that Accenture’s recent commentary underlines cautious discretionary spends, lending support to expectation that demand recovery is likely to remain in a flux. PTI

Rupee falls 60 paise, breaches 95/\$ mark

Mumbai: The Indian rupee fell to a near three-week low on Wednesday, tracking declines in Asian currencies as investors turned cautious ahead of remarks from the US Federal Reserve chair and uncertainty over US-Iran negotiations. The rupee weakened 0.6% to end the session at 95.2475 per dollar, its worst one day fall since June 8. Traders said likely central bank intervention shielded the rupee early in the session, before it weakened as dollar offers from state-run banks thinned. REUTERS

● MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold ▲	US Dollar ▲
76,922.64	24,005.85	₹1,41,632	₹95.25
443.97	140.10		
0.58%	0.59%	Silver ▲	Oil ▲
		₹2,25,430	\$70.58

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION GOLD PER 10G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JUNE 30, 2026

● THE MOVE REFLECTS A GROWING FOCUS ON ATTRACTING PRICE-SENSITIVE PASSENGERS WITHOUT RESORTING TO BLANKET FARE CUTS

Airlines turn to unbundled fares to woo budget travellers

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 1

DOMESTIC AIRLINES are increasingly unbundling their products to cater to different categories of travellers, offering stripped-down fare options that lower the entry ticket price while charging separately for services such as checked baggage and meals.

The move, led by IndiGo and Air India over the past few weeks, reflects a growing focus on attracting price-sensitive passengers without resorting to blanket fare cuts, while also opening up new avenues for ancillary revenue.

ated IndiGo on Wednesday introduced ‘IndiGo Lite’, an entry-level fare category for economy passengers travelling on direct domestic and international flights.

The fare allows passengers to travel with only a cabin bag of up to 7 kg and includes an auto-assigned seat, making it the airline’s cheapest ticket option.

“Designed for customers who travel light and would like to pay only for the services they need, IndiGo Lite is another step towards building a strong, fit-for-purpose product portfolio,” said Aloke Singh, chief strategy officer at IndiGo. The launch comes barely two weeks after Air India rolled out its ‘Basic’



The strategy enables airlines to display lower headline fares on travel booking platforms. REUTERS

fare on select domestic routes, offering tickets that are around Rs 500-600 cheaper by excluding complimentary hot meals

offers a cabin baggage-only fare for travellers looking for lower-priced tickets.

The back-to-back launches underscore a broader shift in airline pricing strategies, where carriers are increasingly moving away from a one-size-fits-all approach towards segmented fare products. Instead of cutting fares across the board, airlines are allowing passengers to choose only the services they require, whether it is checked baggage, meals, preferred seating or flexibility to modify bookings.

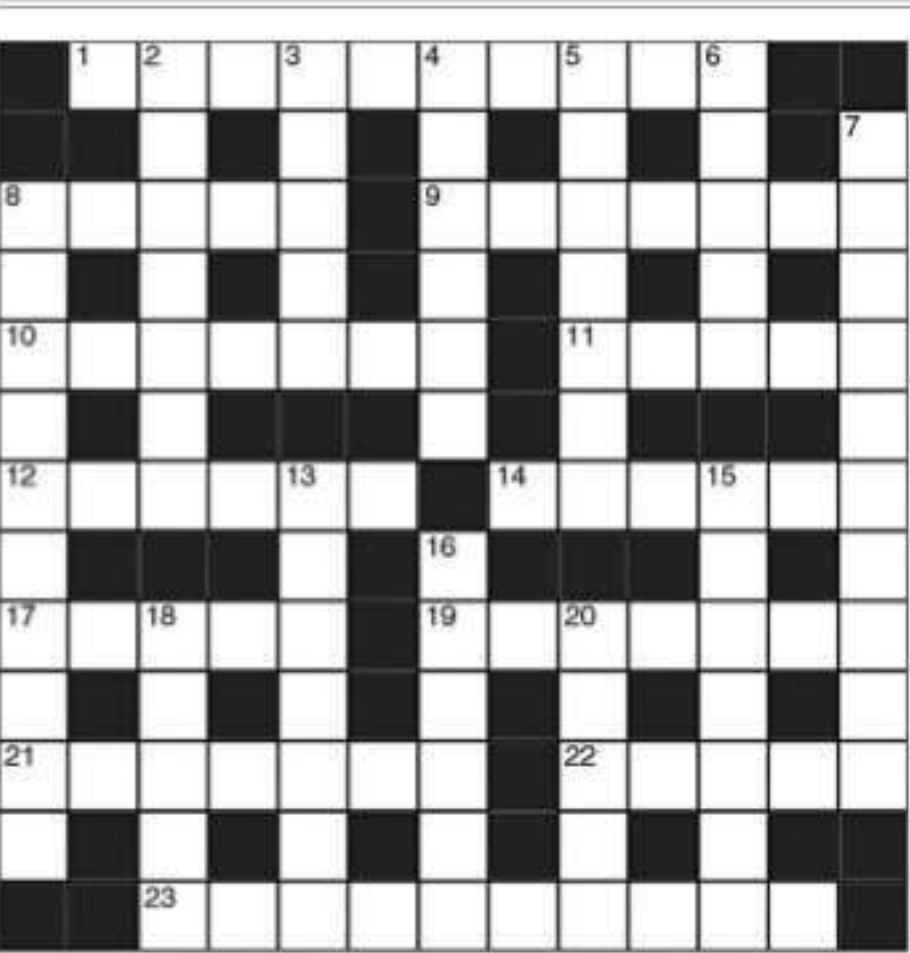
The strategy also enables airlines to display lower headline fares on travel booking platforms, where ticket prices often influence consumer

choice, while generating additional revenue through optional add-on services.

The trend comes amid intense competition in the domestic aviation market and continued growth in passenger traffic. For consumers, the new fare options offer greater flexibility and potentially lower travel costs, particularly for short-duration trips where checked baggage or onboard meals may not be necessary.

For airlines, however, the move is equally about diversifying revenue streams and maximising yields by tailoring products to different traveller segments rather than competing solely on ticket prices. FE

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Final arrival has complaint and is persisting (7,3)
- 8 A pie's turning brown (5)
- 9 A unit is ordered to somewhere in North Africa (7)
- 10 Perfect example of a work in Latin (7)
- 11 The mark of a beast marks the trail (5)
- 12 It means one's refusing in code perhaps (2,4)
- 14 It follows a gale at sea too (2,4)
- 17 It caters for the rest of the drivers (5)
- 19 Displayed — a willingness to invest? (4,3)
- 21 He seeks relaxation — I trust nothing disturbs him (7)
- 22 Goes out of play (5)
- 23 Giving but quietly feeling bitter about it? (10)
- DOWN
- 2 A couple of pages to praise and praise (7)
- 3 What's wrong with the weather? Signs of warning (5)
- 4 Spot something on the board (6)
- 5 Large volume one may take to work (7)
- 6 She provides some excellent essays (5)
- 7 Moons around site all set for development (10)
- 8 Stepfather is a ship's officer (6,4)
- 13 Make an impact (7)
- 15 Noise or disturbance can be wearing (7)
- 16 The clergy adopt Eastern dress (6)
- 18 Hit the first bump (5)
- 20 It holds the unloved Emperor motionless (5)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6029 ACROSS: 1 Screws, 4 Entrap, 9 Tally-ho, 10 Vital, 11 Lydia, 12 Terrace, 13 Good offices, 18 Chianti, 20 Lehar, 22 Trier, 23 Epsilon, 24 Cancan, 25 Edited DOWN: 1 Settle, 2 Ruled, 3 Wayward, 5 Never, 6 Rat race, 7 Pallet, 8 Post offices, 14 Opinion, 15 Ill-used, 16 Acetic, 17 Craned, 19 Norma, 21 Holst.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Never underestimate the determination of a kid who is ___ and cash poor. - Cory Doctorow (4,4)

THROE

DMOII

KOSYCT

MITHER

ANSWER: Never underestimate the determination of a kid who is time-rich and cash poor. - Cory Doctorow

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

GORKHA RIFLES
Indian Army and 11 Gorkha Rifles Salutes its brave heart, Late Lt Col Kapil Dev Pandey 107 (TA), who made supreme sacrifice while deployed in Manipur, on 30 June 2022.
Colonel 11 GR & Sikkim Scouts and All Ranks BORDER SECURITY FORCE
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember itsgallant Jawan Naik Balam Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in Srinagar area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

NAIK BALAM SINGH
35 BN BSF
27.01.1960 – 02.07.1994
CONSTABLE DHARAMBIR SINGH
116 BN BSF
20.09.1970– 02.07.1992
Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Dharambir Singh on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries in Counterpart firing in area of Cone Hill, Uri (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE
DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Sub Inspector Sawant Singh of 44 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating Naxals in Bihar on 2 July 1975. For his conspicuous gallantry and valour, he was posthumously awarded the President's Police Medal for braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Sub Inspector Amrik Singh of 71 Bn, who sustained grievous injuries in an encounter during an anti-terrorist operation in Moga district, Punjab on 30 April 1990 and breathed his last on 2 July 1990. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Jhawahar Lal Chakma of 71 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating terrorists during an operation in Moga district, Punjab on 2 July 1990. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Inspector Sardara Singh of 113 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured while dealing with a violent mob in Gujarat on 2 July 1992. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Ajay Kumar Singh of 48 Bn, who was grievously injured in a grenade attack by a terrorist at Lal Chowk, Anantnag, J&K on 27 June 2002 and breathed his last during treatment on 2 July 2002. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Kuldeep Kumar Oraon of 118 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured while bravely combating terrorists during an anti-terrorist operation near Malabagh, Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 2 July 2020. For his conspicuous bravery, unwavering devotion to duty, and supreme sacrifice, he was posthumously awarded the Shaurya Chakra. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 2s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6367

	2	6		4				
5				1			8	
4	1	3			9	6		
	3		9		5	4		
		4	7		1		6	
		8	4				9	3
7				5				6
			8				2	7

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6366

1	9	7	3	4	6	5	8	2
8	6	2	7	5	9	4	1	3
5	3	4	1	8	2	9	7	6
7	8	6	9	3	4	2	5	1
4	2	1	6	7	5	3	9	8
3	5	9	8	2	1	7	6	4
9	1	5	4	6	3	8	2	7
6	4	8	2	9	7	1	3	5
2	7	3	5	1	8	6	4	9

ROYAL STARS

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Listen to the advice of someone older or more experienced today. It could be to your advantage. This is a good day to make plans for the future. Tonight: Think about goals.

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Today, people will notice you more than usual. However, this also means that some people know personal details about your private life. Be aware of this in case you have to do some damage control. A discussion with a boss will go well. Tonight: Be modest.

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): This is the perfect day to do something different. Shake things up a little. If you can't travel, then be a tourist in your own city, which can be enlightening and fun. Read books, see films and talk to people who can broaden your world. Tonight: Explore.

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): The Sun in your sign, will help any discussions about shared property, taxes, debt or inheritances go in your favour today. Authority figures will help and support your ideas or give you permission. Tonight: Check your finances.

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Today a conversation with a partner, spouse or close friend will focus on practical matters, perhaps related to travel, publishing or legal or medical issues. These discussions will be down to earth and sensible. Learn what you can. Tonight: Schmooze.

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You'll be productive at work or with any task that you set for yourself because you're in a practical frame of mind today. Advice from someone more experienced might help you. Apply this energy to improve your health. Tonight: Get organised.

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): A practical approach to sports, taking care of kids, planning for vacations as well as making art will give you results today. Today your mind is focused. Tonight: Playful socialising.

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Family discussions will be productive today. You might talk to a parent, an older family member or a number of relatives. This could relate to long-range plans for the home or for a family member. Tonight: Relax.

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is the perfect day to learn or study something new as your mind is focused and you will pay attention to detail. Discussions with experienced people will go well. Be patient with spouses and close friends. Tonight: Study.

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): You'll be careful about your spending today. But today you might want to buy long-lasting, practical things, or maintain what you own to preserve or keep their use. An older family member might have advice for you. Tonight: Check your belongings.

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): The Moon in your sign, will give you a slight advantage over other signs. Things will tend to go your way. Discussions with others will be serious and practical. Tonight: You're strong.

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Keep a low profile today. Rest if you can. This is a playful, fun-loving time for you, in addition to which, it's also a productive time because employees and friends are supportive to you. Research will pay off. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

दक्षिणांचल विद्युत वितरण निगम
अधीक्षण अभियन्ता (सांघर्ष-प्रथम), ऊर्जा भवन, सिकन्दरा, आगरा
पत्रांक : 1423/अपी०अपि०(सांघर्ष-1)/आगरा/विज्ञापन/ दिनांक : 30/06/2026
जेच-निविदा सूचना दिनांक :- 30.06.2026

1. GEM/2026/B/7697139, सामग्री Rubberized Cork Sheet (900×600×5 mm.), मात्रा: 2,450 Sheet, Rubberized Cork Sheet (900×600×6 mm.), मात्रा: 2,198 Sheet क्रय किये जाने हेतु, प्रपत्र शुल्क नि-शुल्क, धरोहर राशि: रु० 39,660/-, बिड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 08.07.2026 समय 20:00 बजे तक।

2. GEM/2026/B/7697371, सामग्री Cotton Tape (32 mm.x40 Mtr., मात्रा: 4,084 Roll क्रय किये जाने हेतु प्रपत्र शुल्क नि-शुल्क, धरोहर राशि रु० 1,640/-, बिड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 08.07.2026 समय 13:00 बजे तक।

3. GEM/2026/B/7697450, सामग्री HT Oil Seal (12 mm.), मात्रा: 27,500 Nos., LT Oil Seal (12 mm.), मात्रा: 37,500 Nos., Oil Seal (20 mm.), मात्रा: 1,500 Nos., क्रय किये जाने हेतु, प्रपत्र शुल्क नि-शुल्क, धरोहर राशि रु० 1,200/-, बिड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 08.07.2026 समय 19:00 बजे तक।

4. GEM/2026/B/7697554, सामग्री Iron Strip (19 mm.), मात्रा: 278 Kgs., Iron Lock (20 mm.), मात्रा: 27,500 Nos., Parmacel Tape (25 mm.×25 Mtr.), मात्रा: 7,500 Nos., Rubber Seal (Group Type) 18 mm. Thick×10 mm. Depth, मात्रा: 1,151 Kgs. क्रय किये जाने हेतु प्रपत्र शुल्क नि-शुल्क, धरोहर राशि रु० 11,785/-, बिड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 10.07.2026 समय 13:00 बजे तक।

5. GEM/2026/B/7696873, सामग्री Core Bolt, मात्रा: 5,000 Nos., Aluminium Member, मात्रा: 22,500 Nos., HT Bushing Clamp मात्रा: 5,000 Nos. क्रय किये जाने हेतु प्रपत्र शुल्क नि-शुल्क, धरोहर राशि रु० 3,610/-, बिड अपलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि 08.07.2026 समय 13:00 बजे तक।

विस्तृत जानकारी एवं प्रपत्र वेबसाइट <http://gem.gov.in> पर उपलब्ध है। अग्रेर समस्त सूचनाएं वेबसाइट पर ही प्रदर्शित की जाएगी।

Govt. of Jharkhand
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
Field Survey Division, Advance Planning, Road Construction Department,
Nirupan Bhawan, 4th floor, 56-Set Chowk, Doranda, Ranchi-834002
e-mail— ecerdpsdran-jhr@nic.in

e-Procurement (very Short Tender Notice)
Letter of Invitation (LOI) No.-02/2026-27
National Competitive Bidding (Two Bid System)
2nd Call
e-Tender Ref No.— RCD/FS/DP/ RAN/02/26-27 Dated **29.06.2026**

1	Name Of Work	Consultancy services for preparation of Detailed project report for construction of Cycle-Track, Footpath, Green Verge, Solar Light with Solar roof along the service road on Ring Road Ranchi, in the state of Jharkhand.
2	Tentative Length	40.00 km
3	Period of Completion of Work	30 Days
4	Cost of Tender Document & Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)	Cost of Tender Document :- Rs 10,000/- (Rupees Ten Thousand) (Non-Refundable) through online mode only. EMD :- Rs- 50,000/- (Rupees Fifty thousand) through online mode only. As per the Departmental Letter no.- 4652(S) dated 06.10.2023, cost of tender document and Earnest Money Deposit will be received in online mode only through e-procurement portal (https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in) by Internet banking/ NEFT/ RTGS facility as per Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) issued by Information Technology & e-Governance Department, Government of Jharkhand vide letter no- 120 dated 03.10.2023.
5	Mode of Bid Submission	e-tendering (http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in)
6	Date/ Time of Publication of Tender on Website	02.07.2026, 17:00 PM
7	Last date and Time of submission of Tender (With Tender Fee and EMD)	09.07.2026, not later than 16:00 hrs
8	Date of opening of Bid	10.07.2026 at 16:30 hrs
9	Designation and Contact no. of e Procurement Officer	Executive Engineer, Field Survey Division, Advance Planning, RCD, Ranchi. Mobile No-8051090751

Note-Only e-Tender shall be accepted. Executive Engineer, Field Survey Division,A,P Road Construction Department,Ranchi PR 383641 (Road) 26-27 (D)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Md. Tamir Malik @ Kalli, S/o Feru Malik, R/o N-38/B-52, Jahangirpuri, CD Park, Jahangirpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 48/2020, U/s 457/380 IPC, P.S. Jahangirpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Md. Tamir Malik @ Kalli** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Md. Tamir Malik @ Kalli** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Md. Tamir Malik @ Kalli** accused of **FIR No. 48/2020, U/s 457/380 IPC, P.S. Jahangirpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **19.08.2026**.

By Order - **Sh. Sahil Gupta**
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07, North
DP/8680/NW/2026 Room No. 6, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Rakesh S/o Kanta Prasad R/o G-3/35, Sunder Nagri, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 581/2014 U/s 363 IPC, P.S. Nand Nagri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rakesh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Rakesh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rakesh** of case **FIR No. 581/2014 U/s 363 IPC, P.S. Nand Nagri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Court No. 19, Shahdara District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi
DP/8706/NE/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Rishav @ Rishab S/o Ramesh R/o WP-4P, Pitampura, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 17096/2023 U/s 379/411 IPC, Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Rishav @ Rishab** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rishav @ Rishab** of case **FIR No. 17096/2023 U/s 379/411 IPC, Shahbad Dairy, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
North, Court No. 114, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/8751/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
SEE SECTION 84 BHARTIYA NAGARIK SURKSHA SANHITA

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused Person namely **Krishna S/o Ashok Prajapati R/o Vill. Paddya, PS & Distt: Badaun, Binawar UP,** have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 211/2021 U/s 392/411/34 IPC.,** has been registered at **PS: Kotwali, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Krishna** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Krishna** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused said, **Krishna** of **FIR No. 211/2021 U/s 392/411/34 IPC.,** has been registered at **PS: Kotwali, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Sayesha Chadha
Ld. JMFC-08, Room No. 272
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi
DP/8838/N/2026
(Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Aayush, S/o: Amresh, R/o: M-184, Gali No-7, Near Jeevandan Hospital, Prem Nagar II, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.: 560/25, U/s: 117(2)/118(2)/126(2)/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita 2023, P.S. Aman Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Aayush** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Aayush** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Aayush** of **P.S. Aman Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shagun
JMFC-06, North West, Room No. 109,
Ist Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi
DP/8830/RD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 (2) (ii) Cr. P.C.

Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused persons namely **1.Shivraj Singh Jagrwal S/o Lt. Roop Lal 2.Vikash Jagrwal S/o Shivraj Singh R/o E-3/883, Saheed Nagar, Agra, UP,** have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **CT. Case No. 12805/23, FIR No. 356/2023 U/s 498A/406/34 IPC.,** has been registered at **P.S. Punjabi Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **1.Shivraj Singh Jagrwal 2.Vikash Jagrwal** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **1.Shivraj Singh Jagrwal 2.Vikash Jagrwal** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **1.Shivraj Singh Jagrwal 2.Vikash Jagrwal** of **CT. Case No. 12805/23, FIR No. 356/2023 U/s 498A/406/34 IPC.,** registered at **P.S. Punjabi Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **18.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Shivi Talwar
JMFC (Mahila Court-04), Room No. 358
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi
DP/6580/WD/2026
(Court Notice)

● **RESULTS**

ROUND OF 32

England 2-1 DR Congo
Atlanta Stadium

France 3-0 Sweden
New Jersey Stadium

Mexico 2-0 Ecuador
Mexico City Stadium

● **MATCH SCHEDULE**

ROUND OF 32

USA vs Bosnia and Herzegovina
San Francisco, 5.30 am
(Thursday)

Spain vs Austria
Los Angeles, 12.30 am
(Friday)

Portugal vs Croatia
Toronto, 4.30 am
(Friday)

Switzerland vs Algeria
Vancouver, 8.30 am
(Friday)

ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS



Piero Hincapie was sent off in Ecuador's round of 32 loss. AP

Hincapie second to fall foul of new FIFA regulation

ECUADOR DEFENDER Piero Hincapie became the first player to be red-carded for covering his mouth in a FIFA World Cup knockout match, moments before his side crashed out of the tournament in a 0-2 defeat to Mexico in the Round of 32 match in Mexico City. When Ecuador's substitute Kency Paez was booked with a yellow card for a rash swipe in stoppage time, Hincapie was seen having a go at Mexico's Santiago Gimenez with his mouth covered. After Gimenez appealed to the referee, a VAR decision deemed Hincapie to have violated the newly introduced rule at the World Cup. ENS

Beccacece leaves Ecuador job after defeat to Mexico

SEBASTIAN BECCACECE bid a heartfelt farewell as Ecuador coach following their 2-0 defeat by Mexico on Tuesday, saying he would have liked to continue in the role but failed to deliver on his promises. Despite entering the knockout stage with renewed momentum following a dramatic comeback victory over Germany, Ecuador could not overcome Mexico. "Our contract ended with the World Cup. I don't think we were able to achieve the feat we promised: to make this the best World Cup ever. Today it's my turn to say goodbye," he said after their loss. REUTERS

● LAST CHANCE SALOON

Old man's game: Modric defies time, Ronaldo still in search of one final miracle

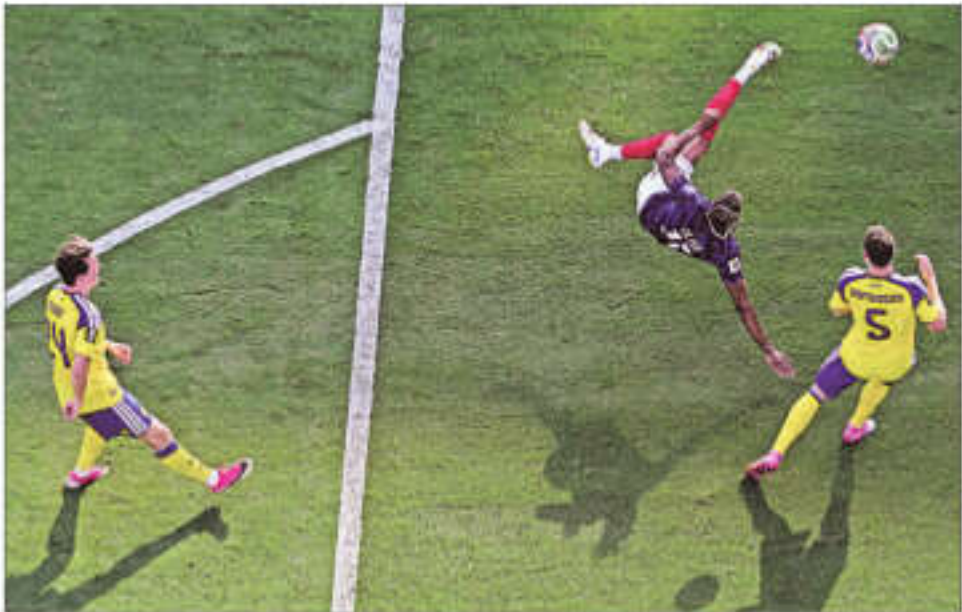
Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 1

BARELY ANYTHING could separate Luka Modric and Cristiano Ronaldo in 2018. They had just won a third consecutive Champions League together at Real Madrid. Modric had then carried Croatia to the World Cup final. Ronaldo, meanwhile, finished the season with 44 club goals.

Football's highest individual honour - the Ballon d'Or - had become a two-man debate. Modric won, before Ronaldo later acknowledged that he deserved it more. Eight years later, there is barely anything left to unite them. They will lead Croatia and Portugal in a Round of 32 tie. Together, they are the oldest outfield players left in the tournament, their combined age stretching to 81. For one of them, in all likelihood, it will also be a final appearance on

SCIENCE AND ART OF FRANCE'S BEAUTIFUL GAME

The frightening part of France's ceaseless waves of attack is the nonchalance with which they come. Metrics of dominance and momentum shifts do not apply to a team which has yet to get out of second gear at the World Cup. Le Bleus average three goals a game with a front four of Ousmane Dembele, Kylian Mbappe, Michael Olise and Bradley Barcola while being 44th out of 48 teams when it comes to distance run per game. Their conquests have come with minimum effort. Against Sweden, the quartet gobbled up a knockout game at a World Cup as more of a test drive than a high-stakes match which could have dire consequences.



Michael Olise attempts a sideways bicycle kick. AP

18TH MINUTE: Barcola unleashes the first real French shot, one that flies over the bar. But the run that started on the left wing, sneaking its way to the centre, followed by a deft drop of a shoulder to flummox two Swedish guards, and the left-footer that was the precursor to what was about to happen for the rest of the match. Barcola is the incisive knife that cuts teams in half.

19TH MINUTE: France had the ball in the net before the goal was ruled out as offside by the margin of half a body. In a crowded midfield, Olise pounces on a misplaced pass and within microseconds, finds Mbappe. The French captain's first few steps accelerated him away

from the Swedish backline. He has more than enough time to pull the revs back a bit, compose himself and give France what seemed like their opener. But VAR wipes the slate clean.

31ST MINUTE: France rattle the post. Jules Kounde plays right-back for the French but has the freedom to move in centrally. Dembele slips a pass to Kounde, who is nestled well inside the Swedish box. He drives the ball through the middle of the penalty area to find Mbappe, whose low side-footed shot rattles the post.

34TH MINUTE: The post would come into play again minutes later. Olise lets us into his mind. Rabiot looks for Barcola in the box, but the



Kylian Mbappe finally opens the scoring in the 44th minute. AP

Swedes have a chance to clear their lines. But the ball loops up in the air and Olise finds himself underneath it at the edge of the box with his back to goal. Most players would bring the ball down and then shoot, or pass. Olise instead goes for the ridiculous. An almost sideways bicycle kick, one which connects with the shin but is direct goalwards. But Sweden's post performs a rescue act again and denies what would have undeniably been hung in the World Cup gallery of great goals.

FINALLY...

44TH MINUTE: On the verge of half-time, what seemed inevitable happened. It was never a question of if, but rather of when, and

Mbappe is the protagonist. When supplied a pass by Dembele into the box with traffic in front of him, Mbappe slid the ball to his right and dropped Viktor Gyokeres first. Then Yasin Ayari puts a foot in and there is still Gustaf Lagerbielke and Zetterstrom to beat, but the French captain curls the ball from a tight space into the far corner and Sweden, who had been wobbling for all of the first half, take a body blow.

52ND MINUTE: Barcola gets on the scoresheet, but it's Olise the provider who delights. None of his five World Cup assists have been banal. He receives the ball while running towards goal, moves it to his left and mid-stride, slides the



Bradley Barcola gets on the scoresheet courtesy an Olise assist. AP

ball between the legs of Lagerbielke, into Barcola's path. The finish is elementary, the genius behind the pass is exquisite.

73RD MINUTE: France's third is the result of Olise's best assist of the game. Barcola, on the left, finds his quarterback, who lets the ball pass by him to the right and shifts a terrorised Swedish block in the direction of the ball. He then halts it all - the box and the players in front - goes to the left, cuts in and threads yet another needle. The impact of Olise can be gauged by how the Swedish block reacts to every move of his. They instantly go into damage control but the London-born player still has his way. Mbappe, always in the

search of goals, has now found himself a provider of the ilk of Paul Pogba and converted his sixth goal of the tournament to go level with Lionel Messi.

81ST MINUTE: Barcola tries to get his second of the game. He cuts in from the right and just as two Swedish defenders fear a shot is about to be unleashed, the PSG winger swipes their ankles from underneath them and takes the ball to his left. A poor subsequent touch prevented what could have been France's fourth but that relentless drive to breach a Sweden backline that had given up eons ago is the warning shot that every top team left at this World Cup will be looking at with concern.

LEADING FROM THE FRONT

Kane is able: Captain saves England's blushes with brace

Striker breaks Congo resistance with two second-half goals after an early deficit had made a huge upset a real possibility



Sandip G
New York, July 1

AN INSPIRED Harry Kane wrote himself into history books and the hearts of England fans forever with a pair of goals that denied what could have been one of the greatest World Cup upsets of all time.

His strikes, in the space of 11 minutes, consigned the Democratic Republic of the Congo, leading the game for 69 minutes, to pure despair. As England wheeled away in celebration, Congo's brave men - who defied a footballing powerhouse for most of the game - broke down inconsolably.

But the World Cup wouldn't forget their courage. It took one of the most lethal strikers in the world, a man inspired in the second half, a loveable man who has suffered heartbreaks in three major tournaments (World Cup and Euros), to deny them a slice of history.

Those were goals that Kane scored with his will, the technique and vision just the complementing tools. The winner could become an iconic moment in English football.

Catching his breath after the match, unable to recollect the

events, Kane said; "We have hero moments, for me it was today."

When he picked the ball on the edge of Congo's box, his back was facing the goalkeeper. Men in shimmering blue converged. He escaped them, turned languidly and paced to his left, before he swivelled and flashed a rising shot past Lionel Mpasi, the guardian of Congo who had kept them in the game with a string of reflex saves. It was a cruel end to Congo's resistance, but Kane didn't want a crueler end for himself.

He could have imagined the public fury back home, the media-scavenging, the end of careers and multiple sackings, the disillusionment and dismantling of the team. But England would croon thankfully: "It was Kane that saved the King." When all his colleagues looked lost and lumbering, running on fumes, Kane alone showed up, lifting his troops in an individual performance that would elevate him to the pedestal of England's greatest. England's captains are associated with tragic flaws and combustibility in clutch moments. Kane was mocked for the lack of trophies in his shelf, for the supposedly poor choices when joining clubs. Not that England loved him less, but they would love him even more now.

His first goal was not as aesthetic as the second, but as significant. Just 15 minutes were left in the game, when Kane



Harry Kane (L) scored both of England's goals in their nervy 2-1 win over DR Congo. AP

sprung higher than the circle of blue men around him, and headed the ball past the leaping, the hitherto infallible Mpasi. The Congolese goalkeeper almost clawed it away, but the power and direction was irresistible. Congo's 70 minutes of pure, glorious resistance ended cruelly.

Kane screeched and gestured to the audience, largely muted and bereft of hope, to bring the roof down. England's fans pulsed, transforming the arena in Atlanta to Wembley or Old Trafford. Their hope was treading on thin ice, dripping away with every moment. Then came the captain's moment, and then came another.

Escape to victory

But how awry it could have all gone. In fixating over breaking Congo's defensive wall, England forgot their own

chores. Just six minutes had passed when their worst nightmare unfolded. Poor Djed Spence - a fourth-choice right-back as Reece James, Tino Livramento and Jarell Quansah were all injured for the match - misjudged the trajectory, and sheepishly watched the ball float over him. Waiting for the lapse was Brian Cipenga, unmarked and lonely in the box. He took a touch to let the surprise gift sink in. The next second, he pulled the levers past a bemused Jordan Pickford.

The England backline was as disorganised as a bunch of kids unleashed in a park. The dynamism of Congo's forwards surprised, and they were unequipped to deal with their directness, more than speed. It was not merely a test of character and skills, but belief.

England turned off the hand-break, with Declan Rice

putting up an inspired show. He stoked a killer pass for Jude Bellingham, but Mpasi pulled out a quicksilver save.

Shortly, Axel Tuanzebe produced a stout block to divert Kane's shy. The rebound fell invitingly into Rashford's path, only to watch his former Manchester United teammate Aaron Wan-Bissaka clear it off the goal-line.

Mpasi made another save off a powerful, low header from Bellingham, by springing to his left. He made another save at the stroke of half-time, his sturdy legs rebounding Kane's volley from six yards. He made a double save seven minutes into the second half as well.

The game thereafter was played entirely in Congo's half. England had to breach three lines of blue walls. It took a super-willed man and an ice-cold forward to break it.

{ SIDELINES }



VAR intervened to rule out Jonathan Tah's extra-time header. AP

FIFA justifies ruling out Germany's extra-time 'goal'

FIFA HAS explained the referee's decision to chalk off Germany's headed strike in their Round of 32 match against Paraguay. On Monday with the scores tied at 1-1, German defender Jonathan Tah's header in extra time was ruled out after a VAR review for a foul on keeper Orlando Gill. Replays showed Germany's Waldemar Anton push Gill to the ground, but the minimal contact led to criticism of the decision. Germany would subse-

quently shoot out in a penalty shootout. "Although keeping a position is not a foul per se, when an attacking player is not interested in the ball and deliberately moves, even marginally, with the clear intention of obstructing opponents' movement and prevents him from defending, then referees, and VAR when needed, should carefully analyze the incident and intervene," FIFA's referees chief Pierluigi Colina said. ENS

Bielsa says no one in Uruguay followed him

OUTGOING URUGUAY coach Marcelo Bielsa said that no one was interested in following what he transmitted during the World Cup. The two-time champions had a horrid tournament, failing to clear their group which had Spain, Saudi Arabia and debutants Cape Verde. "Nothing I tried to transmit was important, at any level," Bielsa said in his farewell press conference. ENS

Fans warned of severe heat for Portugal-Croatia

FANS HEADING to watch Portugal play Croatia in Toronto are being warned to keep hydrated and limit their alcohol intake after a heat warning issued by Environment Canada. "Don't wait till you're thirsty, keep drinking water through the day, try to moderate your alcohol intake, certainly alcohol can be more dehydrating," the City of Toronto's medical officer of health Michelle Murti said. REUTERS

● Stark contrast in the veterans' performance

Metric	LUKA MODRIC (RANK IN CROATIA)	CRISTIANO RONALDO (RANK IN PORTUGAL)
Chances created	5 (1st)	0 (last)
Passes/90	71.7 (1st)	19.4 (13th)
Line breaks attempted	61 (2nd)	11 (12th)
Distance covered/90	9.23 km (11th)	7.56 km (12th)
Distance covered at high speed	3.25 km (6th)	2.19 km (9th)

and distance covered in high speed (3.25 km) are both higher than that of Ronaldo (5 km/hr and 2.19 km, respectively).

An even bigger indicator is the contrast in performance between this World Cup to that in 2022. Despite being four years older, Modric is covering 770 metres more per match than he did in Qatar, while moving 0.7 km/h faster on average. Ronaldo has gone the other way. He is covering 1.5

kilometres less per game than four years ago, while his average speed has fallen by almost a kilometre per hour.

Save for two goals against debutants Uzbekistan, Ronaldo has very little to show for. Modric, despite not being on the scoresheet, has undisputedly been his team's most efficacious figure. Every metric shares a common inference - Modric has been among the most involved players in his

team. Ronaldo has been among the least. And yet, football has never cared much for statistical consensus.

Modric knows that better than anyone. For six seasons, his first instinct after receiving the ball was almost subconscious: when in doubt, find Cristiano Ronaldo. For six seasons, he has known only this much to be true: Ronaldo will save you. In Toronto, Ronaldo needs to save himself first. From the ineluctability of age, the inevitability of time. His contemporary, Lionel Messi, continues to defy it. Behind him surge football's next era - Kylian Mbappe, Erling Haaland, Vinicius Junior. Ronaldo, once the benchmark against which every superstar was measured, no longer sits naturally among them.

Should Portugal aspire to stay alive, their captain has to step up. Be it at the cost of his friend.



Luka Modric (left) and Cristiano Ronaldo are the oldest outfield players in the tournament. REUTERS/AP



you desire to find Ronaldo's corresponding figures in Portugal's metrics, save a few seconds by starting from the bottom. He has played every second of Portugal's campaign and is yet to create a single chance. With 19.4 passes per 90 minutes, Ronaldo ranks lower than goalkeeper

Diogo Costa. Ronaldo has completed just 65 passes in 300 minutes - only four fewer than Modric managed in the Panama match alone.

Modric also leads in terms of physicality - an aspect Ronaldo has always taken pride in. His average speed (6.2 km/hr)

NATIONAL TREASURE

Once a target of racists chants, Quiñones turns hero for Mexico

Colombia-born forward was nearly forced to join a guerrilla group; Now he is the toast of Mexico after Round of 32 goal

Sandip G
New York, July 1

THE DELIRIOUS Azteca crowd chanted “Quiñones, Quiñones...” They showered beer and flung cardboard sombreros at their newfound object of affection, Julian Quiñones.

The forward, drenching in the adulation after putting Mexico in front before setting up the second in the Ecuador rout, asked them to amplify the volume. The chant must have been music to his ears, for two years ago, the Mexican city of Guadalajara had shouted his name too, but with racial slurs prefixed.

He is a Colombian by birth, his parents of Afro-Colombian ancestry. He became a naturalised Mexican citizen in 2023 but the past clung on. He knows he has to prove that he is Mexican every time he steps onto the field; he knows he will be judged by his race and origins when he fails. So, he ensures that he gives little chance for them to dig up his past. He scored the first goal of the World Cup, a devilish strike against South Africa; in the round-of-16 encounter against the sturdily-defending Ecuadorians, he pinched a goal that blended blinding pace, technical purity and savage beauty.

He was strolling on the left, when Jesus Gallardo snatched the ball from Ecuador. Quiñones, sensing a pass, set off, ensured that he beat the off-side trap, gathered the ball, cut inside into the box, dummied right-back Alan Franco and threw the proverbial kitchen sink at the ball. He intentionally did not impart any spin, lest the revolutions take the ball over the crossbar. He chose pure power and precision. Straightaway, he kissed the badge, displaying to the world how much he loves it. “Representing my country is the most important thing, and I give everything in training to make that happen,” he had once said.

The slicker piece of work had to wait. Ten minutes on, Raul Jimenez latched onto Joel Ordóñez's scuffed clearance and passed to Quiñones. Franco again converged onto him. He paused, let him snap his leg and nonchalantly bunted the ball into Jimenez's path. The striker did not falter, and immediately after the celebrations, rose from the ground and kissed the assist provider.

At 29, an obscure Colombia-born forward was fuelling Mexico's dreams. Not only does he



Julian Quiñones became a naturalised Mexican citizen only three years ago and scored against Ecuador in the Round of 32. AP

contribute with goals but also brings fight and energy. Goals to him are secondary, winning the ball is primary, he had said after the South Africa game.

Saudi connection

Last season, playing for Al Qadsiah in the Saudi Pro League, Quiñones stumped Cristiano Ronaldo and Ivan Toney to lead the goalscoring charts (33 goals, besides four assists). His first season had earned him 25 goals as well. He was raised in Magui Payan, a town located in southern Colombia battered by violence and armed conflict. A guerrilla group nearly forced him to join them. His father left the family when he was a toddler. Football was his escape. His mother, who worked in a store, couldn't afford a pair of football boots. So he spent most of his childhood playing football barefoot.

In 2014, Quiñones attended a trial for Fútbol Paz, an academy scouting for talented players from across Colombia. He cleared it and two years later, caught the eyes of Mexican club Tigres UANL.

He consistently hit double digits in scoring charts but couldn't hide the colour of his skin in a country that proclaims it has no race.

He chose to suffer in silence; he locked himself out of social media and quietly slipped into the moneyed shores of Saudi. But his allegiance to Mexico never wavered, and when manager Javier Aguirre summoned him to the national team, he had no second thoughts.

Valencia calls him lion, “because he always attacked the goal”, though his teammates called him panther. At Azteca, he roared like a lion, and kept proving his loyalty to his adopted country with deeds. And how musical it would have been for him to hear the spectators chant his name, through a night of celebrations, without racial prefixes.

Mora: The Mexican Wonderkid

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, July 1

TWENTY-THREE years ago, on the last matchday of a relegation battle in Chiapas, a journeyman midfielder named Gilberto Mora Olayo did something that had nothing to do with talent and everything to do with will. Jaguares needed a win over Tecos to survive in Mexico's top flight. A free kick came up, and the regular taker had already put one off the crossbar. Mora walked over anyway, argued him out of it, and struck it into the top corner. Jaguares stayed up 1-0, the single thing anyone in Chiapas football remembers him for.

Five years later, in that same city, during his father's six years at Jaguares, his son was born. The boy grew up on a dirt pitch called Salvador Cabanas, joining the Jaguares youth school at four with his father as one of its coaches. The family moved to Tijuana at seven, but little changed: his father stayed his coach, and Mora kept doing the impossible, youngest to debut for Club Tijuana, then Mexico's senior team, then the youngest of any nationality to win a senior international trophy, at the 2025 Gold Cup. He is known as Morita. Antonio Rodriguez, now Tijuana's captain, remembers a training drill where the ball arrived at a boy he didn't recognise: one touch, a turn, the defender gone. “Me dejo en shock” [“It left me in shock”], he said.

The records are the least interesting thing about him. Santiago Gimenez, Mexico's senior striker, described a team bus during last year's Gold Cup: everyone on their phones, and then Mora, reading a book. “That's when I thought, this guy is different,” Gimenez said. Asked, half-joking, how he'd celebrate if Mexico won it all, he said, “Yeah, an ice cream. Vanilla.”



17-year-old Gilberto Mora (L) in action in Round of 32. AP

He is seventeen, still studying for university entrance while Europe's clubs prize what he might be worth.

Rodriguez put it another way: “He hasn't gotten dizzy, hasn't been distracted by what's said about him. He's still the same.”

World stage

At this World Cup, Mora played a brief cameo against South Africa, then nothing against South Korea. Mexico had already won the group, but Aguirre started him anyway against Czechia. Mora was slow for a half, then wasn't: a shimmy that opened a chance somebody else missed, then the pass that split Czechia's defence for Mexico's second. He left the pitch late to a standing ovation, in the same match that brought on Guillermo Ochoa, forty and at his sixth World Cup, for a farewell cameo. Neither man mentioned the other. The stadium did the connecting for them.

Four days later, against Ecuador, Aguirre started him again. Mexico won 2-0. Mora became the second-youngest

player in World Cup history to start a knockout match, behind Pele. There is one part of this story Mexican football would rather not look at too closely. Asked last year whether he felt more tijuanaense (a Tijuana native) or chiapaneco (a Chiapas native), Mora didn't hesitate: “Mas tijuanaense ya” [“More Tijuana than anything, by now”], ten years into living there by then. It cost him something at home. Chiapas social media called it a betrayal: some felt written out of his story in five words. One columnist named the uncomfortable part outright: Mexico claims Chiapas once a Chiapaneco succeeds elsewhere, and is less interested in why its most gifted children keep having to leave to do it. Mora's dream is Real Madrid, which has scouted him at the Azteca. He can't move until October, when he turns eighteen.

Twenty-three years before any of this, his father stayed behind after training, alone, two or three evenings a week, and practised that same free kick over and over on an empty pitch, for no one.



(Left) Messi's statue in Cutral Co was unveiled before the opening match of the 2026 FIFA World Cup; Aldo Beroisa sculpting the head of the statue (right). SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Marvel in Desert’ Argentina's new Messi towers 15 feet over Kolkata's

Tanishq Vaddi
Hyderabad, July 1

THERE WAS a 70-foot Messi in Kolkata. It came down on June 1, dismantled after authorities ruled it unsafe, swaying too much in the wind to be trusted standing. A few weeks later, in a Patagonian oil town in Argentina, a taller one went up in its place.

Aldo Beroisa's sculpture stands 85 feet in Cutral Co, unveiled on June 16 to mark Argentina's World Cup opener. It depicts Messi on his knees at Lusail Stadium, the moment after Argentina's shootout win in the 2022 final, one hand clutching the national jersey, the other pointing to the sky in the gesture he makes for his late grandmother. Beroisa, 61, has built giant dinosaurs before, and monuments to Argentina's independence heroes. Nothing he had made had drawn this kind of attention.

He was asked about Kolkata's statue, and its reception, before his own went up. “I believe every artist has the full freedom to express themselves through their work. Every perspective deserves respect,” he told *The Indian Express*. “Messi is deeply admired and loved in India,” he adds. “As Argentines, we feel immense pride and gratitude that a figure from our country inspires such affection and admiration in such a distant place.”

Statue in desert

Cutral Co sits in the Patagonian steppe, the eighth-largest desert on the planet, boxed in by the Andes on one side and the Atlantic's dying moisture on the other.

“Access to water is a challenge,” Beroisa says. “Carrying out a work of this magnitude

under such conditions made the project even more meaningful.”

The Sports Secretary of the Cutral Co Municipality gave him 18 months to design and build it. The statue eventually used around 70 tons of steel, along with rebar and three-grade concrete mortar.

110 structural tubes

“Approximately 110 structural tubes were employed, enabling the creation of a large-scale, highly durable work,” Beroisa says.

Most of the eighteen months went into the face. “The face was undoubtedly the most complex part of the process,” Beroisa says. “For months, I studied videos and photographs from various angles to capture a likeness that truly reflected his essence.” The dimensions alone explain why. “The subject is a contemporary figure of immense global significance; capturing a true likeness carries a heavy responsibility,” he says.

“Messi's head stands 4.30 meters tall and weighs approximately four tons. I dedicated nearly three months exclusively to its creation, striving for the highest possible level of detail.” “From the start, I was aware of the project's magnitude and the challenge it posed,” he says. “Without a doubt, I consider it a very important work.”

Asked why he took the commission at all, his answer was: “Lionel Messi, a man who, through his humility, hard work and dedication, gave us one of the greatest moments of joy in our country's history.”

The desert had the final say in the design. Guests here run 60 to 80 kmph on an ordinary day and touch 150 in a bad

Aldo Beroisa's sculpture stands 85 feet in Cutral Co, unveiled on June 16 to mark Argentina's World Cup opener. It depicts Messi on his knees at Lusail Stadium

one. Beroisa's original plan had Messi holding the trophy aloft in one hand.

“The original idea was never to place the World Cup trophy between the sculpture's legs,” Beroisa says. “The design called for it to be held in one of the hands. However, during the project's development, engineering calculations determined that doing so would be unsafe.”

At nearly four metres tall itself, the trophy in a raised hand was never going to hold against wind that strong. So it came down to where physics put it, level with Messi's knees, and stayed there. It is the one part of the statue that draws a laugh before it draws anything else, and the reaction on social media hasn't surprised Beroisa much. What he wants for the statue goes past the joke and past the record. “We hope this sculpture transcends the local level and becomes a work of national significance,” he says.

The statue still needs finishing touches, though it has already outlasted its predecessor by simply staying up. In Cutral Co, that was never guaranteed. The wind saw to the trophy's placement first, and everything else, water, steel, eighteen months of a sculptor's attention, had to answer to the same desert before Messi could stand at all.

With Serb coach & a bronze, Indian volleyball is looking up

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 1

SOMETHING DRAGGED India's Serbian volleyball coach Dragan Mihailovic back to India for a second stint - and it wasn't desi food. “No, No, No way. Indian food absolutely not. No kurma or curry for me. It's too spicy. They still make bland Western style food for me at the sports hostel in Bengaluru,” the 68-year-old clarifies, feeling no compulsion to please his Indian hosts.

“Maybe, it's watching the Indian team win and how the Ahmedabad crowd appreciated them. There's a word in Greek, Serbian or French for that Indian hospitality, the warmth...” he trails off, explaining why he took on the herculean task of rousing Indian volleyball from its slumber.

Mihailovic wants to help - if they would only allow him.

This last week, India's volleyball team strung together five wins against New Zealand, Kazakhstan, Taiwan, Australia and Bahrain at the AVC Nations Cup

and finished with a bronze medal in front of 8,000 Ahmedabad fans, who fell in love with the sport. They qualified for the 12-team AVC Continental Cup in September, and are eligible as Asia's seventh-ranked team to be sent to the Asian Games, though they're waiting nervously on the sports ministry's go-ahead. Asia's top teams, Japan, Iran and China were absent in Ahmedabad, and will turn up at Fukuoka, Japan for the Continental Cup. Indonesia defeated India in five sets in the semis, and Mihailovic is drawing up elaborate plans for “revenge”, come September.

Bureaucratic hurdles

But these plans start with polite, bureaucratic “Dear Sirs”, in review report mails of the Ahmedabad meet and training proposals for the coming months, sent to officialdom. Making a hundred calls, so his team gets clearances for camps and the Asiad, keeps him busy. It's mind-numbing, necessary paperwork that needs doing - but it was one of the reasons



Dragan Mihailovic guided India to a bronze medal at the AVC Continental Cup in front of 8,000 fans in Ahmedabad. CREIMAS/BCCI

why the Serb left a cushy Hong Kong gig and marched back to India despite several hurdles during his first stint in 2019. He doesn't wish to bicker with federation officials, he is clear. “The 24 players in the team are the priority. There should be no doubt that they have talent, and work hard. And India can really get very good at this sport,” he pleads. Winners Indonesia have an

evolved league where top foreign names from Italy, Serbia and Poland play and help raise their level, and they won the Asian club championship. Losing to them narrowly in the fifth set was no shame for Indians exposed to the domestic Prime Volleyball League.

Work to do

Mihailovic would also prefer if he gets a nine-week training

block - an official camp to train the Indian team to level up on speed, efficiency, precision and quality of reception.

He has roped in a performance analyst and a strength and conditioning coach from Italy who's worked with the best in Europe, besides Indian coaching assistants.

“It's like starting a revolution,” says the Serb. He has technically improved serves and receptions in the 10 days he got with the team. But his superpower is patience, and knowing things don't move as quickly here as they do in Hong Kong.

“I might look young but I've been a player and coach for 50 years now, so I'm actually old,” he jokes, adding that he returned to India very reluctantly, but knowing well that he had to, because India spikers were hard-working blokes who needed guidance to develop the physicality of “huge Kazakh guys”, from “technical precision style of Japan” and learn to tackle both. Word has it that the world body FIVB knew any other coach would run away from

India in 2-3 weeks, so Mihailovic was persuaded to return. So far he has been pleasantly surprised with the steering committee running the game, and how officials and players cooperating can yield immediate results, like in Ahmedabad.

“There is talent. Just give us a chance, you'll see. Last week, Ahmedabad fans made everything special,” he says.

The week had started with some blunt words to his charges. “I told them we absolutely need a medal. Nobody will care about volleyball if you finish fourth, nobody will invest. It's a good group, but we need support,” he reiterates.

Captain C Jerome Vinith dropped out of engineering to pursue volleyball. Anand Kottarathil followed in his father's footsteps, becoming a libero at Kannur, and John Joseph gave up on javelin to switch to volleyball. Their coach moved countries knowing his boys would move mountains if he asked, just to get better at volleyball. In Ahmedabad, all sacrifices were worth it.

Sinner defeats Borges to reach Rd 3 at Wimbledon

Reuters
London, July 1

DEFENDING WIMBLEDON champion Jannik Sinner had several members of Europe's Ryder Cup team watching his second-round clash with Nuno Borges on Wednesday and in golfing parlance he kept it straight down the middle in a relatively risk-free victory.

After the hazards he found against Serbia's Miomir Kecmanovic in a nervy five-set victory in round one, top seed Sinner rarely looked in danger as he won 7-6(4) 7-6(2) 6-4.

World number 48 Borges provided stubborn resistance and was a point away from taking the second set, but Sinner was rock-solid when it mattered as he avoided another long contest. Sinner, the hot favourite in the absence of injured chief rival Carlos Alcaraz, failed to convert any of the three break points he earned in the opening set but stepped on the throttle in the tiebreak to take the

opener. He strayed off course at the start of the second set and sprayed a forehand long to drop his serve.

Portugal's Borges stayed ahead throughout the set, but serving at 5-4 he buried a routine backhand into the net on set point and paid the price as Sinner broke back and then reeled off six points in a row to win the second tiebreak of the match. Sinner dominated thereafter to rack up an Italian record 95th Grand Slam match win, moving ahead of Nicola Pietrangeli.

The 24-year-old said his level of tennis was on the up after arriving at Wimbledon without having played a competitive match since his shock defeat by Juan Manuel Cerundolo in the second round of the French Open, when he suffered physically in searing temperatures. “Two wins now and we'll see what's coming next,” Sinner said. “A couple of things to improve but I'm very happy,” the Italian added further.